

THEORY ON DEMAND

**HEAVEN'S
DELIGHT
ON THE PLEASURES
OF AUDIOVISUAL
PRACTICES**
BY ANDREAS TRESKE

**THEORY
ON
DEMAND**

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OF AUDIOVISUAL
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ANDREAS TRESKE

COLOPHON

Theory on Demand #57

Heaven's Delight: On The Pleasures of Audiovisual Practices

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Many thanks to Will Day for looking over my notes and fragmented writing.

Thanks also to Melih Aydınat for processing my images.

This text is dedicated to the memory of Ingo Florian Schiller, who always asked me *how did you mean that*, and made me listen to the newest electronic music records.

Dem Staub, dem beweglichen, eingezeichnet.

Benjamin & Goethe

LOG:: IN

Provide a username and a password

What am I currently working on? An approximation of where I arrived after working with video for more than two-thirds of my life?

I thought of a personal opening.

My aim or urge is to discuss the aesthetics and practice of video today. But I see myself only preparing a sketch, an approximation: scattering seeds in combining notes and logs. What is the urge?

Video is not simply video. There is Reels, TikTok, platforms, streaming, YouTube and FaceTime, Netflix, Disney, Amazon, MUBI, Gain and BlueTV, ultra-short, limited series, one-minute Turkish vertical soap operas, Chinese ultra shorts, scrolling feeds, camera roll, drones, social and surveillance, Face Recognition, let alone TV and cinema. Or Video AI.

Things look at me. This is a fact. We are changing.

At the 2024 IDFA Documentary Film Festival in Amsterdam, in a conversation on stage, the Romanian filmmaker Radu Jude pointed out that filmmakers need to finally ‘start taking TikTok seriously. To me, TikTok is like the beginning of cinema. It’s like Lumière. Filmmakers are in trouble because this is ahead of us. If you are serious about filmmaking, you have to be serious about [TikTok]’.¹

Producers face Influencers, and Influencers face creators—another economy of video powered by algorithms, large language models and micro-fragmentation. Videos created and edited with texts and effects to stand out and sparkle in the audiovisual ocean, the never-ending expanding universe, ready for monetization with ads and subscriptions, community-forming live events and streaming, many to many, mum and dad, and friends of friends with on-demand video analytics, privacy and access management in a streamlined workflow.

What are we doing? Prompting. Video generators and their promoters, in great numbers by the end of 2024, highlight ‘*a panda riding the subway, an alien smoking a cigarette, a paper boat navigating a stormy sea, and a golden statue winking at you.*’² Eye catching. Is this it?

1 Rafa Sales Ross. Radu Jude Discusses How Andy Warhol Film Began as a ‘Joke,’ Says Filmmakers Need to Be ‘Serious About TikTok’. 16 November 2024, <https://variety.com/2024/film/news/radu-jude-andy-warhol-tiktok-idfa-1236212109/>.

2 Alex Kantrowitz, What Is Sora For? Commentary, The Wrap, 13 December 2024, <https://www.thewrap.com/what-is-sora-for-commentary/?utm>.

People started to complain that the latest smartphones, like Apple's iPhone 16 in 2024, produce images that are far too detailed and 'clinical'. Weren't the early HTC and BlackBerry Curve phones better with their 'organic' video quality?

The retro-analogue boom continues. Netflix tries sending out VHS tapes, and Spotify offers audio cassettes as an alternative to streaming. Both are soon hit by an avalanche of complaints from younger users, unfamiliar with the concept of rewinding, who protest that the tapes will only play once.³

In December 2024, it's not just nostalgia and crystal clear imagery. With all this video around, life itself is already a movie. We are the main characters, the leading actors in our movies. Video culture causes us to view ourselves in the third person. Platform strategies support a feeling of 'life-as-a-movie' for users.⁴

Being constantly observed and constantly observing others, observing everything and anything, generates a feeling of dissociation. We are standing outside, controlling, directing, designing, and writing the script for our activities, documented through our endless video productions.

Life as a theater actualized as life as a movie, begging for audiences. Worlds are built around main characters, plots, and aura. Terminologies are popularized on social media platforms—the fictionalization of daily life through platform design, For-You-Pages, Algorithms, likes and click-counting, for massive, mediocre content creation.⁵

The creator economy produces video as a mass product at incredible speeds, making more people see a single video clip than any cultural product of cinema ever at the classic box-office. We are beyond Andy Warhol's claim that everyone will be famous for 10 minutes. Seconds make smiles for more seconds to come.

Instability.

Rewind ;-)

I call *video* moving images and all kinds of *audiovisual* material. *Film* is the old fashion *moving pictures*—the *photoplay*. *Moving images* is, as terminology, paradoxically static. It implies image definitions that very well needed to overrule if not pointed to wooden frames and glued to walls. Stick it! Tag it!

3 Roland Denning, Olde Denning's Almanak - Film & Video in 2024, 31 December 2023, <https://www.redsharknews.com/olde-dennings-almanak-film-video-in-2024>.

4 Eugene Healey on TikTok, <https://www.tiktok.com/@eugbrandstrat/video/7413940436177341704>, accessed 12 March 2025.

5 Vincent Foerst, Trugbild: Die unendliche Inszenierung, 1 December 2024, <https://netzpolitik.org/2024/trugbild-die-unendliche-inszenierung/?via=nl> 8.12.2024, 08:19.

Godard, in his early film years, left visual clues referencing art on the walls of his films' internal scenery—a photo here, a postcard there in the spaces of living of his main characters. Volker Pantenburg wrote about this in one of the best books on cinema in the 2000s.⁶

Because moving images are no longer necessarily pictures, but also because images are more constructs of multiples, *video* remains, as a term, dynamic; it references movement and energy. Video is online, networked and expanded—light in movement.

•

This essay is a compilation of notes and logs—a log book. These logs are entries in a literal sense—each is an entry point, and one can jump from one entry to another. Logs are fragments, pieces of an assemblage. They can be montaged to each other, *assembled*, in many different combinations and orders.

I traverse the field of aesthetics, pointing towards a status of instability with pleasure. The essay's text will travel many paths; some might not seem to converge, and fragments may feel floating, but I will try to clarify the connections as best as I can at this moment of writing. I hope to open some doors to further in-depth investigations, discussions and studies.

This essay's epigraph, a line from Goethe's poem *West-Eastern Divan*, references a mode of writing that is more ephemeral, spontaneous, instantaneous, inspirational, and imaginative, rather than certain traditional theoretical or *frozen* reflections of storage media forms marked by hierarchical orders of the literary, by defined, well-known rhythms, academic or artistic. It aims to deliver intensity and to preserve the fleeting aspects of the mediated things in passage.

Pictures, not letters, are drawn in the sand or dust, and with a wood stick, generating a blurred visibility that transcends time. It is the energy of the writing that creates an electrifying, long-distance effect. An inscription in a place makes the passage significant.

'Each particle of dust carries a unique vision of matter, movement, collectivity, interaction, affect, differentiation, composition, and infinite darkness'.⁷ Dusty books on shelves, manuscripts in archives recalling fairy tales, deserted places, attics, and dunes.⁸ The house of Gaston Bachelard,⁹ the museum of Orhan Pamuk,¹⁰ and the predictions of Italo Calvino¹¹ crystalize in the invisible dream-like sphere of imagination.

I am looking at what makes the dust move.

6 Volker Pantenburg, Farocki/Godard: Film as Theory, Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press 2015, DOI: <https://doi.org/10.25969/mediarep/3558>.

7 Reza Negarestani, Cyclonopedia: Complicity with Anonymous Materials, re.press, 2008.

8 Jussi Parikka, *Dust and Exhaustion, The Labor of Media Materialism @ C-Theory (Theory beyond the codes)*, 4 October 2013.

9 Gaston Bachelard, *The Poetics of Space*, Boston: Beacon Press, 1969.

10 Orhan Pamuk, *Masumiyet Müzesi*, 1. baskı ed. İstanbul: İletişim Yayınlar., 2008.

11 C. R. Frisch and Italo Calvino, *Six Memos for the Next Millennium*, New York, 1988.

The German term *Anschauung* might convey the meaning of looking at - looking at something. *Anschauung* or *Betrachtung* generates a reflective environment of more depth. There is something to look at, but not just a quick look; it is a look unfolding over time and descriptively, from the details to the totality of the phenomenon or the thing, but to more than the idea. *Anschauung* emphasizes the process of looking towards or at the thing of interest. It is the act. It is action and practice.

But what is it that makes the dust move? I see light.

Kazimir records with his camera and then watches his videos. He says this is the way he sees it. The first YouTube video was *Me at the Zoo*¹² That was 2005.

Yoghurt Boxes

About forty years ago, the idea of an at-home information processing machine grew out of a garage; so goes the legend. Apple was born and made lots of money by selling plastic boxes, which a Turkish friend of mine smilingly called *Yoghurt Boxes* cause of the similarity between the Macintosh and boxes used for yoghurt in the early 80s in Turkiye.

Around this time, Yoghurt-box-time, two other guys discovered that you could sell long rows of code, strings of ones and zeros, rather than boxes with electronics. Microsoft's operating system for personal computers came on a disk and gave us the ability to manipulate, at home, all the box's strings of ones and zeros.¹³

The machines and their operating systems got more and more complex but also compressed, flattened, and merged with other machines and digital tools to communicate, record, and reproduce images and sounds, movies and television, all coded and algorithmically processed data, culminating in the all-in-one object we call the smartphone—a companion always with everyone and always connected. Seeing and speaking.

It is a simple piece of glass with a coated electronic back and a battery to keep alive VIDEO to look at. The fairy tale continues with a seeing, speaking and showing machine demanding touch, occupying sensorial space, and canceling out.

Online Video

With the smartphone, online video is everywhere all at once. Video itself is ubiquitous, unquestionable and unquestioned. This much has been noted many times before.¹⁴ Video is elementary to all aspects of contemporary, technology-driven life, from entertainment and commu-

12 First YouTube Video -- Me at the zoo by Jawed Karim - YouTube Co-Founder, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OaGwyCSw0bo>, accessed 12 March 2025.

13 Neal Stephenson, *In the Beginning... Was the Command Line*, HarperCollins, 2003. P. 1.

14 Tom Sherman, *Vernacular Video*, In: *Video Vortex Reader: Responses to YouTube*, Geert Lovink and Sabine Niederer (eds.), Amsterdam: Institute of Network Cultures, 2008.

nication to education and marketing. Video is multifaceted, from personal communication to encompassing visual storytelling, interactive experiences, personalization, live streaming on various platforms, and human-machine relations and interactions. Online video has spread to virtually all communication apps, with people constantly creating and sharing video content to prove their existence. It is an integral part of modern communication, shaping how we interact, express ourselves, and consume content in the smartphone era. As I wrote before in *Video Spheres*¹⁵ and *Video Theory*,¹⁶ video is an un-discussable companion of the everyday, an obvious attachment to a range of practices not necessarily related to screening, presenting or communication. It is essentially a relation and a relative without being named so. Rather than a kind of object, video is an appearance. It could be a definition. Operational. Expanded.

Video reflects the immediacy of life itself, the desire to overcome death through memory and replay.

Of course, underlying and motivating the essay is a question: *What is video?* The question is meant to reference the historical work of Andre Bazin and his collection of essays *What is cinema*.¹⁷ And yes, this suggests, at first anyhow, that cinema is an ancestor or at least a possible close relative of the idea and object in question.

Aren't these moving images? The very question suggests difference: the one, nostalgic, still about narration and storytelling, a perfect embodiment of the image (which, in fact, is falling apart, unstable, left in tatters after its deconstruction and tech treatment); the other, simply everything and anything.

Video and the question *what* create a vector, which traverses various environments and formulates a path of exploration from the moving image as an electronic construct and signal (now built by code) towards the embedding of simulated cinematic forms, and further still to the multiple applications of images, or, more reflectively, towards seeing video as the crystallization of time.

Cinema: frozen photographic images, chemically fixed crystals to be played to build syntactical relationships, constructing narrative conditions, embedding its ending through its conditioned form and aesthetics—light captured to be freed.

Media in the digital world is hyper-fragmented. Ultra-short videos dominate social media consumption. In our daily lives, we not only touch video screens (our smartphones); the video itself touches us through our devices.

15 Andreas Treske, *The Inner Life of Video Spheres*, Network Notebooks 06, Institute of Network Cultures, Amsterdam, 2013.

16 Andreas Treske, *Video Theory: Online Video Aesthetics or the Afterlife of Video*. 1st ed. transcript Verlag, 2015.

17 Andre Bazin and Hugh Gray, *What Is Cinema?: Volume I*, 1st ed. University of California Press, 2005.

The uniqueness of video, developing from the history of electromagnetic signals, dismisses the distinction between analog and digital. It helps to create the fragmented media platform structures built around us by technology capital, our consumption, our surveilled behaviors, and automated likes, generating subjectivity in *electric seeing*.¹⁸

Video can shape our beliefs and perceptions and reflect and amplify them. As such, it has become a key battleground in debates over truth, authenticity, and representation. Emerging technologies like AI, blockchain, and the metaverse are simple transformative pathways to whatever unknown. Video in expanded form has been woven and dissolved into the very fabric of our digital lives.

Shiny Things

Early film theory saw the screen as a window to another world. Today, the vast amount of online video creates a constantly changing *ocean* of moving images. Traditional film theories based on cinematic referencing may need to be revised to understand this new reality. Moving images are not just simple pictures flowing in time to build narrative structures, but instants and experiences, movement and duration through a signal affecting eyes, ears, and hands.

Online video has blurred the lines, the borders between categories of cinema, film, media, television, photography, moving and still images, sound, and music. Massive amounts of video data exist online and are layered in multiple chains stacked on each other, creating a complex network of meaning, expression and experience. Machine learning and algorithms are crucial in navigating this world in its complexity. All of which calls for new methods of understanding.

With Geert Lovink, we wrote about the totality and power of online video and its aesthetics and political economy, which differ significantly from film and television.¹⁹ Online video implies, from the moment of recording, extreme availability, mobility, and algorithmic processing. Images—blocks of light data—are no longer stand-alone, but are classified, measured, rendered, tagged, and automatically processed to optimize for *algorithmic beauty already in the basic image-making process*.

An aesthetic appeal might arise from simple patterns—structures or visual elements by mathematical algorithms or computational processes—and might influence our perception of beauty, rendering a normalization and distortion through social media and targeted advertisements of what was ungraspable and vivid to describe before and everyone's personal preference.

18 Charlotte Klink, *Electric Seeing: Positions in Contemporary Video Art*, 1st ed. transcript Verlag, 2022.

19 Geert Lovink and Andreas Treske (Ed.), *Video Vortex Reader III: Inside the YouTube Decade*, Institute of Network Cultures, Amsterdam, 2020.

DOVE's campaign *Real Beauty in the age of AI* refers to and acknowledges the impact of generative image algorithms on imagination and the representation of *beauty*, presenting a guided *Prompt Playbook*.²⁰

Just as modern art finally seemed poised to escape the force of representation, GenAI tools like Midjourney, Stable Diffusion and DALL E in 2023 gave everyone the incredible ability to create very fast, high quality images, expanding to an imaginary world, transporting biases, raising ethical concerns, and foregrounding the over-sexualization of the female body, a lack of diversity, non-inclusivity and the reflection of narrow definitions of beauty. Either in the datasets used to train AI models or the language used to describe influence the output, generating an increasing problem, where women are not free anymore in their daily preferences.

Single photographs have been abandoned with smartphones, as computational photography combines multiple images with sensory data to render a precise, studio-like and aesthetically appealing look. This process is only possible if the image is converted to machine-readable text (code), facilitating online image identification, discovery, retrieval, misuse, exploitation, and dissemination. Smartphones have transformed image production, where images are no longer standalone, instant records of a lost moment, but are processed, classified, and optimized through computational photography techniques and *beautification*. Technology acknowledges change: a series of images, a moment needed to define chiaroscuro, the art of light and shadow, in order to overcome the scary frozen death of the single instant.

Online Video is neither photographic nor cinematographic, but a modular data scan to build gestures, signals, forms of speech, moods, temperatures, and climates. It reflects a world defined on frequency and built out of algorithmic belief, as fragmented live video images from drones, satellites, and cameras combine with search algorithms. This cultural practice transcends traditional boundaries.

Online Video isn't merely passive consumption; it's a participatory practice that allows one to express oneself and *connect*. As both product and event on a digital algorithmic automated assembly line, it extends automation beyond production to consumption and spectatorship. Online Video develops bodily intimacies; people have intimate relationships with networks and dominant platforms, with an ever-growing ocean of data.

Still, there needs to be a theoretical toolset.

Any theoretical approach is marginal. A canonical text for this moment remains to be written. We need a critical lens and a theoretical framework to understand the complexities generated now and their impact on contemporary media and life.

20 Beauty in the AI age. Dove. https://www.dove.com/us/en/stories/campaigns/keep-beauty-real.html?utm_source=substack&utm_medium=email, accessed 12 March 2025.

Online Video is an essential defining element, close to forms of life, and should be described as a cultural practice. The participatory nature of this practice demands a reevaluation of both the aesthetics and political economy of video.

Video transcends space and aims to experience something representable less as an image than a social process: an appreciation of impermanence for its own sake. It also fosters a unique intimacy with technology—an intimacy that necessitates critically examining online Video's role in shaping our perception of the world.

We need a deeper understanding of Video as an operative, transformative force, the *elan vital* (Bergson) of contemporary culture.²¹

We need to better recognize the multifaceted nature of Video if we are to appreciate its cultural, technological, and societal implications.

We need to acknowledge its vitality in terms of its ability to capture and convey the world around us, to see similarities between its creative and dynamic energy and that which animates things and drives them towards growth and evolution, creating complexities and expanding self-organizing systems.

We need to acknowledge Video's ability to captivate, surprise and convey meaning—ephemeral, but also often pointless.

A New Barbarism, Positive

Gene Youngblood suggests that technology allows us to create new worlds through new languages. Online Video, with its emphasis on personal expression and connection, has the potential to be that new language, paving the way for a new heaven on earth. To do this, to use the potential and the energy and overcome the generated status quo, we need to be the barbarians knocking at the gates of Rome.

Barbarism here is not associated with destruction and violence. Following Walter Benjamin's notion of *positive barbarism*, it means a renewal, a kind of cultural *starting over* or clearing away of established traditions and norms.²²

This is a call to action.

•

21 Barry Allen, *Élan Vital, Living in Time: The Philosophy of Henri Bergson* (New York, 2023; online edn, Oxford Academic, 18 May 2023), <https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780197671610.003.0004>, accessed 9 January 2025.

22 Walter Benjamin, *Experience and Poverty*, 1933.

The notes and logs, or logbook-like chapters, collected here are about theory as practice and practice as theory, video practice or audiovisual practice, the practice of moving image signals and the practice of sound, audio - Means simply the practice of recording and transmitting, variations of time, at the same time or at some time, including anytime, act and event, the instant as life itself, reproduction, replay, but also the generation of new and non-human in togetherness, the power of Video and the responsibility of form.

The attempt is to capture here in written form something approximating visual-based thinking in movement, to avoid sticking with images, to circle and spiral around them, moving from association to association, spherically, all towards the pleasure of Video.

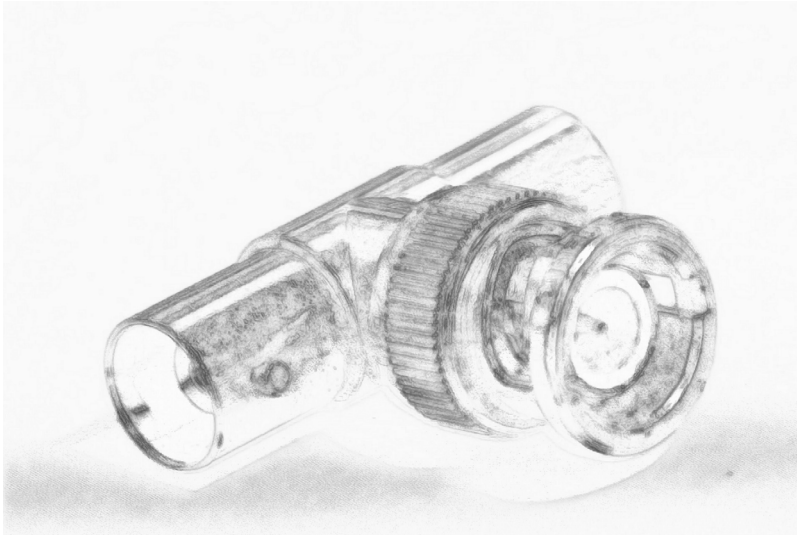


Fig. 1. ARTEFACT

Obviously an artifact, i.e., man-made and not a geological relic, round-shaped tubular, composite object (made of different components (?)); apparent use of various metals or metal alloys (mainly grayish-white, i.e., a possible high-tin copper alloy, lead or even dome-plated or natural silver, if more recent vanadium-containing iron, chromium, zinc or similar possible, digestion can only bring about an X-ray fluorescence analysis); in addition, use of copper or gold-containing material (pin at the end of the flange (?)). In the inner part of the flange (?), visible corrosion residues (?). Mechanically regularly applied, revolving lamellar pattern; whether parts of it are movable cannot be verified on the basis of the image.

—Dr. Thomas Zimmermann

LOG:: 01 AESTHETICS OF INSTABILITY

Video is like water, an entirely ethereal form which was locked into the television for 50 years.

—Tony Oursler (Flash Art, 1996)¹

On the Faculty of Imagination and Cinematic Barbarism

Imagination is the essential ingredient for moving image practice. Imagination is also essential for cinematic barbarism, a necessity if we're to continue to dream CINEMA, but also a necessity for non-cinematic barbarism, a potential force to be awakened.

We are confronted with a difference, perceptible at the skin level. Cinematic practice built on the moving image implies structure and delay, building up forms for narrative constructs. Non-cinematic barbarism, meanwhile, in the forms that confront us every day, simply implies chaos. Here, directed and controlled imagination stands in contrast to the free, wild flow of imagination. What both forces have in common is the faculty of creating images. This is Vilem Flusser's idea of imagination. Compared to such figures as Deleuze, Foucault, or Bergson, he might not be of interest to many scholars, but connecting his ideas on imagination to the aesthetics of moving images, online video, and digital art, and introducing, for comparison, the figure of the barbarian in the work of Mauricio Lazzarato and Walter Benjamin,² as well as the tourist in Hiroki Azuma³ seems an exciting and fruitful route through this ocean of video. What is still relevant in Flusser's ideas is also the somehow shocking fact that we have yet to learn how to use our imagination to decipher the technical images on our screens.

I will contextualize these contrasting figures of the barbarian and the tourist within the dull or not-so-dull work of art house filmmakers and their audiences, or the dull boring or not-so-boring Hollywood industry and the audiences of *Barbenheimer* cinema.⁴

Is the Turkish artist Refik Anadol comparable to Azuma's tourists or his audience? What about *Barbenheimer* and its audiences?

How do these two modalities relate to or reproduce the technologies at hand?

-
- 1 Tony Oursler, Video Dolls with Tracy Leipold, Hirshhorn Museum and Sculpture Garden. 2012, <https://hirshhorn.si.edu/wp-content/uploads/2012/06/Tony-Oursler-Directions-Brochure.pdf>.
 - 2 Maurizio Lazzarato, Videophilosophy: The Perception of Time in Post-Fordism, edited by JAY HETRICK, Columbia University Press, 2019.
 - 3 Hiroki Azuma, Philosophy of the Tourist. Urbanomic 2022.
 - 4 The release of two films on the same weekend - *Oppenheimer* and *Barbie*. See the wikipedia entrance: <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Barbenheimer>, accessed 1 February 2025.

Barbenheimer

But let's first consider the general status of the moving image. Two years after the pandemic, in 2023, came the experience of *Barbenheimer* (the concurrence of the films *Oppenheimer* and *Barbie*), with cinema once again a worldwide synchronous event.

Oppenheimer and *Barbie*, two films released on the same weekend, created a sudden boost for a field marked, once again as often before, by a slow, prolonged death.

Today, streamers, streaming media, and mobile platforms dominate the culture of the moving image. They have absorbed moving image culture and aesthetics into their digital environments, and programmed their aesthetics as the dominating form. Cinematic experiences have now moved into private environments, with giant OLEAD flat screens or handheld shiny devices. Ankara, as a city of shopping-mall cinemas, faces the constant closing of older cinemas beyond the malls, while the latter meanwhile reformat their internal spaces.

Amazingly, Nuri Bilge Ceylan's three-hour film *Kuru Otlar Üstüne*, (About Dry Grasses) enjoyed comparably excellent box office figures in Turkey. Ceylan stands for an art house cinema, promising audiences visual pleasure and cinematic contemplation.

Then, there is the Sphere in Las Vegas: a massive dome with a projective surface inside and outside, an arena for audiovisual events similar to sports stadiums and Olympic games arenas. A building like the Sphere, as architectural symbol, materializes what the Zorlu Center in Istanbul has yet to achieve, or what the architecture—the shape—of the Ankara Opera might, on a much smaller scale, suggest. A friend of mine thought of seeing U2 play at the Sphere, but deemed neither U2 nor the spatial experience worth the \$600 price of a ticket. A reviewer in *Wired* magazine noted that when the band played a few songs without visuals, the musical performance itself was rather dull. Nevertheless, in the Sphere, in the spatial, audiovisual, over-dimensioned, projected, and live sensation, cinema has finally found its cathedral: a home in a dome.

But, honestly, everything has stayed the same since 1924.

1924 was the year of Murnau's film *The Last Laugh*, one of the highlights of cinematic experience in the 1920s, and high on any list of the cinematic language and visual possibilities of the moving image.

I agree with Rudolf Arnheim's judgment that everything that cinema is capable of has already been invented. The installation phase of the cinema had ended; cinema went straight into its deployment phase. Yes, sound was missing, but the films of the 1920s paved the way to recorded sound as the final step in establishing a mass medium. (As a mere side note, cinema always had sound. The 1930s moved from live to recorded sound, establishing another distribution dominance of Hollywood-style cinema, automating a multi-sensory mass product.

Abel Gance had dreamed of a three-dimensional cinema before his multi-screened *Napoleon* in 1927. We still are not there. Our technological dreaming remains in the experimental phase, as television long had, before its emergence in the 1950s, in the wake of world wars. Our technological dreaming remains between the concreteness of spherical cathedrals and immersive noise-canceling headsets.

Surveying the last 50 years of media and cinema development, clearly, digital technology has redefined moving image culture. From the 1971 internet revolution to the digital video revolution of the 2000s, to the 2022 AI revolution, the cultural of the moving image has merged, changing its forms and appearances. Digital technology enabled the mixture of images captured through many different means (cinema, photography, drawings), generating new levels of representation. Analog video gave birth to simultaneity; the computer extended simultaneity to multiplicity.

In his 2001 *The Language of New Media*, a popular work that generated intense discussion, Lev Manovich says, *Cinema becomes a particular branch of painting - painting in time. No longer a kino-eye, but a kino-brush.*⁵ We could extend this prophecy 20 years into the future, from *Adobe Firefly*, *Midjourney*, and *DALL E* to an algorithmic brush, as the new model on the supermarket shelf.

Video is Not Cinema

I wrote in *Video Theory* in 2015:

Comparable to driving a car or taking a shower. It is nearly omnipresent, available on demand and attached to nearby anything, anywhere. Online Video became something vital and independent. With all the video created by the cameras around us, constantly uploading, sharing, linking, and relating, a blue ocean is covering our planet, an ocean of video. What might look as bluish noise and dust from the far outside, might embed beautiful and fascinating living scares of moving images, objects constantly changing, re-arranging, assembling, evolving, collapsing, but never disappearing, a real cinema.⁶

An Ukrainian publisher translated my book into Russian. I don't speak Russian, but was told that the translation was excellent. The inlay of the Russian version includes the following English part, with which I wholly agree:

We are doomed to live in an era of rapid changes, especially in [the] media sphere which overloads us with information. All the technological innovations that are here for us with a single click or a single touch to a smartphone and which we consider to be our extension, literally impose their tyranny on us - the tyranny of vision and perception of reality.

2015 is also the year when Mark Zuckerberg lied about Online Video.⁷

5 Lev Manovich, *The Language of New Media*, Cambridge, Mass.: MIT Press, 2001.

6 Andreas Treske, *Video Theory*. Transcript Verlag 2015.

7 Facebook has been accused of misleading advertisers about the number of people watching videos

The Aesthetics of Instability

Here is where we connect to what I name the Aesthetics of Instability. The power of instability, the constant change, the flow, and the feed define our daily operations and assume our values in a total immersion of ourselves. We have submitted ourselves.

In my 2002 graduate seminar, I posed the question: Will technology alter our perception of time and space in storytelling, or will it lead to entirely new narrative structures, maybe vertical?

Now, I want to offer a change of attitude concerning the use of gadgets around us in ways we need: creative use, uses that avoid all the limitations imposed on us by the industry (limitations of frame, format, vision, and more).

As my Russian translator of *Video Theory* suggests, I would see these not simply as technological developments but as tools and objects with a strong power element. These objects have already changed paradigms, transforming existing systems, neighborhoods, and atmospheres.

The 2022 film *Everything, Everywhere, All at Once* appears as one of the most chaotic films following the pandemic.

Evelyn, a Chinese immigrant running a laundromat, discovers that her life exists in just one of countless universes. The film seems to mirror the internet's overwhelming chaos, or, as the director Daniel Scheinert put it, the sense of *scrolling through an infinite amount of stuff*.

Everything Everywhere has been called one of the first *post-internet* films, capturing the online world's bizarre nature. In our era, human brains, unchanged for centuries, struggle to adapt to a dramatically transformed world. As YouTuber Thomas Flight observes, we now encounter more ideas, people, and places in a single TikTok binge than our ancestors did in entire lifetimes. This rapidly evolving digital chaos challenges our slow-evolving minds.⁸

on its platform. While the company admits to an error in calculating video viewership, advertisers claim Facebook intentionally concealed the mistake for years. This allegedly inflated video viewership numbers, which led many media outlets to shift their focus to video content, often at the expense of other formats and jobs. Essentially, the pursuit of video ad revenue led to a distorted media landscape, harming both advertisers and publishers. Oremus, Will. The Big Lie Behind the "Pivot to Video." <https://slate.com/technology/2018/10/facebook-online-video-pivot-metrics-false.html> Last accessed Monday, 15 July 2024.

8 Rex Woodbury, *Everything Everywhere All At Once: The Explosion in Generative AI Examining Image Models, Language Models, and Use Cases for Generative AI*, Digital Native. J 4 January 2023, <https://www.digitalnative.tech/p/everything-everywhere-all-at-once>.

Of course, ideas are not less complex, less abstract, or less attractive than a 20 second TikTok Video. Flight seems to be overlooking such figures as Duns Scotus, the Scottish Franciscan friar and philosopher (c. 1265/66–1308), or Ibn Khaldun, the Arab historiographer and historian (1332–1406). Their ideas stick.

The universes of the moving image are diverse, strange, weird. They are deep and full of kinetic energy and relentless pace.⁹

Constructive Instability

In 2008, Thomas Elsaesser sparked discussions about YouTube's impact during the second Video Vortex conference in Amsterdam.¹⁰ He shared his journey through the video platform, drawing parallels to Fishli and Weis's *Der Lauf der Dinge*, which inspired the Honda Cog commercial. Elsaesser introduced the term *constructive instability*, a term also used by Condoleezza Rice to describe the Israeli-Hezbollah conflict.

Elsaesser applies *constructive instability* to experiences on the web, primarily through collaborative filtering, exploring how the emergence of Web 2.0 blurs the line between art and artificial life, and prompting us to explore the concept of the *post-human* in a *human* world.

As one of the last flaneurs, Elsaesser navigates YouTube, immersing himself in user efforts, software, and suggestion algorithms. He experiences an episodic narrative filled with loosely connected elements, finding joy but also sensing a fragility, an impending collapse, an *evolutionary dead-end*. This constructive instability's allure lies in its potential destruction.

Similarly, Kyle Chakya, a writer for the *New Yorker*, reflects on his *TikTok* experience.¹¹ He notes that *TikTok* eliminates the need to decide what interests you—you surrender to the platform. *TikTok*'s algorithm drives the platform, creating a personalized feed of short videos that constantly evolves based on user interaction. Unlike other social media, *TikTok* emphasizes the content over the creator, fostering a sense of discovery and immersion. Automation masquerades as customization, dictating what we watch, read, and hear. *TikTok* aggressively pursues our attention, aiming to create an addictive and profitable cycle. Trust in the algorithmic feed empowers the app to manipulate its audience effectively.

Time is the Message. We must treat database-watching with the seriousness it deserves, rather than dismissing it as mere video consumption. Online video platforms are designed to be addictive, with endless streams of content that can captivate viewers for hours on end, far surpassing the length of a traditional film.

9 Black Holes and magic.

10 Geert Lovink and Sabine Niederer, Video Vortex Reader, Responses to YouTube, Amsterdam: Institute of Network Cultures 2008, DOI: <http://dx.doi.org/10.25969/mediarep/19284>.

11 Kyle Chakya, Essay: How do you describe TikTok? The automatic culture of the world's favorite new social network, 9 November 2020, <https://kylechayka.substack.com/p/essay-how-do-you-describe-tiktok>.

This infinite scrolling and clicking has become a defining characteristic of 21st-century culture. We've become accustomed to this perpetual online journey, reluctant to break free from the database's grip.

The short format of many online videos doesn't diminish their potential impact. They cater to our shrinking attention spans, delivering quick hits of information and entertainment. These condensed videos can conceal layers of meaning, inviting deep analysis. However, our supposedly fast-paced lives rarely afford us the time for such contemplation. Ironically, while consuming these videos, we're consuming our own time. In our rush to consume, we neglect to consider the implications of our digital footprints.

Is this constant flux a positive force for innovation or a destructive consumption pattern?

Imagine

Two terms are critically interwoven in this line of thought and questioning: *Imagination* and *Perception*.

Jean-Paul Sartre, in 1936, challenged traditional views of imagination, distinguishing it from perception and emphasizing its totality.¹²

For Sartre, perception is the study of objects over time, an ongoing process of exploring the world, limited by our sensory abilities. It's an anticipative process, revealing aspects of objects gradually in time, piece by piece, and incompletely. For example, we can walk around a building and see different sides of the building at different times. Our perception is, each time, incomplete and needs to be revised as we gather more information, more sensory data.

On the other hand, imagination presents all aspects of an object simultaneously: an object in its entirety, and all at once. When we imagine a building, we don't need to mentally *walk around* the building to conceive of its back side; we can instantly imply the whole structure in our mind. The idea of totality in imagination is crucial to Sartre's conceptualization. When we imagine something, we create a complete image that includes all its essential aspects simultaneously. This totality or whole is not bound by the limitations of physical reality or our sensory experience.

Imagination is an intentional act of consciousness. This means that when we imagine, we are actively creating or shaping the imagined object based on our intentions and purposes. This is not a passive reception of images, but an active, creative world-making process, with meaning and significance that we ourselves give. Imagination allows us to conceive of possibilities that don't currently exist, and enables us to create projections, fictional situations and scenarios.

12 Jean Paul Sartre, *Imagination*, 1936.

Sartre, following Husserl, emphasizes that consciousness is intentional; it is consciousness of something. Imagination pronounces this intentionality. We don't passively receive images; we actively create them. Sartre ties this—our ability to conceive something that is not and to envision alternatives and future possibilities—to human freedom. Imagination allows us to project. It is not simply about mental images, but about how we conceive of and act upon our world.

Sartre's concept of the faculty of imagination indeed allows teleological thinking, with its projective future orientation and role in shaping meaning. The imagination's power to negate the given and envision alternatives is as much about refusing existing ends as it is about positing new ones. It's a tool of freedom, the ground of possibility for both accepting and rejecting given ends—a crucial component of human freedom and meaning-making.

In the 1980s, Vilém Flusser spoke of a new form of imagination, defined by the ability to create and understand images.¹³ Flusser, more than 40 years after Sartre, saw the evolution of imagination as crucial. Historically, primitive forms involved vision, but the hands began to *make and decipher images* to overcome such limitations as constraints on human vision, limited memory, or the restrictions of time and space, introducing artificial images and different alphabets. This process continued through various forms of writing.

While Sartre's analysis was more phenomenological and general, focusing on individual consciousness, Flusser's faculty of imagination is more oriented towards media theory and cultural analysis. He focuses on the role of imagination in creating and interpreting *technical images* (photographs, films, digital images). The *technical image* is no longer a representation of facts and circumstances, but rather an expression of calculations.

Imagination, for Flusser, involves both abstracting from the world (creating concepts) and concretizing abstract ideas into images. Imagination is influenced by cultural codes and programs and plays a definitive role in creating new information and distributing existing information.

Imagination as a faculty has evolved throughout human history, then, from primitive imagination based on a direct visual perception of the world, through what Flusser calls traditional imagination involving the creation and interpretation of handmade images like cave paintings, to textual imagination linked to the development of writing and alphabets, introducing a new level of abstraction of the world. Textual imagination is followed finally by technical imagination related to the creation and interpretation of technical images. Flusser argued that we were moving from a text-based culture to one dominated by particularly technical images, with profound impacts on our understanding and interaction with the world, all of which would require new forms of literacy and new kinds of imagination.

13 Writings by Vilém Flusser. Edited and with an introduction by Andreas Ströhl. University of Minnesota Press, Minneapolis, MN, U.S.A. and London, U.K., 2002. 256 pp., illus. Trade. ISBN: 0-8166-3564-1.

What makes technical images fundamentally different from traditional representative images is simply that they are produced by machines or apparatuses—cameras and computers—based on technical processes. They project specific models onto the world and shape and construct reality through computation. Imagination now requires, if we are to decode conceptual projections, an understanding of the processes and calculations behind image creation. While computers operate on linear sequences (algorithms) and while code is a form of writing, what they produce—particularly visual outputs—are non-linear. Technical images present a synchronic, all-at-once view that's more about relationships and patterns than sequence and causality. This challenges a linear understanding of history.

The new imagination, according to Flusser, is about synthesizing concepts into images. It is not about representing what exists, but about projecting possibilities. Imagination involves translating abstract concepts into visual forms. Flusser's concept of technical imagination provides a framework for understanding how we create and interpret images in a world increasingly dominated by digital technologies and visual media. These media, to be sure, require and call for a different imagination, non-linear and projective.

Furthermore, imagination involves an act of distancing from the world. The ability to distance is connected to and affected by media gestures and media practices, with different media serving as constraints. This ability is connected to media on a practical level. Flusser refers to this practical level not as an *act* or *practice*, but a *gesture* of a medium. For Flusser, a *gesture* is not just a physical movement, but a meaningful action that expresses a particular relationship between humans and their environment. The gesture of a medium refers to the way a particular medium shapes our interactions with the world and with information. Different media have different associated gestures. The gesture of photography might involve framing, focusing, and capturing a moment. The gesture of writing might involve the physical act of putting pen to paper or typing on a keyboard, but also the mental processes of composing a text. These gestures are not fixed but evolve with cultural and technological changes.

Flusser believed the transition to a new faculty of imagination would unlock a new level of existence with fresh experiences, emotions, and values. However, he acknowledged that we're still learning to use this new imagination, and to decode technical images on screens. This new faculty, the translation of concepts into video imagery, has yet to be fully harnessed.

We have to jump into the new imagination.

Art / Kunst

Thomas Elsaesser, thinking aloud along the feed of 2008's YouTube, started his reflective essay in *Video Vortex* with a question already posed by many artists and thinkers in the 1920s avant-garde: Is it that art is coming closer to life, or that life is getting closer to art?

What makes a work of art?

How do we know what is a work of art?

Art and aesthetics are closely connected, with imagination being a key element. Aesthetic thinking plays a role in various aspects of our daily lives. We often use *aesthetics* and *aesthetic* in everyday conversations. For instance, we could discuss the aesthetics of a garden, a hairstyle, a vase, or whether a smartphone is aesthetic.

Our daily lives are filled with aesthetic choices, from selecting and coordinating clothing to liking photos, choosing hairstyles, makeup, places to visit, items to purchase, and music to listen to. Aesthetics, in these cases, pertain to pleasurable sensory experiences. We use aesthetic decision-making when creating graphs, editing photos and videos, drawing images, and designing spaces and structures.¹⁴

Aesthetics encompasses both natural and human-made elements and experiences. It's about everything that can be sensed and perceived, not just what we consider beautiful.

In simple terms, art is a creative expression, a means to tell stories or evoke emotions. It takes various forms: paintings, sculptures, music, dance, literature, or film.

Georg Simmel (1858 - 1918), a German sociologist and philosopher, shows, in his writings on aesthetics, culture, and the applied arts (especially his short essay *The Picture Frame*) that *art* and *design* are two different types of creative processes.¹⁵ Of course, his views predate modern conceptions of design. But what makes Simmel interesting is that he discusses social and cultural phenomena in terms of *forms* and *contents* in a temporal or transient, passing relation. Form becomes content and content becomes form. Art, for Simmel, is autonomous and emphasizes individual expression and uniqueness. Design follows function and the everyday life. It is about applicability in general and embedded in our cultural life. While design responds to immediate needs, art might aspire to timeless and temporary criticism.

Today, AI is automating the art of imitation, introducing a new trend of mass-produced similarities with slight variations. The process remains somewhat mysterious, hidden within the black box of recursive algorithms. AI has been at the forefront of discussions on art and aesthetics. Machine learning and deep learning techniques enable AI to create and analyze art in novel ways. AI can be trained on vast datasets to generate unique pieces not seen before. AI artworks respond to a socio-cultural context and environment with both the space and the need for fast paced production, and for the instantaneous applicability of such artifacts or generative objects.

AI is transforming our sensory experiences and has become the standard method for aesthetic action. In the 21st century, computation, data analysis, machine learning, neural networks, and AI have entered the realm of aesthetics. Music streaming services recommend songs, Ins-

14 Lev Manovich and Emanuele Arielli, *Artificial Aesthetics: A Critical Guide to AI, Media and Design*, 2021, Chapter 1: Even an AI could do that, <https://medium.com/@manovich/artificial-aesthetics-chapter-1-even-an-ai-could-do-that-b75a6266da03>.

15 Georg Simmel, *The Picture Frame: An Aesthetic Study*. *Theory, Culture & Society*, 11(1), 11-17, 1994, <https://doi.org/10.1177/026327694011001003>.

tagram personalizes content on its *Explore* tab, and photo editing apps enhance images with a single click. AI influences fashion recommendations from online retailers. The encounter between AI and aesthetics is significant because aesthetics is traditionally a human domain. One prevalent opinion holds that these developments merely mimic existing styles, and are not creative. In such instances, computers receive pre-existing examples and accordingly generate variants; they try, that is, to introduce some level of variation. Sometimes, what results is uncannily similar to genuine artworks; other results seem a bit off to a trained eye, lacking the final touches to make them convincingly human. Typically, conservative views on art consider technical mastery a criterion for *real art*. However, many people still conceive of art as involving something that doesn't require or perhaps isn't strictly reducible to technical ability. Technical ability means procedural knowledge, for which AI precisely is designed.¹⁶

Aesthetic judgement for Immanuel Kant is always normative. Judgements are based on feeling, specifically the feeling of pleasure or displeasure. When people make aesthetic judgments—such as declaring something beautiful—they are making claims that imply a standard of value that others should recognize. Aesthetic statements are often understood to assert that certain qualities are desirable or preferable, thus carrying a normative weight. For instance, saying *this painting is beautiful* is not just a subjective opinion; it suggests that the painting meets certain aesthetic criteria that can be evaluated and discussed by others. Kant emphasizes that aesthetic judgments are grounded in a subjective experience of pleasure or displeasure, but they claim universal validity. This duality creates a tension: while the experience is personal, the judgment seeks to communicate a standard that others can agree upon.

The *sublime* shatters those norms. Sublime experience disrupts normative frameworks. It overwhelms our senses, inspiring awe and maybe even fear, but is then followed by a process of rationalization. It is foremost an experience of a kind of power that transcends ordinary aesthetic norms, evoking a response that is not easily categorized within the established standards of *beauty*. The sublime challenges the very criteria by which aesthetic judgments are made in the face of something greater than oneself. Thus, while aesthetic judgments aim to establish norms, the sublime shatters these norms by presenting experiences that defy conventional evaluation and provoke a more profound reflection on human existence and life.

Aesthetics is thus conceptualized as a distinct form of judgment, neither purely cognitive nor purely sensual. This touches the *essence* of art and especially avant-garde art. Now, what is called generative art or imagery falls into the *normative* in the Kantian concept of aesthetics. AI cannot generate the *sublime*, or not yet.

16 Manovich, Arielli 2021.

Unsupervised

Let's dive into the work of the Turkish artist Refik Anadol at the Museum of Modern Art. Anadol's exhibition, *Unsupervised*, is unique, having been generated by an artificial intelligence model trained on the public data of MoMA's art collection, spanning over 200 years. AI interprets the museum's diverse collection to create abstract images and shapes.¹⁷

Anadol's art uses machine learning to process tons of data and to craft immersive, multi-sensory experiences that challenge how we perceive space, time, and memory. This amounts, in other words, to technically feeding a specific algorithm or algorithmic model data, examining the results, and tweaking the model output to increase accuracy and efficacy, to foster the expected, intended visual experience and pleasure. The curated data transforms into a dynamic experience for viewers. Anadol and his team loaded their collected data into their neural network to identify and refine patterns in thousands of MoMA artworks, generating new, unique images that share those patterns without resembling any specific paintings. Watching the floating animation is like exploring the universe of MoMA's contemporary art through these patterns.

Art critic Jerry Saltz described *Unsupervised* as a crowd-pleasing, attention-grabbing spectacle—a giant, mesmerizing screen that resembles a colossal techno lava lamp, creating an otherworldly experience.¹⁸ People are drawn to it, taking pleasure in dancing and recording videos while pulpy shapes drift across its edges. The floating colors and shapes recall ocean waves, or else gigantic foams and dusty clouds, pixel dust, a generated dense and intense universe of sensual immersive experience.

But remember, art is subjective. What one person finds terrific, another might not. *Unsupervised* features a large, energy-intensive screensaver at MoMA, essentially a digital daydream based on public data. AI doesn't see images but processes data and weather conditions to produce colorful, flowing patterns. It's like a machine with three dreams, which some technical critics felt was a low number for such a powerful tool.

Anadol tours the world creating massive motion graphics, often screened or projected onto buildings and public spaces, using various databases. Museums love it, and the public is captivated.

However, there's an ethical concern here to consider. AI advancements could very well determine military dominance in the future. The Department of Defense even supports such AI companies as Nvidia, which aids Anadol in creating his unique dreams.

17 Refik Anadol, *Unsupervised*, MoMA, <https://www.moma.org/calendar/exhibitions/5535>.

18 Jerry Saltz, MoMA's Glorified Lava Lamp. Refik Anadol's *Unsupervised* is a crowd-pleasing, like-generating mediocrity, *Vulture*, 22 February 2023. <https://www.vulture.com/article/jerry-saltz-moma-refik-anadol-unsupervised.html>.

In a critical review, Ben Davis points out that *Unsupervised* risks trivializing art history by treating it as random visual elements.¹⁹ But it serves a different purpose; it promotes tech innovation. *Unsupervised* is a program that touches on surveillance and the colonization of space, raising questions about who controls creativity and production. It may appear fun and colorful, but it raises concerns about normalizing surveillance and environmentally harmful computation. Anadol should reconsider the neutrality of his tools, as they have broader implications beyond art.

Never Before

Not only Anadol's spectacular screens but also contemporary cinema calls for meticulously curation, coupled with an assertion of producers and audiences that this, whatever *this* is, has never been done before.

Christopher Nolan touted *Oppenheimer*'s use of alternating black-and-white and color as if it were a new invention, and not something employed in 1939 for *The Wizard of Oz*.

Barbie's marketing positioned the film as a landmark of inclusion, as a blockbuster with a female director, despite the box office success of Amy Heckerling's *Clueless* or Penelope Spheeris's *Wayne's World*. Ironically, this approach even erases the box office success of Gerwig's previous films. *We're trapped in a rugged individualism time loop*.²⁰

The challenge that links Refik Anadol, the cinema industry, and social media stems from their predominantly young target audience. For this *youthful demographic*, everything unfolds for the first time. In the perhaps exceptional case of Anadol, this includes all generations of museum visitors or the museum visiting class, and expands to the commercial target of young people leaving their homes for leisure and pleasure.

We find ourselves in an age marked by a blend of collage and nostalgia, as we continually reinvent our cultural, aesthetic, and artistic expressions.

We lack the contemporary equivalents of cinematic scholars like Andre Bazin or critics like Pauline Kael, who might provide us with a comprehensive cinematic library, offering theoretical insights into the ongoing trends and adeptly identifying emerging voices in the field. Fragmentization, personalization, and individualization have unseated the guiding authority and the narratives and power of cultural critics.

19 Ben Davis, An Extremely Intelligent Lava Lamp: Refik Anadol's A.I. Art Extravaganza at MoMA Is Fun, Just Don't Think About It Too Hard, Artnet, 22 January 2023. <https://news.artnet.com/art-world/refik-anadol-unsupervised-moma-2242329>.

20 Alexandra Coburn, Auteur people, The short memory of film lists, Dirt, 20 October 2023. <https://dirt.fyi/article/2023/10/auteur-people>.

Alexandra Coburn writes in *Dirt*, a daily-ish newsletter on digital pop culture and entertainment:

Now, I work in a film archive, and I can lay out newspaper clippings end to end and watch the American auteur movement of the 1970s die. I can read box office numbers for filmmakers' first films with the foresight that one day, they'll be selling out theaters. Pastiche is often used as a slightly derogatory description—directors are accused of pastiche, as if in the year 2023 it is truly possible to make a film that doesn't rest on the backs of all the films which came before. The most idyllic result of this trend is the resurgence of interest in arthouse cinemas; in a utopia, this would amount to a monetary acknowledgement that good repertory film programming is visionary and worthwhile.²¹

Anything to Be Done?

Nietzsche already called for barbarians: 'Where are the barbarians of the twentieth century? Obviously, they will become visible and consolidate themselves only after tremendous socialist crises'.²²

So, where are the new barbarians? Do we need new barbarians? Who is the new barbarian who breaks free from *the detective opacity of his inner life and the new religious type*?²³

Of course, the understanding of *barbarism* implied here attempts to sketch out a positive concept of barbarism. *Positive Barbarism* refers to Walter Benjamin's view that in certain historical moments, particularly in times of crisis and rapid change, there is value in some sort of a clearing out of *nomenklatura*, of established traditions and norms—a kind of cultural *starting over*. This means not the violent and destructive association with barbarism, but rather a radical departure towards renewal and creative potential in the face of oppression and the poverty of experience in modern life.²⁴

Suppose our experiences and imaginations are fully programmed, flowing algorithmically and automatically. In that case, such *poverty* would force *the barbarian* to start from scratch, to create something new, to make way for new possibilities.

As Maurizio Lazzarato, referencing Walter Benjamin, notes in *Video Philosophy*, the barbarian will not see anything permanent. This is a condition of instability, open thereby to everywhere, with multiple ways to discover and to walk along.

21 Coburn 2023.

22 Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Will to Power*, New York: Vintage Books 1968.

23 Maurizio Lazzarato, *Videophilosophy, The Perception of Time in Post-Fordism*, Columbia Press 2019 JSTOR, <https://doi.org/10.7312/lazz17538>. Accessed 9 January 2025.

24 Walter Benjamin, *Experience and Poverty*, 1933.

Where others encounter walls or mountains, there, too, he sees a way. But because he sees a way everywhere, he has to clear things from it everywhere. Not always by brute force; sometimes by the most refined. Because he sees ways everywhere, he always stands at a crossroads. No moment can know what the next will bring. What exists he reduces to rubble—not for the sake of the rubble, but for that of the way leading through it.²⁵

The text was written in the early 90s, and was translated into English only a few years ago. Lazzarato demands that we testify to our poverty of experience (Benjamin) within the conditions of capital. We must move to politics—to a radical imaginary politics of the moving image. Returning to Henri Bergson's insights, with Maurizio Lazzarato we understand that the Kantian subject apprehends a limited reality compared to the full scope of existence. In Kant's conceptualization, the subject is limited in experiencing phenomena (things as they appear to us), and cannot directly access things-in-themselves (noumena). So, fundamentally for Kant, there is an epistemic limit to what we know. These constraints and limitations further touch on what we perceive and understand of the world. Our perception is constraint. To fathom the true nature of reality, departing from the constraints of the Kantian subject is imperative. This liberation can be achieved through the guidance of James or Bergson, or even through the medium of video without the philosophical guidance of James or Bergson. This dynamic extends to our daily lives.

Political transformation demands more than advocating for improved labor conditions or living standards; it necessitates the expansion of one's experiential horizons. Many subjectivity-related challenges in the realm of work are intimately intertwined with this idea of broadening one's spectrum of experiences.

Consequently, the crisis we currently face isn't solely economic, but is also a crisis in producing subjectivity. This is why, in Lazzarato's work, exploring the production of subjectivity is paramount. This dimension is not extensively addressed in Marx or the broader Marxist tradition. In contrast, the traditions of James, Bergson, Nietzsche and Foucault offer diverse avenues to contemplate the concept of subjectivity's production. When we lament the absence of effective political organization, we may first need to consider more carefully the imperative of enlarging our experiential domains. Walter Benjamin's reference to a *new barbarism* remains acutely relevant today, as the deficiency of a range of experiences underscores the necessity for the emergence of new agents of change.

In *A Thousand Plateaus*, Deleuze and Guattari delve into the concept of the barbarian, particularly in relation to the *nomad*, who perpetually traverses boundaries, moving in and out of empires with unbridled freedom.²⁶ The nomad appears as a source of creativity and innovation in constant movement—one who brings new ideas and practices to established structures and systems. Deleuze and Guattari's concept of the nomad is not primarily about actual nomadic peoples. The *nomad* is a philosophical construct and a metaphor for a way of thinking

25 Lazzarato, 2019.

26 Lazzarato 2019.

that challenges dominant paradigms and offers alternative modes of social and political organization. So, *nomadology* stands in contrast to the *state apparatus* and to power structures. In this sense, the barbarian is associated with a nomadic way of living. Furthermore, Deleuze and Guattari introduce the concepts of *smooth* and *striated* space. Nomads inhabit smooth space, which is an open and undivided space, while the state operates in a striated space—a divided, organized, and structured space. The nomad as well as the barbarian move through smooth space, resisting the organization imposed by empires. Where Walter Benjamin seeks, in his conceptualization of a positive barbarism, to challenge dominant historical narratives and to renew culture and experience freed from the weight of tradition, Deleuze and Guattari try to establish a new mode of existence and thought that resists domination and promotes difference.

While Lazzarato recalls the concept of nomad, the Japanese philosopher Hiromi Azuma seeks to elaborate a *Philosophy of the Tourist*.²⁷ Our *stratified world* today is, for Azuma's analysis of contemporary culture, a world of layers: of the political, economic, national, global, nation-state, and empire. He develops the concept of the *postal multitude*, building it on discussion of the nation-state and empire outlined by Hardt and Negri, but considering the tourist as an element of *misdelivery*. The *postal multitude* refers to a form of collective behavior or social organization that emerges in the context of digital communication and social media. Simply, it combines the ideas of *postal space* and *multitude*. Digital networks transmit and circulate information similar to a postal system, but, of course, with incredible speed and through a mesh of connections. *Misdelivery* is the unintended exchange of information or ideas between members of the multitude of the society, leading to unexpected connections and even collaborations—a failure in delivery, or the occurrence of some kind of unforeseen communication. For Azuma, the *essence of tourism is the misdelivery of information*. The social figure of the tourist is *born of misdelivery* and connected to it. 'The tourist is the subject capable of moving most freely between the strata of the global and the local'.²⁸

The tourist connects the multiple layers of our world and increases the possibility of misdelivery, thereby acquiring an originary role in politics. Azuma defines tourism concisely, categorizing a tourist as someone who, for different reasons, ventures to a destination beyond one's usual environment, excluding employment by a local entity. Moreover, he underscores that tourism is intricately connected to the emergence of mass and consumer societies. This demarcates tourists from immigrants and job seekers, positioning them as consumers acquiring tickets to enjoy goods and services, where consumption is a matter of choice rather than necessity.

In *Philosophy of the Tourist* and his prior work on *Otaku*, Azuma draws parallels with Alexandre Kojève, who, in the first edition of *Introduction to the Reading of Hegel*, sees the end of history embodied in an American way of life, signifying the dehumanization of individuals into mere consumers. In a subsequent edition, after Kojève visited Japan in 1959, he suggests two post-historical archetypes, American animality and Japanese snobbery, positing these

27 Hiromi Azuma, *Philosophy of the Tourist*, Urbanomic 2022.

28 Azuma 2023: 112.

as mutually exclusive, inasmuch as *an animal cannot be a snob*. Yuk Hui, reading Azuma, raises the question of whether tourists exhibit a blend of Japanese snobbery and animality, or perhaps lean more towards one of these traits.

Tourists are not passive consumers as we used to think. Instead, they are active connections that reconfigure the world conceived as a network. A tourist has to be curious and courageous, as Azuma assigns them the task:

to meet people they were never meant to meet, go to places they were never meant to go, think thoughts they were never meant to think; they seek to infuse contingency back into the system of Empire, to rewire concentrated edges once again, and to revert from preferential selection back to mis-delivery.²⁹

Walter Benjamin and Hiroki Azuma might be separated by time and cultural context (from modernity to postmodernity and into the digital age), but *positive barbarism* and the figure of the *tourist* have, at a very essential level, potential connections. Both the barbarian and the tourist are at once engaged with and detached or broken off from culture (the tourist perhaps more superficially so). These figures are responses, carrying renewal and adaptability, breaking with continuity or engaging in temporary fleeting experiences. The barbarian appears more active, while the tourist would seem to wander on surfaces, with the potential of a critical, observational attitude shaped by technological and social structures—the potential of cultural accident, or what Azuma calls *misdelivery*. Both figures are deeply rooted in modes of cultural participation, reflecting and highlighting the ongoing tension between established traditions and innovation, depth and surface, and, most of all, the individual's role in cultural production and consumption.

New Barbarism

The new cinematic barbarism develops out of films that were never meant to be made—a non-cinematic barbarism born of videos never thought of. The new barbarism develops out of an audiovisual misdelivery of sensations of new art and aesthetics, ignoring the operatics of Hollywood capitalist blockbusters, forgetting cinematic real estate and vintage materialities, through smartphone crystal palaces and white halls with high-resolution screens. It emerges out of the loss of grand narratives, the loss of symbolic identification, and builds a phantasmagorical space that traverses reality and fiction, with spatial designs neither indoors nor outdoors, circulating in calibration.

The filmmaker cries for attention to the moment extended in musical dance, an elegiacally ellipsed transition to transcendental instant slow time, a stretched rubber time narrative Proust factor combined with chaos action: diving into the black box for a radical new imagination.

29 Yuk Hui, *A Tourist in the Königsberger's Dream: Review of Hiroki Azuma's Philosophy of the Tourist*, https://webgenron.com/articles/article20230310_01, accessed 12 March 2025.

But what is the point, actually, now?

Considering art house cinema (with its actually 'boring' films), the Las Vegas Sphere (with actually 'boring' music), Adele's stadium in Munich, Refik Anadol's shows (with actually 'boring' visuals), or 2024 as the year of Taylor Swift reformatting cities with even the hint of a visit, the year of pop star tourism (little Taylors all around in Taylor-Gelsenkirchen)... What is being sold is no longer something that has to do with film aesthetics or cinematic/intellectual pleasure/joy (which could be reproduced on any decent screen and sound system) but an *event* that is spatially and temporally confined to a specific moment and location—not unlike the experience of Azuma's tourist.

Taylor Swift does not exist.³⁰

What was your safety question about?

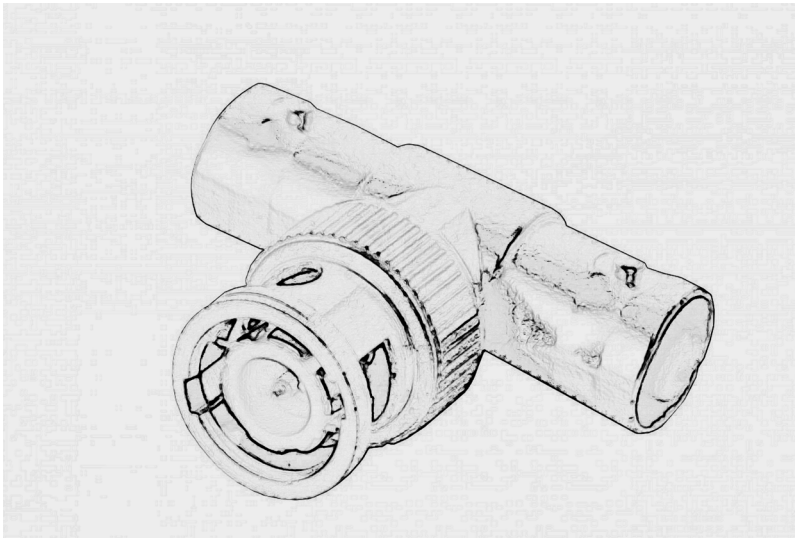


Fig. 2. BABYN

The BNC connector is a miniature quick connect/disconnect radio frequency connector used for coaxial cable. It features two bayonet lugs on the female connector; mating is fully achieved with a quarter turn of the coupling nut. BNC connectors are attached to the ends of coaxial cables and can be used for connecting signals such as RF signals and video signals on consumer electronics. BNC stands for Bayonet Neill Concelman. Bayonet describes the physical connector type and Neill and Concelman are the names of the BNC connector's two inventors. The acronym BNC has been mistakenly believed to stand for British Naval Connector, Bayonet Nut Connector, and Baby N connector.

30 Achim Szepanski, Taylor Swift does not exist (Extended Version). <https://internationaltimes.it/taylor-swift-does-not-exist-extended-version/>, accessed 9 January 2025.

BNCs are suited to accommodate a large variety of RG and industry standard cables, in a variety of termination styles.

- *Bayonet coupling mechanism provides positive, quick mating and un-mating*
- *50 Ω and 75 Ω impedance designs allow customers to match impedance to system requirements*
- *Connectors are available for military, industrial and commercial applications.*³¹

*In earlier computer networks, BNC connectors with coaxial cables were used in Ethernet networks, but Ethernet networks are now more commonly connected by RJ45 connectors and CAT5-style cables.*³²

31 Amphenol, <https://www.amphenolrf.com/connectors/bnc.html>.

32 Sam N. Austin, What Are BNC Connectors Used For? <https://itstillworks.com/bnc-connectors-used-5044736.html>, accessed 12 March 2025.

LOG:: 02 INTENSE HEAVEN

... the next thing you know you're in heaven. You're surprised to be there. On the other hand, it's happening ...

—Jordan Belson

Cinema is not dead. Just a configuration, remastered.



Wie kann man nur auf den Gedanken kommen, das Menschen durch Briefe miteinander verkehren können! Man kann an einen fernen Menschen denken und man kann einen nahen Menschen fassen, alles andere geht über Menschenkraft.¹

Kafka's note, written in another media world with durations of days to deliver messages, suggests how amazing it is to communicate over a long distance in real time; overcoming distance and being simultaneously at different places is just beyond the capacity and the power of us humans, our bodies, and our physical existence, without any technological assistance.

But, isn't it wonderful if things far away come so close?

Some hundreds of kilometers away, a swimming pool pump needs to be repaired. On the small screen of the telecommunication device in your hand appears a man in a dark blue jumper suit pointing towards the pump, explaining what has to be done. You are asking a question. The man is listening, then responding to you. He is making a gesture with his hands and his arms, simulating what he will be doing.

On another call on the same device, a two-year-old child sings a little lullaby, smiles, and waves to the sending device's camera. She kisses her screen. Her lips touch the glass. And here, somewhere too far away, the finger of an older woman, her grandmother, gently touches the surface of the transporting device as well, returning the kiss, laughingly, with a child laughing in response. Without changing positions, without moving bodies, the two overcame a distance. They were far away, so close. For a particular duration, it is a very pleasant, enjoyable situation that is emotionally loaded, has a sense of intimacy, and shares happiness for both. It is a moment of heaven—heaven on earth.

1 How can anyone come up with the idea that people can communicate with each other through letters? You can think of someone far away and you can reach someone close to you, everything else is beyond human power. Franz Kafka [nach: Im Schwarm] Prag, Ende März 1922, Briefe an Milena.

Heaven on Earth

Picturing *Heaven on Earth*, we might point to a concrete location, a place somewhere. This place is often linked to an experience, a situation, or an event—something like a beautiful memory. It is related to a place we have experienced. We know an experience. The memory stays with us as the duration passes, as the event and the place disappear. The place is out of reach. The event might not repeat. But the memory is recalled and repeated in a certain way. The memory is fluid, merged with our imagination.

Heaven on Earth might be the most scenic and breathtakingly beautiful location, something outstanding: marvelous food, joyful people, a wonderland, *Schlaraffenland*, paradise, *Eden*, *Land of Milk and Honey*, *Shangri-La*, *Never-Never-Land*, *Zion* and *Elysium*, *Canaan*, only existing on Earth. In other words, a perfect world somewhere, a world that immerses me, a world responsive to everything I feel and want. Easiness and lightness. Quickness and exactitude. Visibility and multitude. It is just what I feel and want here and now: cyber-phantasies of the 1980s, Xanadu of the computer and internet pioneers of the 1960s, the heaven that Jordan Belson and the video artists and experimental filmmakers of the 1970s dreamt of.

A world that I love and want to hold on to: a memory never to leave. I am generating an image out of my imagination, a personal image, explicitly rendered for me, by me, and deciphered by me.

Imagination is the faculty of making and deciphering images, no longer strictly related to objects. The images are mere concepts and, therefore, transparent. We are accustomed to using images, such that these images become invisible for us. The medium of images is of no interest for us, but rather the content conveyed. Vilem Flusser was particularly concerned with technical images (photographs, films, digital images) because of their apparent realism.²

My Heaven on Earth, this beautiful location, this extraordinary situation, this moment in my life, recalled as memory, is the imagination of a concept producing meaning for me, and only for me.

However, *concepts* are philosophical terms, or at least follow a philosophical understanding. When, in 1987, Gilles Deleuze asked, in a conference at the French film school *La Femis*, *What do you do when you do cinema?* he formulated concepts as a mode of philosophical practice, an act of creating new ideas. Concepts invent a fresh way of conceiving reality. Concepts are constructed out of other concepts, thus building an infinite chain or interconnected network of ideas.³

2 Vilem Flusser, *Kommunikologie*, Mannheim 1996.

3 Gilles Deleuze, *What is the Creative Act?*, Conference given on 17 March 1987 in the Tuesday lecture series at the FEMIS film foundation. Revised transcription and translation by Charles J. Stivale. <https://deleuze.cla.purdue.edu/lecture/lecture-01-21/> Last accessed 9 January 2025.

The place I imagine, then, is not as singular or specific as I believe; the place I see before my inner eye, the place I imagine, is a composite, a construct of many things out of a network of things, layered and multifaceted.

All of a sudden, what appeared to be clear became obscure. My memory, with its clarity and openness, has moved away from the reality of its original experience, from its subjectivity. My memory layers a veil over a surface, generating a lack of depth and giving an opaque or distorted, an incomplete or otherwise unclear representation in an emotional state, mixing with the construction of an individual in a cultural sphere.

What if I did not have this experience? What if I did not live it? But I am confident; I have seen and lived it. I remember. It was a place I could not go. I have seen a movie. One friend shared a video. I read it somewhere.

Charlotte Wells's 2022 coming-of-age drama *Aftersun* tells the story of Sophie, reflecting via video camcorder footage on her last holiday trip as an 11-year old child with her father on the coast of Turkey. Real and imagined memories fill gaps in a portrait of a father-daughter relationship, a very closely inspected and deeply personal reconciliation.

Sakura, a cherry blossom in Japan seen in a film by Doris Dörrie, is a mass of flowers on a tree, a soft beauty reminding the *Vergänglichkeit* of feelings of us and our world—of ephemerality.

The first images of Chris Marker's *Sans Soleil* reference an image of happiness, or the *eastern fantasies* of Flaubert according to Alain De Botton's description in his book *The Art of Travel*.

If it was a film or a book, I entered someone else's imagination. Someone else showed me the world through their eyes, transported me to other times, and made me unexpectedly explore new emotions and experiences. What is wonderful about cinema is that it looks so natural, as Melies already stated, shortly after the birth of the medium we call cinema. When Auguste Lumiere and his wife were feeding their baby, it was not the depiction of the happy family that excited Melies, but the movement of the leaves on the trees in the background around the family. They were so real.

The experience of watching moving images on a screen can be deeply personal. Cinema was a dark chamber excluding the outside world. Shopping malls similarly exclude the outside world, removing windows to embed visitors and shoppers in artificial lighting for the whole experience of personal shopping. LG, the television maker and high-tech company, depicted, in an advertisement for their television screens, people carrying LED screens into a train and closing the wagon beyond the windows to open a space for the wonders of the inner worlds of these screens, displayed to the inside, excluding the world outside. And maybe the outside world isn't worth watching or experiencing. Display technology is taking away, preventing us, from a possible dystopia, from the reality of our existence.

Technology mediates the world we see and imagine with content loaded, attractive images and sounds, giving meaning to while generating tension between the external world, the observable world seen by our eyes and captured by cameras and sensors, and our internal and subjective world of thoughts and feelings smoothes. We enter into a familiar and strange world, enabling us to explore the boundaries between what is real and what is imagined. We have left the dark chamber of the cinema to be exposed to a cinematic world *all-um-fassend* (all around, embedding and immersive), controlled by algorithmic rules in an invisible, surveilling digital environment, not exactly what Jeremy Bentham imagined in his panopticon, but close to the idea, in programmed form.

But Heaven on Earth might not just be the imagination of a place, the memory of an experience. Heaven on Earth can go beyond a feeling or an atmosphere that is difficult to define and describe, which might differ for different people. Heaven on Earth might be the feeling of flow, a state of being fully absorbed and engaged in an activity, where time seems to disappear, and our senses of ourselves merge with the task we dived in. Just the idea of Heaven on Earth can encompass a sense of connection and belonging and community, where we feel grounded and secure in the world.

‘Separation. The cold separation of space, and the wonder and terror of the plain technical fact that a signal can shrink distance, so that people millions of miles apart are able to talk with each other, face to screen, disembodied, versions of themselves hurtling through space in signals and waves.’⁴ This is the paradoxical nature of technology and communication. We are far away physically, but experience immediacy in our conversation, seeing each other in virtual environments, and hearing each other. Only touch and the blow of breath remain to be enacted. Modern communication technology has enabled us to connect and communicate across vast distances, in ways unimaginable just a very few decades ago. The pandemic of 2020 has calibrated opportunities for online work, collaborations, distance learning, and video-conferenced social connections. The paradox here is that the same technology creates a deep sense of separation and disconnection. We communicate through screens we view and touch with our fingertips, and listen to disembodied voices rather than in person. The shrinking of physical distance builds a psychological distance through mediated technological channels of audiovisual communication platforms. The ambivalent nature of technology affects our lives and challenges our privacy, security, relationships, and social interactions.

But, ...

Still. Wouldn't it be nice, for example, if you enter a room and the room would understand that it is you who enters? When you sit down, a chair adjusts to you based on knowledge of you and your body. A car you will drive has, at the moment you sit, miraculously adjusted its operating system to your needs and preferences, your average driving style, and comfort. Wouldn't it be nice if your home knew where you and your children are?

4 Nicholas Rombes, 10/40/70: Constraint As Liberation in the Era of Digital Film Theory, Winchester, UK: Zero Books 2014.

What kind of food is in the refrigerator, and whether it's enough for the kids? Will the kids like it? Actually, what would I want to eat now?

Our spaces, the spaces we live in, are enhanced through technology expanding our everyday spatial experience. Cinema was the space of imagination, narratively and visually. Did the space of our everyday become more cinematic or utopian through these technological enhancements, these mediated extensions of our bodies?

The Ultimate Display

By early 1970, Ivan Sutherland had already described the *ultimate* situation:

The ultimate display would, of course, be a room within which the computer can control the existence of matter. A chair displayed in such a room would be good enough to sit in. Handcuffs displayed in such a room would be confining, and a bullet displayed in such room would be fatal. With appropriate programming such a display could literally be the Wonderland into which Alice walked.⁵

Amazing. Sutherland's display still does not *exist*. A fully immersive and interactive environment reproducing our experience of the physical world is a dream yet to have come true. We still can't *exist* in a virtual world.

Janet H. Murray, in her 1997 *Hamlet on the Holodeck: The Future of Narrative in Cyberspace*, discusses the influence of digital technology on the development of stories and narrative.⁶ She examines the use of the *holodeck* as it first appeared in the TV series *Star Trek: The Next Generation*. Murray comes to the conclusion that interactive cinema and hypertext fiction of the 1990s are tools or technologies to *explore inner life*. Space has not been taken over or transformed—yet.

Video Vortex XI, held in Kochi in 2017, featured the artist-research Nadav Assor's *Titchener's Cage*, a site-specific, mixed reality installation in which the viewer wears a VR headset. Entering the space, the viewer is confronted with an altered physicality of her own body, as well as a cast of former, now ghostly visitors, captured as 3D point clouds. The space turns into a subjective sensory and aesthetic experience of other people. VR technology here leaves the inner life, and confronts us with an already occupied environment of others.⁷

5 Ivan Sutherland, Ultimate Display, 1970, <http://www.w2vr.com/timeline/Sutherland.html>.

6 Janet H. Murray, *Hamlet on the Holodeck: The Future of Narrative in Cyberspace*, 1997.

7 Video Vortex XI Kochi. Conference Report. 23 – 26 February 2017, Kochi, India. Institute of Networkcultures 2017. <https://networkcultures.org/videovortex/2017/04/05/video-vortex-xi-kochi-conference-report-now-available/>.

In 2021 Mark Zuckerberg outlined his vision of the future of the mobile internet, in what he called the *metaverse*, a space where digital and physical worlds come together:

It is a space where digital representations of people – avatars – interact at work and play, meeting in their office, going to concerts and even trying on clothes. At the centre of this universe will be virtual reality, a digital world that you can already enter via Facebook's Oculus VR headsets. It will also include augmented reality, a sort of step back from VR where elements of the digital world are layered on top of reality – think Pokémon Go or Facebook's recent smart glasses tie-up with Ray-Ban.⁸

In June 2023, Apple announced the VR AR headset *Vision Pro*, following Meta, Google, Magic Leap, and Microsoft, each with its foray into this virtual world through various interfacing devices and hypermedia-oriented software. Apple's step seemed, in 2023, to be a starting point for a much broader technological exploration into augmented reality, with new applications and the expansion of spatial video. Spatial video and spatial computing open up vast possibilities for enriching engagement and experience with technology, potentially redefining how we will interact with and shape our new digital and physical worlds. Zuckerberg's Meta and Apple are building a new computing layer with *fantastic world-changing possibilities*, through a commercial vision of re-connecting people through spatial computing that expands from the screen and the headset to the surrounding physical space.

A few days ago, a contact from across the country was Facetiming with me on the Vision Pro, which felt a bit like being in the same room. It was a mind-melting experience, and it's pretty clear that in a few years we'll be able to just feel like we're physically together. That's very cool, and could help us stay connected to friends and family in a way we can't do now.⁹

Matt Stoller's testimony sounds like an advertisement. Probably the first telephone conversation gave the people the feeling of being *in the same room* with each other as well.

Still, we have yet to arrive. The internet and smartphones dominate the digital world experience for most of us, a never-ending stream of data, images, and sounds, attractive, distractive, and addictive, much like the real universe or the German *Weltall*.¹⁰ It is the whole as one and the whole as all things, but it appears somehow flat.

In his seminal 1945 essay *As We May Think*, Vannevar Bush envisioned a system of the future called *memex*, where all information could be accessed and organized. AI technology companies must have read the text and embedded this vision in their training sets for the commercial

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- 8 Dan Milmo, Enter the metaverse: the digital future Mark Zuckerberg is steering us toward. The Guardian. 28 October 2021, <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2021/oct/28/facebook-mark-zuckerberg-meta-metaverse>.
 - 9 Matt Stoller on Substack - Subject: It's Apple's Vision Pro, The Rest of Us Just Live Here, 16 February 2024 at 22:44, <https://www.thebignewsletter.com/p/its-apples-vision-pro-the-rest-of>.
 - 10 Martin Burckhardt and Dirk Höfer. All and Nothing: A Digital Apocalypse, translated by Erik Butler, The MIT Press, 2017.

realization of their algorithmic models.¹¹ Ted Nelson's Project Xanadu, from 1960, proposed a digital repository scheme for worldwide electronic publishing. In Xanadu, all documents are interconnected and seamlessly navigable. Somehow, in its vision, it is still superior to the World Wide Web, which is, as today's joint simulation of paper, a maze of dead ends.¹²

The simple vision of this universe reminds us of the sleeping beauty Snow White, or of Alice's looking-glass: of being simultaneously at different locations on the globe and having entered into a world, an archive of the actual and possible forms of reality.¹³ Like Dorothy we are landing in *Munchkinland*, in the *Land of Oz*.¹⁴

Heaven is not just the technological transfer of an audiovisual signal through a device, a window as a sensible outlook to another known world, an algorithmic translation of seeing in patterns and 8x8 coded squares decoding information in chunks and blocks of the existing physical space in front of a camera eye or in a video recording image, a room continuously computing its interior, a code/space surveilling and directing. Heaven is an expanding universe of incredible possibilities, overcoming the limits of my body and even my imagination, never-ending and always there. Simply, spatial computing and immersive sounds open up a digital universe layered on our physical space, where we are centered, each of us, individually and customized.

Passages

Once, the closest thing to heaven was a place of worship where people would go, centered and visible from afar in a landscape, thanks to its architectural structure. In a world where windows of buildings turn inside like those of shopping malls, and glass high-rises mirror the glass mirrors of other surrounding high-rises as the light changes and the clouds move, heaven's architectural focus flattened and multiplied, now shrunk to the surfaces of devices or perceptible. Sensitive human perception assists glass-like thin objects, carried very close to or even directly on the human body, in generating their spherical enclosure. We carry these devices with us every day. They are a central part of our lives; through them, we explore never-seen new worlds and shopping heavens previously impossible; we disconnect from the physical world and lose ourselves in the space between.

Devices function as passages.¹⁵ They are not substitutes for telephones, television, or tele-action. They are assisting in the realization, the coming into being, of at least two bodies, two of us, generating a digital double. Devices assist in realizing the presence of the two of us. This is the transformative potential of digital technology. We are becoming present in a place

11 Vanevar Bush, As we may think, The Atlantic. July 1945. <https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/archive/1945/07/as-we-may-think/303881/>.

12 Project Xanadu. Wikipedia. 09.01.2025 https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Project_Xanadu

13 Martin Burckhardt and Dirk Höfer, 2017: 48.

14 The Wizard of Oz. Film. Directed by Victor Fleming. 1939. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Wizard_of_Oz.

15 Invisible and immediate passages. To communicate with objects, we need devices, need assistance, as long as they are not within our bodies. In that case, the cyborg. . .

different from where we are physically, through a digital object, which could be called an *image*, a vehicle, or a visualization of a touchable transfer port. This object passes from us to anywhere and anytime. Maybe we have an expected duration where we match in realization, or a kind of creative actualization, but it is not necessary to match with the *virtual*.¹⁶

This kind of *image* is not a flat plane of visual information. Here, *image* denotes a block, a pattern, or an amount of data related to a physical appearance, a body appearing in a diverse range of forms, and not only visually on the surface of a screen or display.

Visual information, temperature, experiences and actions from past and present, different locations, and references of any kind that could have been sensed, registered, translated, stored, and accessed in non-linear ways are building a multiplicity in a singular digital object, like cells of a non-physical body in endless realizations.¹⁷ For digital *images* or images alike, imagery objects are not static or flat, but dynamic and multi-dimensional. They are constantly evolving and adapting to different contexts and interactions.

Our technology transforms us as digital objects in data entities, life-like performing beings, enabled to produce high-resolution fiction, or, in practice and training, responsive, creating or consuming, working. Another us or I, a double, comes into existence, a copy in the form of a digital or mathematical entity, an object seemingly us. We are still determining if this double is truly us or merely an approximation of who we are in our physical world. How do we reconcile our physical existence with our digital presence?

The smartphone device combined and merged telephony, as an attachment to our physical body. It transforms us into screen, into skin, into this other entity as sums, or sums of data, the result of an operation, a calculation. We, thereby, are the world, or we become complex in this specific world, or *with* the world.

As no longer just physical beings, we can constantly connect to a vast other world with new frontiers and significant challenges, navigating a complex and ever-changing landscape. We have overcome Gaia's limits, won the fight for a seat on the starship Earth, and exhausted its physical presence.

Our ability to act somewhere other than where we are physically still follows a 19th-century urge, a wish to overcome distance and proximity, to bring things, or consumable goods, to us from far away. It appears to be a follow-up of the railway as a mechanical transport technology. Mechanics are replaced, and former industrial processes are extended and transformed with electronics, wireless circuits, microcontrollers, and the digitization of information. Video is a method of transporting containers, a packaging for data across time.

16 To be more precise, to indeed deepen the discussion, it will help to contextualize things through Deleuze's treatment of the virtual/actual. See *On Virtuality: Deleuze, Bergson, Simondon* by Matt Bluemink. <https://epochmagazine.org/36/on-virtuality-deleuze-bergson-simondon/>.

17 We have in ourselves experience of a multiplicity in simple substance ... See G.W. Leibniz, *Monadology*, 1714. §16. <https://www.plato-philosophy.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/07/The-Monadology-1714-by-Gottfried-Wilhelm-LEIBNIZ-1646-1716.pdf>.

Temporality creates density of information.

Essentially, embedded is the aim not to transport us, but rather to transport to us things of interest conquered or acquired outside of our immediate environment. Rather than transporting our bodies in situations where physical presence might be necessary, these bodies are substituted, even replaced, by lightweight or non-weight, real or virtual objects. New bodies are remotely enabled to act in our physical stead.

Through telepresence, we become present with two bodies. The energy consumption of the transport is reduced to nearly nothing, so as to enable multiple, endless transportation and actions in a more complex, automated, and multiplied world and environment. The motivations of modernity, the 19th century of discoveries and inventions, continues to be the determined path we still follow and to which we are still exposed in our technical development. We just no longer need to transport physical bodies and objects.

In the 19th century, panorama, daguerreotype, and photography, the technological precursors of film, cinema and moving image culture, were inspired by the paradigms of simulation, substitution, and reproduction; dynamics and kinetics inspired the movement of images, the creation of movement, transport, and the transport of objects. The projection of moving pictures was based on the inspiration of energy transformation—fairs, exhibitions, and world market-inspired public and collective screening. All the inspirations and inventions of the 19th century have this in common: they simulate and substitute. They simulate materials, activities, attributes, and functions. The idea of substitution guided inventors, who aimed to create a replacement for everything imaginable and practical. The purpose of a majority of these substitutes was to allow one to overcome distances, to move things, reduce things, create simultaneity and immediacy, leading, at the same time, to multiplications or multiples of any object or thing, to variations and operations.

Finally, all modern technological developments have a specific narrative form. An aesthetic of transparency characterizes this last element, adopted by films in the 1910s, particularly in US American film production. The desire to *travel without having to move* inherent to this aesthetic can be traced back to the nineteenth century in phantasmagoria, immersive *dispositifs* such as panoramas and stereoscopic photography, and, principally, in the novels of Balzac and Dickens, which make use of new techniques to sketch out characters, actions, space and time.¹⁸

The ability to be absolutely mobile, flexible, and dynamic anytime and anywhere: this dream ends up in stillness, surrounded by things in autoplay, and by infinite scrolling. Traveling in space beyond our planet, or traveling outside of our spans and durations, along a scale of time we now have learned, must be related to the death of our body. To travel, we have to perform suicide. Only if we are convinced that body and mind are separated and can exist

18 A. Parente and V. de Carvalho, *Cinema as dispositif: Between Cinema and Contemporary Art*, Cinémas, 19(1), 2008, 37–55, <https://doi.org/10.7202/029498ar>, <https://www.erudit.org/fr/revues/cine/2008-v19-n1-cine2876/029498ar.pdf>.

independently can the body be replaced like a car or a phone, like any object of use, or a thing: the Golem. Biologically, cells are always dying and renewed in our body. The whole actually needs to be accepted as renewable. Wasn't it the breath of God that blew the spirit into the body of clay, linking these until the end of the human day?

As parts of our bodies become replaceable and possibly generated anew, we can't replace their whole entity, which would be a unity of another object and mind—or not yet. This is what we are not certain about. The other entities are still connected and interwoven with the existing version of the body 1.0, the replacement, mediating our identity, and building a system of social interactions, webs, and networks, and air-conditioned spheres.

We are taught that we can only leave our limits, can leave Earth only if we produce a moving image or a life-like image of us. We are still embedded in the modernist approach to technology, within 19th-century modes of invention. Beaming as molecular deconstruction is only possible in the form of a video stream, only that video is not an image but rather a body; this sounds like a conclusion found in another cyberpunk novel, but reality has become a mode of scanning and printing. The post-human body will be printed not with plastic but with cells and growing information written in or on them. Images would be the carriers of information. The motion of the moving image would also be the freeing act of human consciousness, neglecting the single individual but selecting one subject, the entity described just before, an entity worth leaving, or, as we said, the amount of noise creates this single human entity, a different kind of Golem, with a blown-in spirit built of our moving images.

What Blake found in the Bible is the priority of Inspiration over Memory, of the visionary and the imaginative over the traditional and conventional. In these words there is a manifesto for the thesis of this book. They culminate with the stirring stanzas to encourage people to build the New Jerusalem.¹⁹

We can't take technology for granted, or at least we shouldn't. Technology will change and transform rapidly, but what will we become? We become material, substance, the universe, gods, the singularity, and the world, everything, including religious utopia, the new utopia, an unlimited body for an unlimited mind built out of millions and millions. We are the world... Ultimately, we have never traveled; we have always been in one place. Where do we go if we can't go? We are moving, spinning like atoms, electrons, that we already know. The outcome of all the technological advances we already know and have in our genetic code. The end of grand narratives is the upcoming of the oldest.

We have to overcome our natural—that is, our body. This will be painful. But having pain is what makes us human. The new entity is not human, if human is what we are, so it becomes alien. The alternative will be impossible not to change. It always does.

19 Christoph Rowland, *Radical Prophet. The Mystics, Subversives and Visionaries who Strove for Heaven on Earth*, Bloomsbury Publishing 2017: .3.

Heaven is any world you can be as you. Maybe the world is you. You or the I, the subject, is what is constant. We are constantly documenting ourselves in moving images as proof of our being. We repeatedly demonstrate to ourselves the mode of our existence in the world. This world summarizes all possible worlds: the inner us turned outwards. In our selfies, we are real.

All and Nothing - Immortality

Our digital world consists of information, zeros and ones, infinite chains of combinations and infinite replication. We can achieve immortality through turning into a pure sign.²⁰

The passages, screens, and devices are not simple interface images but movements, objects in movement, and changing *things*. Movement and change present a reality of the digital mirroring double. God has not just been removed from the church tower and the town clock and replaced by himself as a programmer; God has become a VJ, making us dance with ABBAatars.²¹

We want to imagine that things are fixed: plain objects and clear structures. The world we live in is messy. We imagine stability while the surrounding circumstances are unstable. Science has taught us that the world is not composed of fixed and tangible things. The world is a continuous process of fleeting entities and vibrations, particles coming to light and disappearing, a swarm of ephemeral quanta of space and matter, a great jigsaw puzzle of space and elementary particles constantly appearing and disappearing. Fluid. A world of events and happenings. Humans, *we*, are the subjects who observe the world: *nodes in a network of exchanges through which we pass images, tools, information and knowledge*.²²

We invent stories and follow traces in this world to find or uncover something. The world we perceive is something we are situated within, and which is shaped by our interactions.

In *De rerum natura* (On the Nature of Things), the Roman philosopher Lucretius already spoke about our demanding appetite for life and experience. We can never experience enough of life to satisfy our desire for it. The desire for life is the desire for the world. Pleasure is the highest good. The pursuit of pleasure should be the ultimate goal of our human life. Of course, Lucretius warns us to be cautious against excess and the pursuit of pleasure at the expense of one's well-being, emphasizing the importance of moderation and balance. Ulus Baker, reading Spinoza, reminds us that the affections that a body can experience are not only limited to joy, but also sadness, and this range of affections *empowers* the body.²³

20 Martin Burckhardt and Dirk Höfer, *All and Nothing, A Digital Apocalypse*, MIT Press 2017.

21 Reanna Smith, What is ABBA Voyage? How 'hologram' concert works in specially built arena, *The Mirror*, 27 May 2022, <https://www.mirror.co.uk/3am/celebrity-news/what-abba-voyage-how-hologram-27079797>, accessed 12 March 2025.

22 Carlo Rovelli, *Seven Brief Lessons on Physics*. Penguin Publishing Group, 2016.

23 Ulus Baker, Aras Ozgun (Editor) and Andreas Treske (Editor), *From Opinions to Images: Essays Towards a Sociology of Affects*, Amsterdam: Institute of Network Cultures, 2020.

Seeing things moving, recording them, and replaying them endlessly generate pleasure, excitement, and well-being, satisfying curiosity and stabilizing the world through repetition, forgetting the fluidness and instability of being inside a simulated stream. The world coded from the world in writing turns back to the world in writing to become a world in video streaming. The pleasure of video is its fluidity combined with its sense of touch overcoming the skin and the frame blended in. Everything turning into writing became everything turning into video. It is more immersive and vivid, but seems faster and more complex overall. Its duration allows complexity.

On the other hand, everything video turns into writing. A prompt for generative AI is a text, a code, an image, or a video, but it is then again a code and a text. Writing and text are fundamental to understanding human culture.²⁴ Writing plays a crucial role in the shaping of our imagination. Video is replacing writing as a dominant communication form; it reorganizes our hand's functions and the message's tactility; the spoken word, when spoken, forms communication with a home bot or any form of chatbot. Digitization has reconfigured every element, object, and thing, making it available and transformable, fluid, and fast. A written prompt is a slow form of a word uttered to create a world and to communicate with my double, my other in the virtual. The tools to do so are not dominated by hand or body movement to transform, but by delegation, through language acts, to a system of tools and utilities, through communication with objects. Human and non-human actors are involved in a creative process that generates new forms and structures. What feels strange disrupts our habitual understanding and perception of the world. It breaks with established forms and structures to engage with the virtual, or, we could say, with the potential realm of ideas and concepts, in order to open something up for creativity and innovation, as the continuing driving forces of human culture and of we humans ourselves.

Suppose we can imagine a world with our double. In that case, imagination can transform our perception of reality and, therefore, our actions in the physical world. Imagination is the active force that shapes and reshapes our understanding and acting.

Suppose the world is a fixed image on a flat surface, frozen death for eternity. In that case, our imagination will be limited, and it will be impossible to see beyond what is given. The image framed is a barrier to the free play needed to imagine.

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Understanding the social and technological factors that shape our experience of the world is essential. Cinema as a medium or/and media in general have shaped this experience for the last centuries. Now, the way we access and consume media has dramatically changed. The development of the internet and digital technologies, as well as platforms and modes of media production, have set in motion certain socio-technical changes.

24 Vilém Flusser and Nancy Ann Roth, *Does Writing Have a Future?*, NED-New edition, vol. 33, University of Minnesota Press, 2011, JSTOR, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/10.5749/j.ctttfww>. Accessed 9 January 2025.

We need to look beyond the surface level of the image and around it.

Gene Youngblood argued that cinema, at its most expanded form, was both a model of consciousness and the medium that could transform it. Referring to Jordan Belson, Youngblood believed that artists and scientists working together could create a utopian vision of the world. The artist is a *design scientist*, because in their broadest implications, art and science are the same.²⁵ Gene Youngblood's influence in the 1970s and 1980s was much more attuned—more than those who were widely expected to lead an ongoing and independent avant-garde culture—to the future development or destiny of contemporary experimental film and video and to the digital future of the avant-garde's formal impulses. Youngblood was the opposite of Jonas Mekas, who increasingly prioritized the radical amateur. He saw the possibility of artists and scientists working together to make a *high-tech end run* around Hollywood, which, as it happens, may be occurring now in the 2020s. Still, Youngblood failed to see the administration of the integration of art and science by corporate capital.

Everyone Cinema

The 2020s have witnessed a dramatic shift in how we consume movies. Cinema has shrunk to fit our screens and pockets, readily available on streaming platforms. However, these platforms go beyond the mere presentation of content. They employ design tricks like infinite scrolling and autoplay to keep us glued to the screen, potentially fostering addiction for revenue gains. This cycle creates a loop: the more engaged users become, the more platforms design features to exploit that engagement, leading to a relentless data harvest.

While convenient, concerns are mounting about the potential downsides of these *pocket cinemas*. Studies suggest a link between excessive platform use and negative impacts on mental health and social well-being. Platforms are deliberately designed to keep users hooked, even at the cost of user misery. While the severity of these effects remains debated, the potential for social isolation and depression is a growing worry. The convenience of digital platforms is undeniable, but concerns are rising about their potential negative impacts. We need a more critical eye towards the role of companies like Facebook and TikTok in shaping our society.²⁶

But isn't it nice to feel present, receiving a signal of presence, an indicator of existence, or at least an indicator that suggests the existence or proximity of someone or something? Online status indicators, activity feeds, notifications, and then live video as the proof of being, adding visual and auditory cues. Footprints, shadows, temperature changes, or air currents are missing. But it is there. There is something. Angels or ghosts interacting with us. It is this heavenly smile, which we once tried to remember, but now have stored forever in a vast cloud not to be forgotten.

25 David James, *The Most Typical Avant-Garde: History and Geography of Minor Cinemas in Los Angeles*, University of California Press 2005.

26 Geert Lovink, *Sad by Design. On Platform Nihilism*, Pluto Press 2019.

Can online video help us to understand the complexities of our world? Video in digital environments is not just a form of entertainment, a carrier for pleasure, but also a source of information and insight into our world. Of course, navigating and making sense of the vast amount of visual content and the multitude of available moving images seems beyond human reach. Nam June Park already made fun of academic research on video art as a whole, questioning the possibility at all because of the simply massive amount of artistic production already implied in his days.²⁷

There are certain visible operations that underlie online video and device culture. How can we understand the mechanics of online video platforms and the behavior of their users so that we can critically assess their impact on society and our world? Consequently, how can we re-engage with the structure of these assemblages, which surround us, embed us, and are built of a complex and dynamic network of actors, technologies, and practices?

Harun Farocki and his conceptualization of operational images or the *operative* might offer a framework for understanding how audiovisual media are used to shape our perception of our world. According to Farocki, operational images are created for a specific function or purpose, such as surveillance footage, military targeting systems, or medical imaging. They are very often produced and circulated within closed systems or specialized industries. They are intended to facilitate a particular type of action or decision-making process. Farocki was interested in how these images operate within more significant social and political systems and how they can be used to shape and control human behavior. He was particularly critical of how these images are used in the military and surveillance industries, where they are often used to justify violence or control populations. The study of operational images could help us gain insights into broader social and political contexts and the structures of power and control within contemporary society.²⁸

Video has transformed our understanding of reality. It is alive and gives us never-ending pleasures. The power of video lies in its ability to create immersive experiences that engage our senses and emotions. Video is giving data a face; through changing and moving micro-gestures, it humanizes our interaction with our digital double and naturalizes the strangeness of the underlying operation. Just as we need a face to identify a person (a subject, the other), we need visual clues, certain sensual experiences, to collaborate and engage with the world. And, there, video generates memory. Chunks of data are opportunities for engagement. The interface for engagement with the world is video as a temporary coded signal of images and sounds.

27 Nam June Paik, In: Jerome Robbins Dance Division, The New York Public Library. *Time and space concepts in music and visual art*, 1978 The New York Public Library Digital Collections, 1978, <https://digitalcollections.nypl.org/items/fa5d6120-645f-0132-6c6a-3c075448cc4b>.

28 Volker Pantenburg, Working images: Harun Farocki and the operational image, in Jens Eder, and Charlotte Klöckner (eds), *Image Operations: Visual media and political conflict* (Manchester, 2016; online edn, Manchester Scholarship Online, 18 May 2017), <https://doi.org/10.7228/manchester9781526107213.003.0004>, accessed 8 January 2025.

Is our brain recording our experiences? How do we recall our experiences? Are the memories faulty or incomplete? Can video replace or fulfill this task as a memory technique? Are we delegating the task of remembering? Is this interpassivity?²⁹

The technique of instant replay is added to our human abilities and to the storage of audiovisual sense or sensation equal experience, aiming to hold the moment in flow and to stop forgetting. With endless resolution and endless looks and views, memory machines assist the brain, or create intelligence, through the ability of memory devices. Video is a memory machine.

Cameras are body assets, modifications, and storage devices of experiences. Body and camera merge as technology, as device and spirit. Lens and sensor collapse with physical appearance and presence in multi-focality.

With computing and generative algorithmic processing, a device becomes self-reflective.

Cinematic is a reading, a temporal structure of simulation that constructs instant experiences and automated replies.

Engagement is random, instant, and simultaneous. No delay.

Video makes our images visible. As Ulus Baker noted, *Video* gives us our thinking back, which means video gives us our images back. We cite ready items of thought through a replay of video-like data and instantaneous sharing.

Yet, we are delegating our abilities to devices and machines. These devices and machines give us the safety of our stored memories and lives. They convince us that none of our moments is lost. The ocean guarantees us what our own body and soul only blurs. We can carry our youth and our beauty, our pleasures and desires for every instant of our lives, fighting to stop the irreversible, the aging, and the loss.

We need to know the stamp, the code, the time, the address to be able to replay. In the ocean of video data, everything can be recalled, but only a little, only the tip of the iceberg, of the near-lost moments and perhaps the just-present is available, fostering a continuous presence through mechanic imagination of a memory that algorithmic decisions foreground for us in our inability to keep track of and differentiate our self. Isn't that past always a wish, as with what is now and what will come?

29 Robert Pfaller, *Interpassivity: The Aesthetics of Delegated Enjoyment* (Edinburgh, 2017; online edn, Edinburgh Scholarship Online, 18 January 2018), <https://doi.org/10.3366/edinburgh/9781474422925.001.0001>, accessed 27 December 2024.

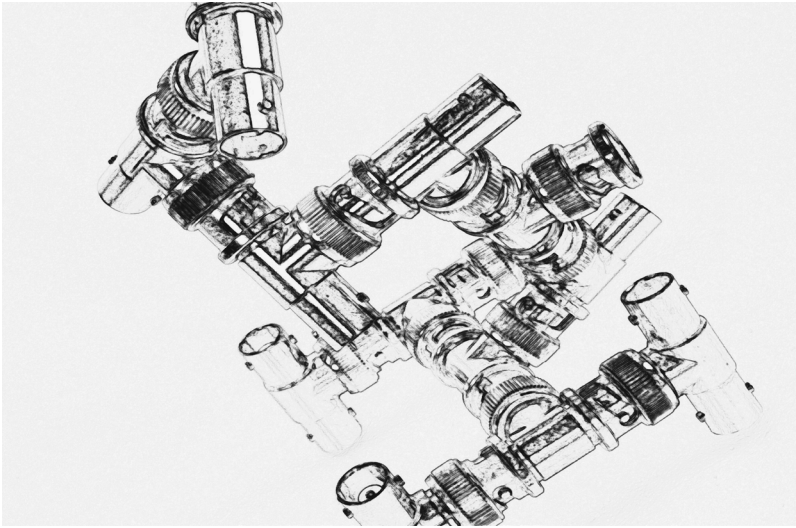


Fig. 3. NEILL-CONCELMAN-SALATI

Paul Neill was an American electrical engineer at Bell Labs in the 1940s. He is credited with helping to invent the BNC, TNC and Type N connectors used for microwave and RF communications. He joined Bell in 1916 after spending 12 years at the Westinghouse Electric Company. He retired from Bell on September 30, 1947.

Carl Concelman (December 23, 1912 – August 1975) was an electrical engineer who, while working for Amphenol, invented the C connector and teamed up with Paul Neill of Bell Labs to invent the BNC connector. (Foto: Carl Concelman, 1929)

Octavio M. "Tav" Salati was an American engineer, academic and educator. He served as Professor of Electrical Engineering at the University of Pennsylvania in the field of Electromagnetic Compatibility.

As the name suggests, the connector was designed collaboratively by Paul Neill from Bell Labs and Carl Concelman from Amphenol. The development, however, was based on an earlier design by Octavio M. Salati, who filed for a design patent in 1945, with patent #2,540,012 being granted in 1951. Accordingly, the BNC connector is considered an iterative improvement of Octavio's design, rather than an entirely new invention.³⁰

30 Powertec. <https://portal.powertec.com.au/equipment/rf-communications/rf-connectors/rf-connector-series/bnc>, accessed 12 March 2025.

LOG:: 03 ARRESTED DEVELOPMENT

C'était un endroit, le cinéma, c'était un territoire.

—Jean-Luc Godard¹

Cinematographic Imagery & Kernel Panic

One of the fascinations about the cinema is that when the lights went down, you're in the dark, director David Lean told Melvyn Bragg on ITV's South Bank Show in 1985. It's very private and I used to turn round and look at that beam going through the tobacco smoke. And it still holds a fascination for me. That beam showed me places I'd never thought I'd visit. It showed me characters that I'd never meet in my ordinary, dull, suburban life.²

Being without a body in the dark in a room with many others is the magic of cinema. It is only the screen and you, the moving pictures, your eyes, the brain, and its world. Just your mind floating. *Cinema* is a mode of watching the world un-viewed.³ You perceive cinema as a living arrangement of things and ideas.

Through the years, the technological, industrial, and social shifts in cinema and film have allowed seamless convergence with other media. Not only is film no longer *filmed* and does not need celluloid as a physical medium for transporting images or pictures, but cinematic presentation is no longer bound to a specific architecture and form of exhibition and consumption. *Cinema* moved to mobile phones and public facades.

The glamorous world of cinema, its stars and stories, have moved to streaming platforms with warehouse catalogs of items ready for continuous automated play in binge-watching. Platform films produced by streaming capital are entering world-renowned festivals and competitions in Berlin and Cannes. 2019, just before the pandemic, had already been declared the year of kernel panic by candy and popcorn-selling cinema owners in big Western cities. The *blue screen of death*, the sign of an ultimate system crash on a computer, increases worldwide fear. However, there are no safety measures for the termination of cinema as a building and location in the center of the city, a former dispositive which now appears publicly as abnormal or beyond common interest.

1 Engl.: *It was a place, cinema, it was a territory.*

2 Elaine Lennon, David Lean, *Historical Journal of Film, Radio and Television* Vol. 35, Iss. 2, 2015. Pages 382-384 | Published online: 22 April 2015, <http://www.tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1080/01439685.2015.1030221?scroll=top&needAccess=true&journalCode=chjf20>.

3 Stanley Cavell, *The World Viewed. Reflections on the Ontology of Film*, Harvard University Press 1979.

The move of transformed cinematic narrative fictional platform media into the glamorous hall of fame of the idealized memory of cinema dominated the Oscars in 2019. By 2024, after the pandemic and amid the debacle of generative AI, Hollywood (the classic cinema industry) and capital have found a way to get along with streaming platforms. As the hype around platforms slows, the world of cinema—its *creme de la creme*, its festivals, Cannes—is bringing back its old, recently retired Gladiators: the stars of what was once the new, innovative cinema of the 1970s (e.g., directors like Francis Ford Coppola), in a celebration applauded by the stars of social media, the serials of the streaming platforms and worldwide television, whom nobody knows anymore by name besides their social media followers.

In his book on 1990s Turkey, Dogan Gürpınar argues that media at the time manufactured lasting stars.⁴ These stars remain prominent in entertainment even today, three decades later. However, after the 2000s, especially the 2010s, fame has become fleeting. Social media, now abuzz with Cannes 2024, thrives on fleeting images. Fame is instant but quickly forgotten, swept away by autoplay. At Cannes 2024, the afterglow of films is replaced by selfies with fading stars, a snapshot of a moment and place. The promenades are now dominated by Turkish TV stars and influencers plucked from global streaming platforms. Even cinema itself has become a self-referential fiction, a realm of a thousand rehashed stories.

How to debug cinema? Could cinema be an institution in which the people is missing, recalling Deleuze's note on the creative act?

And what relationship is there between human struggle and a work of art? The narrowest and for me the most mysterious relationship of all. Exactly what Paul Klee meant when he said: "You know, the people are missing." The people are missing, but at the same time, they are not missing. The people are missing means – it isn't clear, it will never be clear — that the fundamental affinity between a work of art and a people that does not yet exist.⁵

Le cinéma. Truffaut and Godard called for an ontological framework—cinema as a formal description of our existence, an unfulfilled role up to the present. What happens today to cinema happened nearby in a similar way in the late eighties, with the birth of cable television and the increasing commodification of Hollywood. The TV series *Dallas* and *Dynasty* were the newborn rising stars. Televisual consumption was understood to replace the seventh art. But, as put simply by Godard, *la télévision fabrique de l'oubli, alors que le cinéma fabriquait des souvenirs*: television produces forgetting while cinema produced memories.⁶

4 Dogan Gürpınar, *Küstah ve Cüretkar: Türkiye'nin Doksanlı Yılları*, Telematik Kitap 2022.

5 Gilles Deleuze, "What is the Creative Act?", Conference given on 17 March 1987 in the Tuesday lecture series at the FEMIS film foundation. Revised transcription and translation by Charles J. Stivale. <https://deleuze.cla.purdue.edu/lecture/lecture-01-21/> Last accessed 9 January 2025.

6 T. Murray, R. Célestin and E. DalMolin, Introduction. *Sites: The Journal of Twentieth-Century/Contemporary French Studies Revue d'études Françaises*, 4(2), 2000, 243–248. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10260210008456029>.

At Cannes 2024, cinema, the original grand narrative, celebrated its survival. In reality, outside of the social media sphere of selfies and instagram stories

[...] Cinema should have remembered that people still go to spas, temples, churches and still crave for a little bit of insulation as long as it is coupled with mystery, sour suspense and emotion. The cinema theatre could have grown up from a popcorn restaurant to so many other things. But now we have a television at a home and a television in a darkened room. We have home theaters at all because cinema theaters are nothing more. Even commercial jets offer a more adventurous experience. [...] ⁷

The size of Ankara's Roman bath confirms the principle of simple pleasures... Moviegoers in 2023 showed they crave originality. Sequels and recycled stories just aren't cutting it anymore. To compete with home entertainment and streaming giants, cinemas need to offer something new, exciting, and bursting with ultimately fresh ideas, and not an attempt to sell to a young generation what has already been sold to an older generation as innovative (Barbenheimer).

The magic of cinema lies in transporting us to unseen worlds, introducing us to unique characters and concepts, and sparking emotions: always a first time. It's about authenticity, not manipulation. It's about helping us understand the world around us, not simply telling us what to think. We crave beauty, desire, chills, and giggles: a full cinematic experience, a story to live.

Remember those films that had everyone talking? The ones that stayed with us long after the credits rolled, followed by inspiring parodies and endless discussions? These movies didn't shy away from difficult topics. They sparked essential conversations on a grand scale. Films like *Straight Outta Compton* challenged perceptions of race relations, *Inside Out* tackled mental health in a rarely seen way, and *Wolf of Wall Street* made us question modern cultural excesses.

Today, cinema feels scattered and unfocused. Yet, the need for powerful, culture-shifting blockbusters is greater than ever. These can unite us, spark emotions, and leave a lasting impact on cinematic art for years to come. ⁸

The Dream Machine Stutters

Cinema, once a wellspring of fresh dreams, seems to have stumbled. The stories have grown monotonous, mirroring a homogenized reality. We've either created a version of ourselves based on the silver screen, or the silver screen now reflects a version of ourselves we've built. This is cinema's failing. Obviously, the transportive power of cinematic dreams can't be replicated on a tiny phone screen.

7 Abhinav Prayas, Cinema. From the Museum of Vestigial Desire. 2013. <https://museumofvestigialdesire.net/books/cinema>, accessed 12 March 2025.

8 Brian Raftery, Could This Be the Year Movies Stopped Mattering?, Wired. 26 August 2016 <https://www.wired.com/2016/08/do-movies-still-matter-2016/>, accessed 12 March 2025.

Cinema boasts a history intricately woven with technology and society. From its very birth, cinema has been entangled with commerce. The Lumiere brothers, Edison, even Georges Melies – they were all as much *exploiters and businessmen* as they were inventors. Cinema is more than just a technical marvel; its development is a complex dance with the evolution of electronic image reproduction. It's a story of multiple forces, not isolated inventions. It's a commercial practice of movement generation and continuous, attention-grabbing production.

Cinema's Complexities

Cinema has indeed a complex relation to its own history. Jean-Louis Comolli proposed the concept of *signifying practice*, acts of meaning-making that people engage in, to address the intricate relationship between cinema and its history. Comolli argued that a materialist understanding of cinema's history is impossible without acknowledging this concept of a practice.⁹ In a further theoretical approach, Jean-Louis Baudry explored the implications of the basic cinematic apparatus and questioned whether its technical aspects inherently produce specific ideological effects, and if these effects are shaped by the dominant ideology of the time.

These theoretical approaches question meaning-making, ideology, social aspects, and subjectivity within cinema. Such exploration furthermore prompts a reevaluation of technological communication systems, similar to what Bertholt Brecht and Raymond Williams did with radio and television. Williams and Brecht both argued that these technologies were initially developed without predetermined content. Engineers in Germany in the late 1920s and early 1930s tried to imagine, in their journal, the possible use scenarios for a new system of television to be established, but were far from content programming forms.¹⁰

Häufig wird die Ansicht vertreten, dass es für eine erfolgreiche Einführung des Fernsehens genügt, wenn die Apparatur genügend weit durchgebildet ist, die Schaffung von befriedigenden Fernsehprogrammen biete dan keine Schwierigkeiten mehr. Diese Ansicht würde, nachdem sich jetzt der Tonfilm durchgesetzt hat, richtig sein, wenn der Fernseher ein Ersatz des Lichtspielhauses wäre, und eine gleiche Leistungsfähigkeit erreichen könnte, wie die Einrichtung für unmittelbare Projektion. Beide Voraussetzungen treffen jedoch nicht zu.¹¹

9 Teresa de Lauretis and Stephen Heath (eds.), *The Cinematic Apparatus*, New York: St. Martin's Press, 1980: 6/7.

10 Andreas Treske, *Fernsehen - Eine Zeitschrift - Ein Verein: Beiträge Zur Fernsehdiskussion Aus Der Zeitschrift "Fernsehen" Von 1930 Und 1932*. Forschungsschwerpunkt Massenmedien u. Kommunikation an d. Univ., Gesamthochschule, 1986.

11 Rudolph Thun, *Die Bedeutung des Programms für einen Erfolg des Fernsehens*, In: Treske, Andreas. *Fernsehen - Eine Zeitschrift - Ein Verein: Beiträge Zur Fernsehdiskussion Aus Der Zeitschrift "Fernsehen" Von 1930 Und 1932*. Forschungsschwerpunkt Massenmedien u. Kommunikation an d. Univ., Gesamthochsch, 1986. p. 34: It is often held that for the successful introduction of television, it is sufficient if the equipment is sufficiently developed, and the creation of satisfactory television programs will then no longer pose any difficulties. This view would be correct, now that sound films have become widespread, if television were a replacement for the cinema and could achieve the same performance as direct projection equipment. However, neither of these assumptions is true. (Translation by the author).

The *cinema-machine* itself, considering the conditions that enabled its development, is shaped by its ongoing changes, adaptations, and realignments. Stephen Heath highlights how it brings together the technical and the symbolic, the technological and the ideological, creating the current ambiguity surrounding the term *apparatus*.¹² The concept of the classic cinema experience, with its specific architecture, technology, and storytelling format, might not be the only way to think about film and cinema. Movies have constantly pushed boundaries and redefined this structure. From the pioneering work of Abel Gance with his multi-screen displays to experiments with duration and audience interaction, the cinema of attractions, expanded cinema, and exhibition-based cinema movements, film has ventured far beyond the darkened theater, challenging traditional models of representation, creating new ways for audiences to engage with film, and breaking with (and developing) conventions and practices.

Jean-Louis Baudry offered a concept, *dispositif* (derived from the Latin *dispositio*, for arrangement), that delves into the psychological impact of cinema on viewers. Drawing inspiration from Plato's allegory of the cave and Freud's theories of dreams, Baudry finds parallels between these experiences and the way cinema affects us. For him, the *dispositif cinema* is a complex web formed by social norms, technical aspects of filmmaking, and the viewer's own imagination.

The *dispositif* is understood as the nexus of the spatial and technical arrangement of the apparatus in cinema, which constitutes the cinematic perception with each screening (and beyond). Independently of the content conveyed by the media, an ideological effect develops from the *dispositif*, which aims at both the impression of reality, the quality of experience, and the suggestion of participation. In other words, it essentially determines cinematic perception.¹³

The elements of the *dispositif* include, among others, the dark cinema room, the placement of the audience in it (axial alignment), the film space inherent in the image, and so on, which together form a *dispositif* network in connection with the mental disposition of the audience. The concept brings together elements that were previously considered separately, such as cinema technology, cultural traditions of perception and the work of psychological processing.

What is the pleasure of cinema? What desires does it satisfy, and what is a possible explanation for the reality impression in cinema?

The concept of *dispositif* helps us to understand cinema as a complex network of diverse elements, including technology, institutions, discourses and cultural norms—in short, the unsaid as well as the said. This network shapes how we experience film. If you remove the key element of physical location from this network, cinema opens up new possibilities.¹⁴

12 Teresa de Lauretis and Stephen Heath (eds.) 1980.

13 Knut Hickethier, Dispositiv Fernsehen, Skizze eines Modells, In: montage AV. Zeitschrift für Theorie und Geschichte audiovisueller Kommunikation, Jg. 4 (1995), Nr. 1, S. 63-83. DOI: 10.25969/mediarep/483.

14 Valie Export. Expanded Cinema as Expanded Reality. Senses of Cinema. October 2003. https://www.sensesofcinema.com/2003/peter-tscherkassky-the-austrian-avant-garde/expanded_cinema/.

We can project films onto houses, bodies, or even ourselves, blurring the line between representation and reality. This shift can lead to a more immediate and subjective experience, transcending the limitations of celluloid and objective storytelling. ‘The world is no longer simulated; rather, the possibility of producing world is demonstrated.’¹⁵

It is valuable to revisit the works and writings of the 1970s and inhale its push for a transformative character of cinema that might encompass new technologies like video, computers, and even light itself. Electronic media allows cinema to move away from commercial, narrative formats and to create experiences where the image itself becomes an active element in space, rather than simply representing something else.¹⁶ Peter Weibel, Gene Youngblood, and Valie Export envision an *expanded cinema* that draws inspiration from various art forms and media, going beyond the traditional film experience.¹⁷ This vision, which took shape in a pre-digital, analogue era of video, foresaw the major expansion that cinema would undergo in the decades to come, fueled by technological and societal changes. As the fight for audiences continues, waged with television and platforms, cinema constantly needs to reinvent itself, demonstrating its remarkable adaptability.

The ever-growing landscape of video (moving imagery) media makes it difficult to define clearly what cinema is. The classic definition is lost. Vertov’s Kino-eye and Deleuze’s Brain Screen¹⁸ don’t seem to be sufficient theoretical frameworks or tools anymore. Cinema needs to maintain specificity and find a way to distinguish itself from other media, proving its unique value proposition against global technologists and capitalists.

The traditional way we understand cinema (the *classical dispositif*) faces a crisis similar to the breakdown of authority and origin associated with lists and maps.¹⁹ The concept of *World Cinema* appeared when film theory and culture began to question the very nature of cinema. This questioning can be seen as a problem of organization: where does cinema fit as a medium, an institution, a collection of films? *World Cinema* offers a solution by proposing new ways of categorizing films. On one hand, *World Cinema* can be seen as an attempt to restore a unified view of cinema as a whole. It helps redraw the map of cinema, encompassing its experiential aspects, emotional impact, and cultural significance. Whether we discuss the crisis of the *classical dispositif* or the various ways to categorize films, we’re essentially engaged in a process of *spatial ordering*—creating systems for understanding cinema.

15 Valie Export 2003.

16 Valie Export 2003.

17 Gene Youngblood, *Expanded Cinema*, 1st ed. New York: Dutton, 1970.

18 The Brain is the Screen. Interview with Gilles Deleuze. Originally published as ‘Le cerveau, c’est l’écran’ in *Cahiers du cinéma* 380, February 1986, the result of a roundtable with Alain Bergala, Pascal Bonitzer, Marc Chevre, Jean Narboni, Charles Tesson and Serge Toubiana on the occasion of the publication of Deleuze’s *Time-Image* (Minuit, 1985), translated by Marie Therese Guirgis. <https://www.diagonalthoughts.com/?p=2252>, accessed 12 March 2025.

19 Vincent Hediger, What Do we Know When We Know Where Something Is? World Cinema and the Question of Spatial Ordering. Screening the Past. <http://www.screeningthepast.com/issue-37-aesthetic-issues-in-world-cinema/what-do-we-know-when-we-know-where-something-is-world-cinema-and-the-question-of-spatial-ordering/>, accessed 12 March 2025.

On the other hand, categorization is just the beginning. It's a stepping stone towards deeper analysis—an intermediate stage. The real goal is to ask productive questions and move beyond an initial framework to explore the underlying relationships that shape film. Rather than what or where is it, the question is, what will come next? How can we use our accumulated knowledge of the boundaries of cinema for a cinema to come?

The Location of the Moving Image

In this line of inquiry a question surfaces: Where is the location of the moving image? Does anybody ever ask such a question, or precisely this question? Why ask this question? Is there a need for this question, or does it amount to asking where 'cinema' is? There is a place of a lost cinema in a desert, where somebody speculatively built a gigantic open air cinema, which slowly now fades away. Google Earth still shows you its traces in 2024.²⁰

But, actually the question is asking for an object: the moving image. It does not ask where this object is, but rather indirectly looks for its location. The word *location* from the Latin 'locus' refers to a particular point and, therefore, to a specific coordinate. That means an exact point and coordinate in an exact descriptive system of an actual space or environment. Why is this in question?

Several assumptions are at play here. The most basic is that the moving image is an object, and that this object has a location. A location is a place or a point in space. Therefore, the moving image has a place, owns a place, occupies a place, or is placed somewhere. Overall, it is related to a place.

The most straightforward, most general answer would be that this place points to what is called cinema, architecture, or a room, or it points to an object itself, a television, an object placed in a room, or any kind of screen anywhere by itself or attached—that is, any other object with an ability to comfort, carry, or host the moving image. Such spaces or locations are not cinemas.

Cinema and TV don't describe a specific or precisely defined location, which would be *the* cinema or *the* TV, and would there be unique. They don't lead towards the *locus* but to a *locus*. However, a *locus* named cinema leads to a specific place described as a cinema, which might be unique. The cinema, like the theatre, is a building in a city. In Europe, it is a building in the center of a town. The cinema can be a part of a building or included in a building belonging to a shopping mall, a multipurpose center, a museum, a place where people come together or which many people frequently use, a place where a collective viewing can take place and be experienced.

The home is a place for the Television. An object listed in a household register for insurance purposes, attached to walls or placed, set on stands, amid expanses of furniture.

20 Messyessy. The Abandoned Secret Cinema of the Sinai Desert. 8 February 2018. <https://www.messyessychic.com/2014/03/06/the-abandoned-secret-cinema-of-the-sinai-desert/>, accessed 12 March 2025.

Cinema and Television are seen in direct relation to a viewer. The viewer meets with the moving image in the form of presentational architectures or presentational objects—a device, a carrier with visible moving imagery, other carriers with invisible, boxed, or stored moving images. It is a physical activity and experience. Cinema and Television are old systems in established places with *informed* conditions. Film, tape, and cassette are carriers of the moving image, which need a kind of specific machinery to make the moving image visible.

In the 1980s, film history, as taught at numerous film schools, was a list of films manageable with clear genres and style, relatively easy to curate in an educational framework.

Expanded Cinema Stretch

What expands cinema, moving image, and video media is the incorporation of new technologies like immersive sound, IMAX, 3D, computer-generated imagery (CGI), and, lately, generative AI, including spatial explorations in AR, VR, and MR in production and experience. More easily accessible mobile technologies and a new culture of creation allow more people to produce and share films. Affordable filmmaking tools and online distribution platforms have empowered audiences to become creators, producing such fan-made content as remakes, recuts, and mashups. Consumption has created influencers in smaller and smaller social media environments. Audiences are no longer passive consumers. Online platforms allow for discussions and interaction around films, shaping their reception while making them, at the same time, a product to be capitalized upon. Time spent in participation is valuable, marketable and generates Transmedia storytelling, sequels, adaptations, remakes, and participative forms with growing blogs, social media outlets, and new spaces embedded in cinematic universes for sharing as integral to the production process and the underlying expanding business model.

Cinema needs to embrace its evolving nature, redefine itself in the context of technologically-driven media developments, and utilize this drive to expand its expressive potential while staying true to its core identity and maintaining its connection to the real world. >[*Cinema*] is the only aesthetic language suited to the post-industrial, post-literate, man-made environment with its multidimensional simul-sensory network of information sources.²¹

The *fusion of aesthetic sensibility and technological innovation* produces a shift from representing phenomenal reality to representing human consciousness.²² Based on assumptions from the experimental film environment of the 1960s, Gene Youngblood imagined a cinema machine that aimed at intensifying the level of the cinematographic experience through greater involvement of our senses—more deeply engaging, for example, our vision through ultra-high-definition resolutions, or our hearing through complex sound environments.

21 Francesco Casetti, *The Lumière Galaxy: Seven Key Words for the Cinema to Come*, Columbia University Press, 2015. JSTOR, <https://doi.org/10.7312/case17242>. Accessed 9 January 2025: 102 -110.

22 Youngblood 1970.

Cinema is no longer rendered optical, it becomes a natural environment in which our entire body is engaged

Paratexts accompany other texts to offer a broader discourse and new interpretations of these texts. They are supposed to intensify the textual experiences and provide the possibility of a personal path in the industry-controlled version—a fake cause of being scripted in advance.²³ Hollywood, however, absorbs home producer practices, using media expansion in the home or grassroots productions as quasi-open sources, and operates through a gift economy, as fans do.

A film is part of a cinematic universe. It could be born in any theme park, continue as a video game, generate a wide range of products linked to its narrative world, run on a platform as a series, and finally return to cinemas in town as a film, or in shopping malls as a comic or novel. Simple examples are the universes of Marvel and Disney or movies like *The Pirates of the Caribbean* and *Star Wars*.

The 1970s also predicted the merge with computer and digital technology. The digital image supports the creation of algorithmic-based worlds, leaving any mold of the real world aside. Through the digital, film ceases to be a direct witness of real events.

Cinematic narration continues to function as a model.²⁴ The shift to digital inaugurates a new mode of representation. Even when all images are artificial and algorithmically generated, it is the process through which we, the audience, understand what is shown to us as real, and this is the same as the process set into motion by the cinematographic picture. Digital images have allowed cinema to expand and acquire new possibilities. However, it must still define where it is or what cinema is.

The immersive documentary *32 Sounds* by Sam Green²⁵ and *Eno*, the generative documentary on Brian Eno by Gary Hustwit in 2024²⁶ are remarkable steps in a direction of newness in bringing *sensory experience, aesthetic sensibility and technological innovation* to global attention, reformatting the documentary narrative format.²⁷

In its most and least problematic context, its most profound and its poorest, the domain of cinema is nothing but moving images displayed on a screen. Maybe it will be wise to follow Serge Daney and choose the term visual rather than image.

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23 Jonathan Gray, *Show Sold Separately: Promos, Spoilers, and Other Media Paratexts*, NYU Press 2010.

24 D. N. Rodewick, *The Virtual Life of Film*, Harvard University Press 2007.

25 32 SOUNDS. A film by Sam Green. 2022. <https://32sounds.com/>.

26 Eno. A film by Gary Hustwit. 2024. <https://www.hustwit.com/enno>.

27 Kevin Nguyen, *Eno documentary: behind the first generative feature film* - The Verge. <https://www.theverge.com/24197153/enno-documentary-generative-film-gary-hustwit-interview>, accessed 18 August 2024.

The Snackification of Cinema?

What if, from its very inception, cinema was—and still is—precisely a way of organizing masses of human beings into processes of imagining, producing, and exchanging stories and images that, at the same time, solicit our sense of futurity while foreclosing our hopes that we might ourselves be agents of that future?

Cinema makes us modern, and it does so by announcing to us that the future is already here. Naturally, then, what usually follows this future-that-is-already-here is nothing short of apocalypse—an apocalypse we can only imagine resolving itself in our favor through some heroic return to a recognizable, if reconfigured, *Edenic*, *Shangri-la*, *Heaven-on-Earth*, a long-gone past.

In a 2014 talk at the German Film Academy, the film producer and screenwriter James Schamus argued that cinema is a double-edged sword: it allows us to dream and fantasize, but the very technology behind it reflects the potential for destruction.²⁸

Why, he asks, does nobody seem concerned that Georges Méliès' *A Trip to the Moon* ends in violent war? Similarly, why do so many films, including *Interstellar*, depict the future as destruction and a return to our past social structures, often emphasizing rural life? Cinema's focus on individual heroes reinforces the idea that we cannot envision a collective future, one we build together. Eisenstein already detected a fascinating contradiction in Hollywood's rise. D.W. Griffith's films showcased the towering skyscrapers and bustling capitalism of New York City. Yet, the characters seemed trapped in a narrow, almost Dickensian mindset. Modernity existed alongside a surprising parochialism. Fast cars zipped by, yet traffic crawled, and the high-rise apartments held on to small-town sensibilities, with doilies and faux-Victorian furniture. Siegfried Kracauer, influenced by Marcel Proust, took a different approach. He viewed the camera as a *death-machine*, in a positive light; by capturing and presenting the world, it inevitably alienated and objectified what we see. However, this *death* of our usual perception allowed us to notice the overlooked and forgotten aspects of our surroundings. The camera forced us to see anew. For Kracauer, cinema's photographic nature was the key to breaking free from the limitations of traditional art. Traditional art, he believed, limited the world through rigid structures, with tragedy as the prime example. Cinema, even when striving for tragic closure, had a built-in escape. It could capture the mundane and the overlooked alongside grand narratives, creating a unique balance.

In the digital age, Kracauer's valued balance between recording reality and shaping it through form is fading. The photographic, indexical function of cinema, the ability to capture the world, appears to be disappearing. To truly envision a future for cinema, we need to break free from simply recycling a decaying past. We need films that genuinely contemplate the future, not just regurgitate tired tropes.

28 James Schamus, 23 Fragments on the Future of Cinema, German Film Academy 2014, <http://filmmakermagazine.com/92531-23-fragments-on-the-future-of-cinema/#.VMlwBYznG2>, accessed 12 March 2025.

Cinema's economic model has undergone a dramatic shift. For decades, ancillary revenue streams—from video rentals to streaming—were the lifeblood of the industry. Theatrical releases were often loss leaders, advertisements to be consumed later on smaller screens. Can the future of cinema simply be about selling overpriced snacks to a captive audience? Currently, the *No Outside Food or Drink Allowed* policy seems like a key pillar of the business model. Is cinema destined to just be about gathering large crowds to consume popcorn and watch screens?

Historically, cinema thrived as a community event. Double features, newsreels, and trailers created a shared, plural experience. The assumption that cinema starts with a singular theatrical experience followed by a digital afterlife is a recent invention.

One defining characteristic of cinema is that a film's conclusion is often preordained. Unlike television, which can endlessly adapt and evolve, cinema starts with an ending in mind. In a world of endless content, is this inherent finitude a death knell for cinema?

'It is not that film producers create cinema, but rather that cinema, as an ideology and institution, produces cinema producers.'²⁹ Movies aren't just about visuals, sounds, and emotions. They also create a complex behind-the-scenes network. This network involves administrators who translate money, intellectual property, and creative work into protocols and relationships. These protocols and relationships are then embedded within the movie itself, designed to travel across different media platforms. Think of it like a hidden language—a network of co-production treaties, credit lines, contracts, licensing deals, special accounts for holding funds, talent agreements, and even marketing tools, all working together to create and target audiences.

Traditionally, cinema expertise is seen as existing on a spectrum between *artistic merit* and *commercial success*. This creates a false dichotomy. The assumption is that focusing on artistic merit means the film won't make money, and vice versa. We see producers as the ones who have to manage this *art vs. money* balancing act.

However, the reality is that cinema itself exposes this as a myth. *Art* and *money* aren't opposites; they actually depend on each other. Art, when present in a world where everything can be reduced to a price tag, allows us to imagine human creativity as something *priceless*, something beyond mere exchange value. At first glance, cinema might appear as a vanishing pool for financial resources. Investment pours in, and the films themselves become part of our cultural landscape. This artistic aspect of cinema seems to reject the idea that money is the only way to envision the future. This perspective is an illusion. It reinforces the notion that a world dominated by money, practicality, and logic is the only *real* world. This *real world*, in reality, can often feel like a dystopian nightmare of exploitation, destruction, and a warped sense of reality.

29 Schamus 2014.

The logic used by governments to monitor threats is eerily similar to how companies like Netflix predict user choices. The effectiveness of this method relies on users believing they have free will, while their options are subtly manipulated. This mirrors corporate-controlled elections, where voters are presented with limited choices. As these predictive technologies become more refined, the future of cinema seems tied to a shrinking window of possibilities. The very concept of a future built on diverse choices seems to be replaced by a series of immediate decisions. The idea of a *cinematic citizen* who can watch films without being tracked and predicted is a point of resistance against this reality. Cinema can be a tool to imagine and resist the predicted future.³⁰

We are Visually Sophisticated and Visually Illiterate

Film blogger Tony Zhou published a video analyzing director Michael Bay's signature style, which he humorously calls *Bayhem*. Bay's technique includes rotating shots, multiple moving elements, and low angles, which Zhou argues are often used without a clear purpose, resulting in a lack of substance and meaning in the story. Zhou believes this style is popular because people can process visual information quickly but need help to think critically about what an image means. Regular consumption of images and photographs does not necessarily or naturally develop visual literacy. It needs to be taught. People are visually sophisticated when using various mobile phone apps to achieve particular effects like nostalgia, or to emulate film or force focus on an element. Still, they often need a deeper understanding of why they are using these techniques. Visual literacy is not just about appreciating the technical aspects of photography, but also about understanding the context and meaning behind an image.

'It's fun to be sophisticated, but it's dumb to be illiterate.'³¹

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On Cinema Alone or the Uniqueness of Cinema

The cinema was only really alone, truly alone, between the arrival of the sound film and the arrival of television, which more or less applies to what André Bazin called the cinema of reality (even if his description has assumed many more definitions than he could have imagined).³²

Despite having different goals, cinema and television developed in tandem. Television's roots go back to the silent film era, or deeper in time, with advancements then happening in the US, England, and Germany. While sound film initially overshadowed television's potential, both technologies continued to evolve. Unchallenged, cinema would reign supreme.

30 Schamus 2014.

31 Allen Murabayashi, We are Visually Sophisticated and Visually Illiterate. PetaPixel. Published on July 15, 2014, <http://petapixel.com/2014/07/15/visually-sophisticated-visually-illiterate/>, accessed 12 March 2025.

32 Raymond Bellour, in: Alphaville: Journal of Film and Screen Media, Issue 5, Summer 2013.

The fusion of image and sound, encompassing dialogue, effects, and music, birthed a revolutionary *realism* unlike anything ever experienced. Television, with its distinct apparatus, had yet to emerge as a competitor. Sound film altered fundamentally our experience of moving pictures. Voice and sound became *a new dimension of the visual image*. Sound 'makes visible in itself something that did not freely appear in the silent film, effectively denaturalizing' the visual image.³³ The established order is disrupted; the image is no longer simply *seen* while speech is *read*. Instead, the *speech-act becomes visible at the same time as it makes itself heard*, and the visual image itself becomes *legible as such*.³⁴ This shift from classic to modern cinema, as Deleuze terms it, involves a *new use of the talking [sic], sound and the musical*. Sound becomes more independent, with a tendency towards *free indirect discourse*,³⁵ where the image carries the weight of meaning rather than the spoken word.

Such transformation elevates the image's role; it becomes *readable* in a new way. The *speech-act* itself becomes *an autonomous sound image*. Bellour further connects this development to television, suggesting that television represents a *second stage* of sound film. While television enabled this evolution, it failed to exploit its own creative potential, necessitating cinema to provide a *pedagogical lesson*.³⁶

To understanding cinema's unique qualities, Bellour argues for a perspective rooted in the personal experiences and deep love for film held by French cinephiles, particularly those associated with the influential magazine *Cahiers du cinéma*. Following the ideas of André Bazin and the *Politique des Auteurs* approach, this movement championed Hollywood's classical era and the second stage of sound film. Filmmakers like Rossellini, Renoir, Hitchcock, Hawks, Welles, and Bresson became central figures in their discussions. The journal's focus reflected a growing recognition of film's distinct artistic character. This awareness coincided with a decline in cinema's dominance as a medium, leading to a heightened appreciation for its unique qualities. Filmmakers like Jean-Marie Straub and Jean-Luc Godard aimed to preserve the distinctiveness of cinema and film.

Bellour's concept of *cinema, alone* is intricately linked to the notion that cinema's unique identity began to fade as its self-awareness and appreciation blossomed. The core idea is to safeguard cinema's unique character across all its transformations and challenges. Such a perspective raises a critical question: how does contemporary cinema relate to its original form? The introduction of sound, for instance, brought the element of time to film, and filling this time necessitates a viewer capable of piecing together the film's information as a whole.

33 The Deleuze Seminars. Cinema and Thought / 18. APRIL 16, 1985, <https://deleuze.cla.purdue.edu/lecture/lecture-18-5/>, accessed 12 March 2025.

34 Gilles Deleuze, *Cinema I: The Movement Image*. U of Minnesota Press, 1986-89. Page 232.

35 Deleuze 1986.

36 Bellour 2013.

Chris Marker's *Level Five* may not be his best film, but it is, for Bellour, significant in its own right. It is the first example of a film that creates an intimate relationship between memory, image creation, and the computer as a machine and *dispositif*, through the practice of the filmmaker Marker. This film opens a wound in the *cinema-dispositif* and places itself within it.

Level Five was made simply and modestly, using a single room and no crew. Marker claims that this approach allows for a new intimate, solitary filmmaking practice. He further claims he opened up . . .

one of several possible kinds of cinema, that's all. . . You could never make Lawrence of Arabia like this. Nor Andrei Rublev. Nor Vertigo. But we possess the wherewithal—and this is something new—for intimate, solitary film-making. The process of making films in communion with oneself, the way a painter works or a writer, need not be now solely experimental (qtd. in Walfisch).³⁷

While working on his CD-ROM project *Immemory*³⁸, Chris Marker also explored the concept of cinema's future within the CD-ROM's *Cinema* section. He ponders the possibility that cinema may have reached its full potential, paving the way for something new. Marker quotes Jean Prévost, who suggests death isn't a tragedy, but rather a reunion with all that's been loved and lost. In the same way, cinema's potential demise could be seen as a vast memory, an honorable fate.

Even though cinema may seem lost, it's constantly reignited by exceptional films that continue to be made.³⁹ These films deliver on the core promises and possibilities that cinema, as a unique medium, has always offered. I am thinking of Peter Tscherkassky's film work, or the 2023 *Anatomy of a Fall* by Jutine Triet, narrating and performing so-not-seen kinds of cinema.

37 Raymond Bellour, Cinema, Alone/Multiple Cinemas, Alphaville: Journal of Film and Screen Media. Issue 5, Summer 2013. <https://www.alphavillejournal.com/Issue5/PDFs/ArticleBellour.pdf>, accessed 12 March 2025.

38 Chris Marker, *Immemory*, CD-ROM, Film 1997.

39 Bellour 2013.

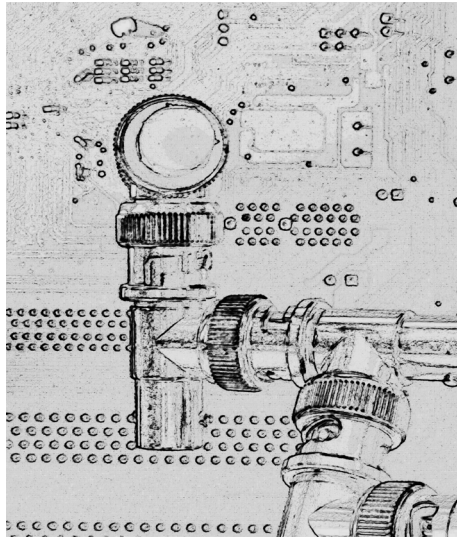


Fig. 4. AMPHENOL

Amphenol Corporation is a major producer of electronic and fiber optic connectors, cable and interconnect systems such as coaxial cables.[3] Amphenol is a portmanteau from the corporation's original name, American Phenolic Corp. Amphenol was founded in Chicago in 1932 by entrepreneur Arthur J. Schmitt, whose first product was a tube socket for radio tubes (valveholder bases). Amphenol expanded significantly during World War II, when the company became the primary manufacturer of connectors used in military hardware, including airplanes and radios. From 1967 to 1982 it was part of Bunker Ramo Corporation. The company sells its products into diverse electronics markets, including military-aerospace, industrial, automotive, information technology, mobile phones, wireless infrastructure, broadband, medical, and pro audio. Operations are located in more than 60 locations around the world.

LOG:: 04 MELODY OF LIFE

Uncle Wendel, Uncle Wendel! Just look at the soap bubbles, the wonderful colours!
But where do the colours come from?

—Kurd Lasswitz, On the soap bubble

We are in open circuits.

—Nam June Paik 1970

The concert. Tuning in. Chorus. Noise, cacophony. Mushrooms making music, spores jumping. Atoms spinning. A fly. Dancing all night long. Spin me around. Sound and color. Synesthesia. Elan Vital. Energy. Excess.

My essay *Video Theory* started with a dream-like imagination of all videos ever made in the world seen together as a blue, not gray, ocean. I did not reflect on sound, on any sound related to this imagination of an ocean of video. Of course, this might first appear as chaos, a cacophony, a wildness, disturbing and maybe even painful. The amount of video now surrounding us furthermore calls to mind rather a tsunami, not a storm: gigantic waves, regional platform floods.

If videos have a single sound, patterns of videos together could realize melodies. Positive imagined. As videos are not seen together, as they develop in time, even considering that they are built on simultaneity and the instant, still, over time they create a melody of life. So, wouldn't it be nice if all videos create a kind of music? Don't they hold the potential for a symphony representing the world? That might be the music of the planet, the music of our world and the music of us, representing a unique and ever-changing experience, a symphony of blue. But, maybe we need to be alien to this world to identify this sound and music, the signal in the ether.

Video Worlds / Video Sphere

The imagination of a music of the world of all videos and moving images, or *visuals* together over time, recalls the concept by the biologist Jakob Johann von Uexküll of *Umwelt* and his extensive use of musical metaphor.¹ Influenced by Leibniz and his idea of the individual as entangled in a network of relationships and perspectives through which one defines oneself, and whose manifold reflections in consciousness constitute the fullness of his worldview, Uexküll described the plan of nature as constituting a kind of melody, a *Melody of Life*.

1 Kalevi Kull, Jakob von Uexküll: An introduction, *Semiotica*, vol. 134, 2001, pp. 1-59, <https://doi.org/10.1515/semi.2001.013>.

Every animal has an *Umwelt*, surrounding and enclosing it, much like a soap bubble. Each animal has its own *Umwelt*, and one soap bubble may enclose many others within it or be enclosed in other, larger bubbles. Unlike Leibniz's monads, these bubbles have windows, or at least intersect and interact with each other in concrete ways. The *Umwelt* is not merely given, but rather produced by the animal through the functioning of its body, its sensory and instinctual apparatus, and the objects it encounters.²

A *monad* (from the Greek *monas*, *unit*) is an elementary individual substance that reflects the world's order and from which material properties are derived. In Leibniz's system of metaphysics, monads are essential substances that make up the universe, but that, lacking extension in space, are thus immaterial. Each monad is a unique, indestructible, dynamic, soul-like entity.³

The bubbles, the *Umwelt*, around each animal may not be monads. Still, they exist in a pre-established harmony in the composition of nature. This harmonious composition constitutes the plan of nature, or a natural musical score. Deleuze characterized Uexküll as a *Spinozist of affects*.⁴ Every animal behavior signifies—and this signification differentially constitutes—its *Umwelt* as a meaningful world for it and others capable of interpreting the signs, animals, or even humans. Every animal has sensors that report the state of the *Umwelt* and effectors that can change parts of the *Umwelt*. Uexküll distinguished the effector as the logical opposite of the sensor or sense organ. Sensors and effectors are linked in a feedback loop. Sensor input is processed by a *Merkorgan* (memory organ) and effectors are controlled by a *Werkorgan* (working organ). The modern term *sensorimotor* used in enactive theories of cognition encompasses these concepts.⁵

Uexküll proposes a distinction within the *Umwelt*. The *Umgebung* refers to the distant aspects of the external world, or the *surroundings* as a whole. In contrast, the *Innenwelt* (inner world) represents the immediate sensory data picked up by the organism. This sensory data is considered the only unfiltered reality directly accessible to the organism. The organism must learn during infancy how the indirect and processed information of the *Umgebung* relates to the direct and unprocessed information of the *Innenwelt*. This relationship between these two aspects of experience is significant for understanding later theories of embodied cognition. This idea connects to Kant's distinction between phenomena, or beings of sense, and noumena, beings of understanding or reason. However, it's derived from the limitations of our senses, not philosophical arguments. The concept we call a *feedback loop* is similar to what Uexküll called a *function-circle*. Here, *circle* seems to represent a broader concept like *system*.

2 Brett Buchanan, *Onto-Ethologies: The Animal Environments of Uexküll, Heidegger, Merleau-Ponty, and Deleuze*, State University of New York Press, 2008, 223pp., ISBN 9780791476116.

3 Leibniz. *Monadology* (1714).

4 Brett Buchanan, *Onto-Ethologies: The Animal Environments of Uexküll, Heidegger, Merleau-Ponty, and Deleuze*, State University of New York Press, 2008, Reviewed by Robert Vallier, DePaul University 2009.06.08, <https://ndpr.nd.edu/reviews/onto-ethologies-the-animal-environments-of-uexk-252-ll-heidegger-merleau-ponty-and-deleuze/>.

5 Jakob Johann von Uexküll. Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jakob_Johann_von_Uexküll, 09.01.2025.

Interestingly, his term *melody* refers to something close to what we now call an *algorithm*. To link to Uexküll's *Umwelt* concept, we need to have an environment with movement and flow, a signal of change, and a perception of surroundings to act upon. For Uexküll, species are constitutive of the milieus they occupy. In this milieu, objects are opportunities for engagement.

Music is the nature of life itself.

Video has gone from being a way to store events (like on old tape) to being a central part of our lives. It's not just a tool anymore, it's a world around us. We're constantly surrounded by videos. We are living in a video sphere. *Spheres* is an intrigue concept by Peter Sloterdijk to explain our digital world.⁶ Think of Earth's layers: the solid ground, the layer of life, and the atmosphere. Sloterdijk talks about these and other *spheres* like the *noosphere* (the sphere of reason, Teilhard de Chardin) and the *semiosphere* (the sphere of signs and communication, Juri Lotman). Our digital world, as *infosphere*, connects for him to the old idea of the *firmament* - a giant dome in the sky where God lived. Just like the breakdown of the firmament led to the modern world, Sloterdijk suggests our technology might be creating a new kind of *firmament* around us, one that's constantly changing and growing.

Thinking about video as part of this *infosphere*, *firmament* or *Umwelt* makes the *visual* seem like a living, breathing thing. It's constantly evolving and interacting with itself, just like a complex organism we are observing. It makes us curious to know what takes place in its dynamics—how waves are created and constantly evolving. There appears to be a system that can build and maintain itself constantly, an autopoietic system, as Niklas Luhmann described.⁷ *Autopoiesis* means *self-creation* in Greek. The term was originally used for living things like cells to point to how they constantly replace parts while keeping their overall form. Two Chilean biologists, Maturana and Varela, explained, in 1972, autopoietic systems as self-contained networks. These networks use their elements to rebuild themselves and create the space where those elements exist. In simpler terms, the system makes its own building blocks and uses them to remain itself. This concept can be applied beyond biology. Luhmann argued that societies are also autopoietic. They function by creating their own elements, like temporal communication events, from within their existing structures. These events are fleeting moments, not permanent things, temporal and ephemeral. For a society to keep existing, it needs to constantly generate new elements. These communication events don't have meaning on their own, but gain significance through their connection to other communication within the system. Think of a conversation: a single word doesn't make sense by itself, but within a flow of conversation it contributes to the bigger picture.

Luhmann argues that social elements, like people and actions, aren't the building blocks of society. Instead, he proposes communication events as the key element. Societies, in essence, are self-sustaining networks of communication.

6 On Life in the Infosphere (Jacob Burda, Luciano Floridi, P.Weibel, P.Sloterdijk, J.Jarvis) | DLD16, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DbQC4WfXxjw>, accessed 12 March 2025.

7 Clemens Mattheis, The System Theory of Niklas Luhmann and the Constitutionalization of the World Society, *Goettingen Journal of International Law* 4 (2012) 2, 625-647.

Social systems use communications as their particular mode of autopoietic reproduction. Their elements are communications which are recursively produced and reproduced by a network of communications and which cannot exist outside of such a network.⁸

Breaking away from a common view of communication, Luhmann draws on Karl Bühler's ideas and defines communication as three elementary things working together: what's said (information), how it's said (utterance), and how it's interpreted (understanding).

Information, according to Shannon and Weaver, is choosing something to say from all the possibilities. Every act of communication picks a message from all options. Utterance is why and how something is communicated. It's like picking a specific way and reason to say something out of all the possibilities. Understanding is the difference between what's said and how it's said. To understand something, you have to separate the message itself from how and why it's delivered. Understanding is also choosing a specific way to interpret that difference. Instead of focusing on what the speaker meant, Luhmann flips it around: the meaning is ultimately decided by how it's understood. He says communication works *from behind*, meaning that understanding shapes the meaning, not the other way around. This is like the principle of hermeneutics, where the listener, not the speaker, decides the meaning. The listener's understanding limits the possible meanings, no matter what the speaker intended.⁹

Video vs. Cinema (Film Again)

Sound and music drive online video. Sound drives the TikTok platform par excellence. Video is related to music, objects of engagement, and the environment or milieu as physical spaces. Digital moving images are closer to sound than to visual images. They appear as a time-based signal of presence, simultaneity, and instants. Playing video is a flow of time, similar to a melody. A single video might be a single sound, even a note, but we realize a melodic form in all videos. This is an abstract layer of perception, a transformation outside of the experience focusing on flow and autoplay, instantly swiping away the current video.

The emergence of video sparked a dramatic change in how we experience images and their relationship to time. Unlike film, video emphasizes the concept of *the instant*. A cinematic image, despite depicting movement through a series of connected frames, remains a fixed composition—a captured and frozen moment. It's also a delayed experience, viewable only after processing. In contrast, video's ability to record and display images *almost* instantaneously creates a closer connection to real-time events. This immediacy strengthens the inherent link between movement and time within the video itself.

The concept of real-time in video is intertwined with the idea of simultaneity. Filmmakers like Godard, Coppola, and Greenaway explored this notion in their work. In contrast to film as cellu-

8 Niklas Luhmann, *Social systems*, Stanford, Stanford University Press 1995 [1984].

9 D. Baecker, *Why Systems? Theory, Culture & Society*, 18(1), 59-74, 2001, <https://doi.org/10.1177/026327601018001005> p66, accessed 12 March 2025.

loid, video allows further a dissimulation of the beginning and ending of a shot. Thus did video technology, even in its early analog development, dissolve temporal and spatial unity. Video allows one to intrude, to interrupt and reformat, the streaming of flows. It defines a capacity to act on time and in relations between flows, between different rhythms and *durations*. While cinema relies on editing to connect images and sounds, with a (sometimes implicit) sense of narrative continuity even through cuts, video can handle actions *simultaneously* without requiring cuts themselves.

Real time is synchronous time. My time here and there, in different places, now in this instant, either slow or fast, either jumping, disconnected and continuing, fluid, streaming.

Nam June Paik has pointed out continuously that video is not about physical space, but about time. His work challenges the idea that video is just a way to record things at home. Video, especially in its early analog form, could create entirely new visual experiences.

Chris Marker experimented with storytelling and memory. He used the past not just to reminisce, but to think about the future. He manipulated real footage to make a point about historical events. His techniques are all about using technology to tell stories. Marker's last film, *Levi's* (1996), uses all sorts of images: still photos, film clips, computer graphics, video footage, found footage, interviews, articles, and even a character named Laura (played by Catherine Belkhodja). Laura talks to an unseen man who might be dead, or it could be Marker himself filming her, or even the audience. The film starts with a close-up of a hand using a computer mouse, and then we see the computer screen with city lights overlaid on a computer-generated head. In his own unique vision, Marker mixes real and imagined elements to create a new kind of cinema, one that tells stories in a new way and uses new kinds of images that are neither completely true nor completely false. Marker's methods point to the future of digital storytelling, even as it references the very beginnings of cinema, where moving images were first created from still photographs.

The digital confronts us with a new form of realism. Images and sounds are built based on algorithms processed by a machine, a black box of code, learning and traversing human data and information, presented or embedded in new video media, a motion signal derived from mathematical formulae.

The still image, the photographic image, the film frame: all are always related to a specific time continuum, and never to the now. Even if the film plays now, what is reproduced is a recorded performance, not a new performance; the object performs the new, which refers to the operation but not to the content, not to what is inside the frame or what is projected. What is projected is a specific registration; it does not develop something new. It is limited, and has borders. It has a defined, fixed body; the photograph is an attempt to resolve a specific condition and keep this condition existing.

The feed or the algorithmic timeline cannot be compared with the filmic or cinematic timeline; it is not object-based and, therefore, lacks borders. The algorithm constantly evaluates, observes, and receives; hence, it is never cinematic. Cinematic is a specific style, a form, a format, or a phrase: narrative and structure. The web, the digital sphere itself, develops non-cinematically.

Video is about being present. It emphasizes event character and participation. Cinema includes only indirect participation as an inactive receiver: passivity. Video is a feedback system that suggests input and reverse response. The signal produces a constant now in a defined area of variability; the definition itself is variable.

Music Silence

This reminds me of something Theodor Adorno said about popular music. He thought popular music was too standardized, meaning all its songs sounded pretty similar. There were no surprises, because we're trained to expect certain things from popular music. For Adorno, classical music was the opposite. It required you to pay close attention, because every single note mattered in the whole piece.

Basically, the music industry has dumbed things down. People might be really into their favorite bands and know all the details, but overall, the experience is pretty shallow.

Imagine our phones and computers as windows into a world dominated by video. Streaming services and social media are constantly showing us videos, creating an environment where everything is a moving image. These videos are not just things we watch; they are connected to each other and can even react to what's around them. The way these platforms use algorithms to recommend videos is becoming more and more uniform, which is similar to what Adorno worried about with popular culture: that everything would become the same, which is a recipe for, in Benjamin's thought, *poverty*.

The Idea of Silence and the Digital Frame in Video

Imagine incorporating the ideas of composer John Cage into the way we think about video and the dynamics of the *visual*. Cage's concept of silence isn't total quiet, but rather a system that allows for its own natural sounds to emerge. It's akin to a kind of artificial awareness that comes from letting things be.¹⁰ In the future, composers would work with tiny fractions of a second, similar to how film editors use frames. Music could be created like a movie, with a system responding to what happens around it. The composer could even incorporate unexpected events into a piece.

10 David Goldberg, EnterFrame: Cage, Deleuze and Macromedia Director, *Afterimage*, vol. 30, no. 1, 2002, pp. 8-9, ProQuest, <https://www.proquest.com/scholarly-journals/enterframe-cage-deleuze-macromedia-director/docview/212114507/se-2>, accessed 12 March 2025.

Thinking about video in the digital world, it's like a complex dance of events, constantly changing at incredible speeds. Digital information is made up of tiny, distinct pieces, similar to the sprocket holes on film. The frame in a movie is, for Gilles Deleuze, a system holding lots of information. Each frame captures a moment with various elements like actors, setting, and lighting. This information can be changed by how the shot is framed, by transitions, or by light and shadow. Even the camera angle and filming techniques affect what information the frame carries. This information can also be dynamic, with changes in light and movement. Deleuze added the idea of the *out-of-frame*: things existing just outside the shot that still influence what we see.

An environment that's both open and controlled is created, where things can be copied, contained, yet also manipulated. For Cage, the frame was a way to structure music, not with traditional notation, but by borrowing ideas from film editing. It could be a single *unit* containing the entire piece, or a series of frames building the whole thing. This frame is flexible, able to hold everything in one shot or be spread across many. It's not the standard frame you see in a movie, but an expanded idea that reaches beyond the visible to a larger, virtual space.

The traditional rectangular screen format is limiting and outdated. Unlike paintings or photographs, there's no frame in real life. This rectangle is just a human invention, based on how we see the world when we hold our head still. If we created the frame, we can get rid of it. There's no reason to be stuck with this rectangular format in film. It's time to break free and explore new ways of showing the world on screen.¹¹

Discussions of framing, of course, run across the history of audiovisual media technologies. Television imposed its format on films until television itself became, through higher resolutions and LED technology, more horizontal, rendering the absolute and rigid square obsolete. In the struggle for audiences, cinema expanded the frame horizontally, establishing super formats like cinemascope and others. And not so many years ago, flexible, rectangular, hand-sized-build smartphones established vertical rectangular formats for social media practices and stories, a mode of the perceptible that is explicitly about mobile media, while television continues to move towards scale and home cinema likeness. It is a matter of the distribution of audiovisual forms, which becomes less observable if the presenting or the streaming screen format can be automatically detected and if the source allows reformatting. The transmission system automatically adapts the content to the available framing device, which means matching the available surface.

In the Cageian context of an environment, as described essentially by Uexküll, the presence and absence of something becomes a particular concern. Presence or absence allows for chance operations in the environment.

11 Peter Greenaway, *Toward a re-invention of cinema*. Variety Cinema Militans lecture at the Dutch Film Festival on Sept. 27, 2003. <https://variety.com/2003/voices/columns/toward-a-re-invention-of-cinema-1117893306/>, accessed 12 March 2025.

The verticality of the frame limits the space to the subject of interest and emphasizes presence inside the frame. Absence is the new norm. Cinema generated the possibility of objectivity, while smart phones produce selfish subjectivity, controlled by design.

The Age of Now

How do we understand the dynamics of contemporary life, particularly regarding the role of technology in shaping our perception of time and space? Paul Virilio's answer might be the *Instant*.¹² We live in a time of instant information. News, ideas, and data travel almost instantly around the globe. This has changed the way we experience the world. We can be connected to anything, anywhere, at any time. Virilio believes this *instant* world creates a new reality. In this reality, distance and time don't matter as much. The physical world and the digital world blur. We crave speed and efficiency, and everything needs to be instant. This rush towards immediacy, however, has downsides. It leads to a world dominated by technology, where people feel disconnected and isolated.

There's a flip side to speed, though. The faster we go, the more exhausted we can become. It's like trying to run too fast; eventually, you have to stop.

Buckminster Fuller used the idea of *frequency* to describe the world. He saw everything, even solid objects, as made up of tiny, rapid events. Imagine the white foam of a wave – it looks solid, but it's actually lots of tiny bubbles moving very quickly. He believed that everything, even things we can't see, works this way.

Cinema's frame has an eternal character. Similarly, a computer file stored on a hard disk or a server seems to have an eternal character. Frame and file are both objects, which resist the ephemeral of the flow. Both don't deliver the possibility of the act in an instant. They are too slow.

Video, on the other hand, is an electronic means of capturing and transferring experience. It's faster than any other visual media because it deals with signals, not objects. Video isn't concerned with creating a perfect image; it focuses on the flow of information itself. Cinema, in contrast, is like a game played with images, a specific style with its own rules.

We tend to be too attached to the traditional image-frame of cinema. But the future lies in temporary audiovisual experiences, events built from signals, instants. These signals can carry vast amounts of information, like a stream of points or pixels, creating a new kind of visual experience and immediacy. Even signals without a clear message can be important. They are part of the overall flow of information.

The video artist and scholar Paul Ryan was not at all interested in the image. Like his friends and colleagues in the early 1970s around *Radical Software*, he was interested in video as signal and as ecological system:

12 Paul Virilio, *The Futurism of the Instant: Stop-Eject*, Polity, 2010.

I would avoid the term visual to describe video. You can see a bottle of perfume, but sight is not the sense it really affects. . . Video is about perceiving events with the nervous system, not visualizing in a pictorial way.¹³

Exploring technology for environmental and local awareness, Ryan merges video art and environmental education in his work and conceptual writing. Analog video technology can be seen as a means by which individuals attend to their local environments. Ryan developed an *Earthscore* curriculum and a New York City *Ecochannel* for community members to continually monitor their watersheds, as well as other educational projects to make non-private ecological information available anytime and anywhere:

Give them videotape, audiotape, and film and let them find forms for their own experience and their own environs rather than let the teacher take the data, inform it, and present it as a precooked packet to be warmed over and consumed in the classroom. Self-structuring of unprepared data develops the capacity to be your own information composer.¹⁴

Though written around 1970 and limited by the technology of the time, Ryan's vision for video's potential to democratize information is strikingly relevant today. Widespread access to new technologies could empower people to document and share local cultures, fostering a sense of environmental stewardship. The rise of online platforms and social media usages aligns perfectly in theory with an idea where individuals map, record, analyze, and try to raise awareness about their local environments.¹⁵

Earthscore, published by NASA in 1990, is designed to produce video content that reflects environmental realities and fosters behaviors that align with Earth's natural balancing mechanisms, ultimately supporting global environmental efforts. Its core concept lies in viewing *Earth* as a complex, self-regulating cybernetic system. Natural systems possess inherent mechanisms for maintaining balance and adapting to changes through feedback loops. Environmental problems often arise from intricate interactions between human and natural systems. *Earthscore* emphasizes understanding these interactions to develop effective solutions. By adopting a holistic perspective, cybernetics encourages us to consider the entire system, rather than isolated components. Conceptually, Ryan's *Earthscore* curriculum blends Gregory Bateson's cybernetics (with its focus on interconnected and self-regulating systems) with Charles Sanders Peirce's semiotics (a theory of signs and communication that's deeply sensitive to the context or environment of the communicative act) to create a novel system for environmental videography, as a way of making the acquisition of environmental knowledge more engaging, interactive, and impactful.

13 Orit Gat, History Class: Paul Ryan Interviews for Grey Room, <https://rhizome.org/editorial/2011/sep/28/recent-history-class-paul-ryan-interviews-grey-roo/>, accessed 11 March 2025.

14 Paul Ryan, Video Mind, *Earth Mind: Art, Communications, and Ecology*, a collection of essays from 1968 through 1991, 1993: 31.

15 Christopher J. Keller and Christian R. Weisser, eds., *The Locations of Composition*, Albany: SUNY Press, 2007, Place-Blogging, Geoannotation, and other examples of Environmental Knowing via Locative Media (198/199 Chapter: From Site to Screen, From Screen to Site).

Video is a powerful tool for transmitting information based on a *shared perception of environmental realities*, rather than a sole reliance on language. Video offers a unique way to model reality compared to language—an alternative way and form of communication beyond language, beyond control and domination, which threaten our planet's well-being.¹⁶

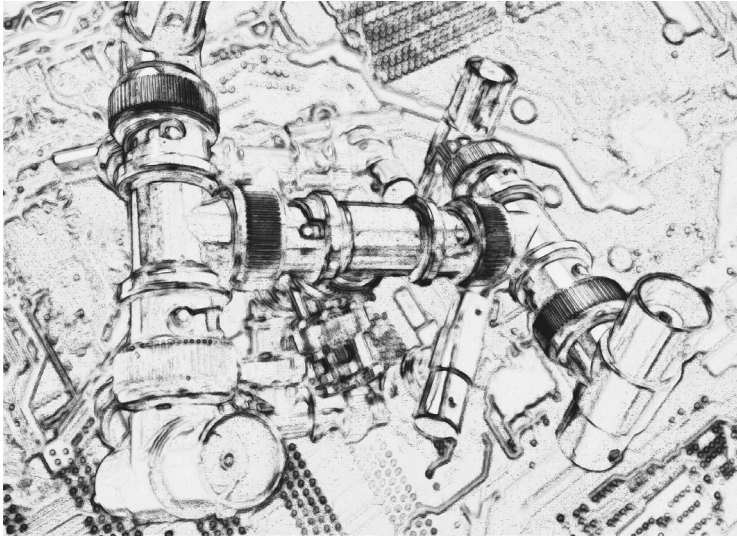


Fig. 5. TWIST AND LOCK

A series of connectors used for connecting thinnet coaxial cabling to various networking components. BNC connectors use a twist-and-lock mechanism that provides a secure connection between network cabling and components. BNC connectors are typically used on 10Base2 Ethernet networks. The different types of BNC connectors include the following:

- BNC cable connector: Soldered or crimped to the ends of a thinnet cable
- BNC T-connector: Used to connect a network interface card (NIC) to a thinnet cable segment
- BNC barrel connector: Used to connect two pieces of thinnet cable
- BNC terminator: Provides a 50-ohm termination for the free end of a thinnet cable⁴

Often the BNC connector is specified for operation at frequencies up to 4 GHz and it can be used up to 10 GHz provided the special top quality versions specified to that frequency are used.

However it is wise to fully check the specification.

16 Elizabeth Swanstrom, *Animal, Vegetable, Digital: Experiments in New Media Aesthetics and Environmental Poetics*, The University of Alabama Press, 2016: 106/107.

Basic BNC Specification Summary - Parameter - Specification - Cable Type Coaxial - Securing - Bayonet fit - Typical operating frequency range 0 - 4 GHz Diameter (Male) 14.0 mm / 0.570 in - Diameter (Female) 11.1 mm / 0.436 in¹⁷

17 The Network Encyclopedia, <http://www.thenetworkencyclopedia.com/entry/bnc-connector/>.

LOG:: 05 ALL FLOWS - DANCING ÜBER

Camera as Fonteyn, operator as Nureyev would be ideal - a dance partnership capable of any vector of graceful motion within the range of the operator's hands, arms, and legs.

—Garrett Brown

You spin me right round, baby

Right round like a record, baby

Right round round round

—Dead or Alive, 1985

An ancient bell rings: πάντα ῥεῖ—all flows. This is how the pre-Socratic philosopher Heraclitus described the essence of the universe. Later, Plato would rephrase this and say that a man can never enter the same river twice. What holds for the river must also be true for man: humans change; they do not stay the same over time. Every perception, every experience, changes how we think. Experiences themselves also change.

Substance - Substantial Motion

We see video as an emanation, a surplus that adds to the world (emanation, from the Latin *emanare* meaning *to flow from*). Still, we live in Video Worlds or *Umwelten*, which define how we perceive and interact with it. We understand the world by simply following sensations; watching or viewing entails following stimuli in various frequencies or instants. Philosophically, the substance of Video is not the image at all, not a picture, or a cinematographic definition.

Azadeh Emadi explores the essence of digital video through the lens of Mulla Sadra's philosophy, emphasizing an "inside-out" perspective.¹ She argues that while Gilles Deleuze acknowledges the image's composed nature (molar), he also recognizes the underlying *becoming* at the pixel level (molecular). Similarly, Sadra's view posits stability and form as arising from motion, aligning with Deleuze's concept of becoming.

Unlike analog film, with its static frames creating the illusion of movement, digital video presents a single, constantly evolving image. These internal changes, driven by pixels, reflect a relationship with the external world. The code is informed by the filmed object, causing movement and changes within related digital elements.

1 Azadeh Emadi, Reconsidering the Substance of Digital Video from a Sadrian Perspective 79
Downloaded from http://direct.mit.edu/leon/article-pdf/53/1/75/1579572/leon_a_01602.pdf, accessed 26 April 2024.

Pixels, like us, possess an inherent *destination* that encapsulates the universe's destinations. As microcosms, they contain the *seminal reasons* of the larger world, and their *substantial renewal* mirrors the renewal of all existence.

This concept of *Substantial Motion* suggests that digital video, with its unified yet ever-changing pixels, has the potential to more truthfully represent reality. It exists in infinite time, forming a moving image unit while its internal elements constantly transform.

In contrast, the identifiable frame of analog film creates a sense of representation, separating us from the image itself. It becomes a window to observe, not a portal to explore. This *looking at* approach closes interpretive possibilities. Emadi proposes *looking into* the image, experiencing it, and discovering its potential connections to other entities, beings, and images. From this perspective, digital video challenges our perception of a stable, identified image. Our own perception creates the division between entities in the world, including the distinction between an image as representation and the object it represents.

From Motion to Movement

Birds never fly backwards. Aristotle viewing the world and reflecting on its choreographies, describes an exponent when he concludes that *In nature nothing has a movement backwards*. Aristotle's *law of movement* has its *actuality in the consequent*, and applies *alike in figures and things animate*, constituting a series, *each successive term of which potentially contains its predecessor*.² Movements are world making.

We are moving. Objects in a frame are moving. Through montage and editing in film, movement takes place between framed images. The recording, streaming camera is moving. Lenses are moving, zooming in and out. The signal is moving. Data is changing. Everything moves.

Cognitive neuroscience sees human experience as a form of relational experience:

We live in relation with other people, objects, landscapes that are present in our real world, but also live in relation with people, objects, landscapes that come to us within the imaginary worlds displayed by the arts.³

Does each form of movement imply a particular form of a relation between us, others, objects, screen, screen objects and so on?

An illustrated letter, a single folded page sent by Jean Tinguely to a 16 year old, rubbed superhero's, unfortunately lost colorful small feathers, found objects, and a confirmation of obsession with movement.

2 Progression of Animals, 706b30, in Thomas Moynihan, Spinal Catastrophism, Urbanomic 2019.

3 B.M. Stafford, Crystal and Smoke: Putting Image back in Mind, in: A field guide to a new field ... 2011, <https://humanitiesfutures.org/papers/visions-body-embodied-simulation-aesthetic-experience/>, accessed 12 March 2025.

Fascinated by his sculptures, I had written to Museum Ludwig in Cologne to forward a letter to Jean Tinguely and received a surprisingly personal answer. Movement, since Tinguely's response has followed me as a central element in my career as a filmmaker, editor and producer, as an artist and writer, but also, and mainly, in my continuing reflections on video, cinema and the post-digital. Tinguely's kinetic art not only just represented movement: crazy, silly, and ironic. His sculptures embodied fundamental ontological and social processes, emphasizing dynamism, change, and the breaking down of static forms. An interesting parallel seems to be appearing in the world of online video and social media platforms. Short, looping videos capture our attention through constant motion, a digital obsession. TikTok in particular has become known for its fast-paced, constantly moving content. Users scroll never-ending streams. An aesthetic of instability, a constructive instability, dominates our platform culture. Obviously, maybe even in different realms, this digital kinetic obsession might echo Tinguely's mechanical curiosities. The worlds of his kinetic sculptures and those of online videos would seem to be miles apart, but the embedded principle is a fascination with movement and its ability to captivate, surprise and convey meaning, ephemerally, pointlessly, but fundamentally: a continuum of artistic and cultural exploration of motion.

Curiosity

Cinema, and I always come back to this at once relative and solid definition of the *visual* (*moving images*), is an in-depth study of movement. Video is its fluid state, component, or appearance, just as ice is a specific state of water (though here, a solid state). The history of cinema is, at the start, critically tied to the study of movement. The invention of all the tools that led to the making of cinema aimed, it seems, simply at the analysis of the body. Wasn't it one of the first curious questions answered by a camera recording: a gun shooting a sequences of images confirming that the legs of a horse sometimes don't touch the ground? The cinematic apparatus realizing itself now in video or the visual was designed as an investigation into optics, bodies, motion, and physiology. Movement is the first motivation for technological development.

From 1895 until 1900, films of fact, or 'actualities', capture the imagination. Running up to five minutes, films of fact focused on everyday events such as New York in the Blizzard. Filmmakers began to record specific events, for example, The Kaiser Reviews His Troops and The Spanish Coronation. The novelty of movement yielded to a desire to edify, and the use of the camera for documentation was explicit in these early films (see Jaeds 1979: 2-3). Film became recognized as a tool capable of recording events that could be shown again and again to those who were unable to witness those events in person. All of these films were shot in a single take, that is, in one camera run.⁴

4 Sheron R. Sherman, Documenting Ourselves: Film, Video, and Culture, University Press of Kentucky 1998.

The cinematic apparatus not only captures the movement of objects before it; it also includes two essential kinds of movement in itself: it moves and the recording medium moves, transporting fixed images in time. The recorded movement is an illusion created by the recording and transporting of still images, which are nothing else than frozen photographs of motion, instants in sequence. The discovery of the moving motion picture camera sets in motion the aesthetic and ethic of cinema and the cinematic apparatus. The moving picture camera allows one to take control of the viewer's perspective. The movement of the camera introduces a new powerful relation between the subject and the camera. Movement by itself creates significance. The camera moves and changes the perspective of the viewer, and the camera frames and shows us only a part of an object/subject. There is something outside the frame, what the camera doesn't show, and there is something inside, which is related to it. The outside and the inside create a dramatic attraction. Object movement and camera movement create a rhythm, a fluent and magic atmosphere. All together it's the cinematic combination of time and space. Its part of the language, the syntax of film.⁵

The moving camera adds *kinaesthetic*, bodily, tactile cues as well as the sense of balance and gravity. The visual appears live. The camera motion is bodily, the experience mobile. There is the affect of an intentionality and subjectivity, and a bodily appearance. While obviously being in the real world a viewer might subjectively locate herself aesthetically in a film or movie, and relate to the cinematic visual.⁶ We are there. We are given the missing information for shape, size and layout, and depth of space. The camera itself might become like another person. It is connecting me, making me involved, taking me by the hand. The fluidity of movement gives me a sense of immersion. And when it shakes, it is, of course, my over-excitement.

Cinematography is a writing with images in movement... Robert Bresson defines cinematography as the act of filmmaking.⁷ The Russian filmmaker Dziga Vertov idealized the camera to the extreme. He called the moving camera, in combination with editing, the *kino-eye*. The camera is superior to the human eye, able to see at long distances, to film in slow or fast motion, taking extreme perspectives, going where we can't. In the editing process, scenes from different times and places could be cut together and united. The *kino-eye* was liberated from the confines of time and space. A *kino-eye film* was able, Vertov believed, to reveal a deeper level of truth in the world than was normally perceived by the all too imperfect human eye.⁸

I am kino-eye, I am a mechanical eye. I, a machine, show you the world as only I can see it. Now and forever, I free myself from human immobility, I am in constant motion, I draw near, then away from objects, I crawl under, I climb on to them. I move apace with the muzzle of a galloping horse, I plunge full speed into a crowd, I outstrip running soldiers, I fall on my back, I ascend with an aeroplane, I plunge and soar together with plunging and soaring bodies. Now I, a camera, fling myself along their resultant,

5 Andreas Treske, Curiosity. 2003 www.kasputnik.com/thoughts/curiosity/curiosity2.html.

6 Uri Hasson, O. Landesman, B. Knappmeyer, et al., Neurocinematics: The neuroscience of films, in: Projections: The Journal for Movies and Mind. 2008 ; Vol. 2.: 1-26.

7 Robert Bresson, Notes on the Cinematographer, New York : Urizen Books 1977.

8 Kevin Macdonald and Mark Cousins, Imagining reality: the Faber book of the documentary, Faber and Faber 1996.

manoeuvring in the chaos of movement, recording movement, starting with movements composed of the most complex combinations. Free of the limits of time and space, I put together any given points in the universe, no matter where I've recorded them. My path leads to the creation of a fresh perception of the world. I decipher in a new way a world unknown to you.⁹

Camera movement has, within the means of cinematic design, an extraordinary position: when and how the camera moves might have a lot to do with this position, and from what perspective and with what kind of aesthetic the viewer shall experience the film is central to design and expression.

Is the world passing by or are we in the middle of everything? Does the audience experience the scenes as a quiet, slow river or a high-dynamic, wild ride? A basic assumption of cinematography is that the camera determines a way of seeing things.¹⁰

A Phone in a Cage

Digital filmmaking allows for extreme long takes or plan sequence, while at the same time generating an ocean of ultra-short videos. Cage's frame might include a simple long movement of either an object inside, outside or with, or a multitude of movement, changing signals throughout time and space.

Movement might be a matter of walking or stabilization, hand held or technically supported, attached to a cage, gimbal or drone, extended image making with mechanical and optical extensions or generated and enhanced signals.

What is the difference between an amateur and a professional camera? The answer is very visible: the amount of manual control and the supporting tools. Actually, the professional camera doesn't hide its lens; it's visible and controllable to give the most possible effect on the image.

Who Else Dreams of Flying?

The opening of *Shining*. Aerial Shots. *Dies Irae*, the music accompanying. Many movies establish location in their first moments of screening through aerial imagery. Across film history, this practice claims that *you are here, in the space of the movie*.

Aerial views of landscapes, people and objects moving and following from above had long been out of the reach for the general public. We move our bodies about on the ground, on feet, on wheels, motorized, on water in boats, in the air by plane.

9 Kino-Eye: The Writings of Dziga Vertov. by Dziga Vertov (Author), Kevin O'Brien (Translator), Annette Michelson (Introduction by). University of California Press. 1985.

10 BIRDMAN vs VICTORIA - camera movement and the restoration of the plan-sequence or long take, unpublished presentation by Stephan Vorbrugg and Andreas Treske, Goethe Institute Ankara, 14 May 2017.

But, we need to rent a plane or a helicopter, or, as in Cappadocia, book a touristic hot air balloon tour for a day to see from above. Sight-seeing adventure.

The earliest forms of aerial imagery predominantly centered on urban landscapes, whether through *bird's eye* perspectives or the pioneering aerial photographs taken by Felix Nadar and his son in the mid-1800s, as they captured Paris and its surroundings from their balloon. With World War I and finally World War II, aerial photography brought to the foreground the broadest scale of devastation. The imagery of destroyed cities, bombed from the air, dominates the archives of aerial photography.

Even as everything seen by the cameras on planes was being documented and as photographs from the air were analyzed and archived, looking and seeing did not necessarily entail the discovery of objects on the ground. Despite photographing Auschwitz from the air already early in World War II, the Allies were not aware of the concentration camp. They simply were not looking for it, as Harun Farocki showed in detail in his documentary.¹¹ The aerial images are flat.

In a form of movement and aerial photography combined, a boom in the availability and use of drones has led to the ability to easily produce videos from above. Drones, or unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs), include a diverse range of remotely controlled or autonomous flying devices. These can take the form of fixed-wing aircraft, resembling small airplanes, or multi-rotor systems similar to helicopters. Modern drones can be operated by mobile applications, wearable devices, or specific dedicated ground control stations. Drones typically include cameras and sensors, enabling them to capture and transmit or record visual data in real-time. For military and public safety purposes, drones serve crucial roles in surveillance and emergency response. They are used for agricultural tasks, mapping, and disaster management, as well as, of course, news coverage. Event organizers employ drones to monitor crowds and provide live streaming capabilities. Real estate agents leverage them for house sales. The television and film industry embraces drone technology to capture dramatic aerial footage. For tourism, the use of drones to produce videos has generated a large amount of visually appealing footage of various destinations, attracting much attention on social media.

The COVID-19 pandemic transformed urban landscapes into strange empty spaces, captured through contrasting technological perspectives. Drone footage documented deserted metropolitan areas, showing sterile streets and vacant public spaces from above. These aerial views presented cities in an almost surreal state, simultaneously familiar yet altered, creating a visual record of an unprecedented moment in urban history.

These drone perspectives stood in sharp contrast to the intimate, close-up views of life during lockdown captured through video conferencing platforms like Zoom. The pandemic created a visual dichotomy: the vast, empty spaces seen from above versus the confined, personal spaces viewed through screens. Within these aerial views, occasional signs of life—whether human activity, wildlife, or vegetation—served as reminders of the persistent vitality beneath

11 Harun Farocki, *Images of the World and the Inscription of War*, Documentary Film, 1988.

the apparent desolation, creating a complex interplay between the built environment and natural elements that continued to thrive. If drone footage documented a sense of loss and disconnection, narratives emphasized emptiness. A video from New Delhi titled *Incredible India: Before and After Lockdown* suggests a transition from a past of contact to a future of absence. What this footages does not capture is the underlying health crisis: the virus itself remained invisible, creating a disconnect between visual documentation and actual threat.

These videos excise the relational by displacing it onto the technological and the visual, but they also displace the profound social horror and hysteria of not seeing or knowing where the virus is: it is nowhere, elsewhere, everywhere, impossible to visualize with the human eye.¹²

Time Suspended

In 2014, British filmmaker Danny Cooke released a compelling short film that resonated deeply with viewers. The three-minute video, published on Vimeo, combines striking visuals with an atmospheric musical score. The somber footage, partially captured using drone technology, provides a haunting perspective of Chernobyl's abandoned cityscape. Cooke shares his personal connection to the project, noting that the 1986 nuclear disaster occurred in the year of his birth and impacted his own family during their time in Italy. He describes Chernobyl as one of the most fascinating yet hazardous locations he has encountered in his work.¹³ The filmmaker reflects on the distinctive atmosphere of the abandoned city, observing that it possessed both a serene and deeply unsettling quality. He describes the location as a place where time appears suspended, surrounded by echoes of the past.

•

The emergence and impact of drones represents a significant technological development of the 2010s, particularly in how they reshape social and political relationships through remote observation. Aerial drones have gained the most attention through their military applications. Drones serve as tools of global surveillance and power projection. Space collapses through networked digital technology. As they become consumer products, available through retail channels, ethical and privacy concerns rise, with surveillance risks overshadowed by their entertainment value. The transformation of military technology normalizes surveillance, as well as remote engagement and the nature of technological mediation.¹⁴

12 Coronavirus Drone Genres: Spectacles of Distance and Melancholia, Film Quarterly, <https://filmquarterly.org/2020/04/30/coronavirus-drone-genres-spectacles-of-distance-and-melancholia/>, Page 14 of 17, accessed 29 April 2023.

13 Dany Cooke, Postcards from Pripyat, Chernobyl, Video. <https://vimeo.com/112681885>.

14 Patrick Lichty, Drone: Camera, Weapon, Toy: The Aestheticization of Dark Technology. Furtherfield 2013, <https://www.furtherfield.org/drone-camera-weapontoy-the-aestheticization-of-dark-technology/>, accessed 12 March 2025.

Blue Sky Days, Unblemished by a Single Cloud

I no longer love blue skies. In fact, I now prefer gray skies. The drones do not fly when the skies are grey.

—Zubair Rehman

This striking observation is from Zubair Rehman's 2013 congressional testimony on U.S. drone campaigns. The photographer van Houtryve later incorporated Rehman's observation into his series title *Blue Sky Days*. Rehman's testimony provided a profound perspective on how drone operations affect civilian populations in conflict zones. His grandmother had been killed by a drone strike in Pakistan's border region in 2012, an incident that also left him wounded by shrapnel. This poignant statement reveals more or less how drone warfare has fundamentally altered even the most basic human experiences, transforming a blue sky into a source of anxiety and fear.¹⁵

Yes, weather plays a role in war. Carl Clausewitz knew this when he pointed out that it is fog that clouds the enemy and yourself. *Fog makes vision uncertain*.

Fog functions...to give shape to the vague and unpredictable; it is evidently not as foggy as *uncertainty* itself, which it is supposed to make more tangible. This fog does not obscure so much as it provides a form, albeit a hazy, shifting one, for something more abstract that is not directly accessible to the senses...Fog straddles the literal-figurative divide, representing intangibles, clarifying other figurative terms, and sometimes standing in as *itself*, a meteorological phenomenon in the atmosphere.¹⁶

Invisibility is a refuge. So, why do we need or want images at all? Do images give us real connections, relations, empathy and care for others? Do they bridge the distance between me and their devastated situation, their suffering? We look at people on the ground, people without faces. Do they exist? Is this the basic condition of drone warfare?

The ability to hide and deny a drone strike is not an insignificant side effect of this technology, but a central part of a campaign that relies to a great extent on secrecy and deniability. The violence inflicted by drone warfare is thus typically compounded by the perpetrators' negation: the violence against people and things redoubled by violence against the evidence that violence has taken place.¹⁷

15 Alexander Abad Santos, This 13-Year-Old is Scared When the Sky Is Blue Because of Our Drones, *The Atlantic*, 29 October 2013, www.theatlantic.com/politics/archive/2013/10/saddest-words-congress-briefing-drone-strikes/354548/.

16 Cited after Jan Mieszkowski, *Watching War*. Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2012: 19-20.

17 Eyal Weizman, Introduction, Part II: Matter against Memory, in *Forensis: The Architecture of Public Truth*, ed. Forensic Architecture. Berlin: Sternberg Press, 2014: 369-370.

Drone vision is intimately uncanny. The extended capacity of perception makes the drone a paradigmatic figure in our networked world, generating anxious ambivalence.

If we think about how we've traditionally captured images of war, from battlefield paintings to war photography to combat footage, we realize, as Paul Virilio pointed out, that military technology and visual technology have always developed hand in hand. Drones have changed this relationship.

Unlike a soldier looking through a rifle scope or a war photographer peering through a lens, drone vision creates something entirely new: a perspective that's fundamentally detached from human eyes. While traditional war imagery tried to capture what a person would see if they were there, drone footage shows us something we could never see by ourselves: a cold, distant, algorithmic view of the world below.

This is a new way of seeing which isn't just changing warfare, it's seeping into art, activism, and popular culture. There is something more strange and elusive about drone imagery. Unlike a photograph or video that feels like a direct window onto reality, drone images feel more remote, more processed, more digital in their very nature. They're creating a new kind of visual evidence that we are still trying to understand.

This matters because we've long trusted what we can see with our own eyes, or at least through technologies that extend our natural vision. Photos and videos have carried weight in courtrooms and shaped public opinion precisely because they seemed to show us *what really happened*. But drone imagery is different; it shows us something no human eye could see, from perspectives no human could naturally achieve. This raises fascinating questions about how we should interpret and trust these new kinds of images that are increasingly shaping our understanding of events happening around the world.¹⁸

Drones symbolize our social media age, capturing images that reflect both the beauty and strangeness of the world while also serving as tools for surveillance and data collection.

Drones operate by analyzing human behaviors and patterns through continuous monitoring, allowing operators and algorithms to identify significant events and anomalies. This capability is crucial in military contexts, where understanding daily activities can help anticipate potential threats. The goal of drone surveillance is to differentiate between normal and abnormal behaviors, thereby enabling preemptive actions against perceived threats.

18 Cited after final author version: Forthcoming in Schankweiler, K, Straub, V, and Wendl, T. Image Testimonies: Witnessing in Times of Social Media. New York: Routledge. Chapter 7 DRONE'S-EYE VIEW: AFFECTIVE WITNESSING AND TECHNICITIES OF PERCEPTION Michael Richardson 0000-0002-2750-2487.

Drone surveillance contributes to a form of governance that determines who has the right to live or die based on data analysis. This leads to a visual economy that reflects operational chaos rather than divine order, highlighting the role of drones in maintaining a state of exception in societal control.¹⁹

The drone is an experience of weightless dominance in its displacement and augmentation of the 'metabolic vector' for the 'void', not so much of speed, but of invulnerability.²⁰

Sit Back and Enjoy!

This is Scotland in its most stunning form, as seen from the sky by a DJI Inspire 2. John Duncan has done it again with his new film *Ancient Scotland*.²¹

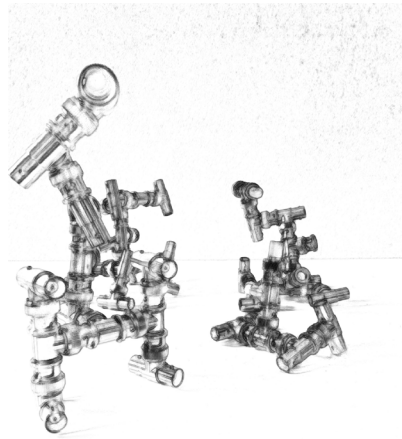


Fig. 6. CO-EXIST WITH YOUR COAX

Finally a variety of BNC adapters and other ancillary items are available. One popular BNC adapter is the straight through adapter, allowing two cables with male connectors fitted to be connected end to end. Other "T" adapters are also available. These have a male plug at the bottom of the "T" and two female connections at either end of the horizontal of the "T".

19 Pasi Väliäho, *The light of God: Notes on the visual economy of drones*. Necsus, <http://www.necsus-ejms.org/light-god-notes-visual-economy-drones/>.

20 Benjamin Noys, *Drone Metaphysics*, CULTURE MACHINE VOL 16, 2015.

21 This is some of the most stunning drone footage we have seen in a very long time, https://www.redsharknews.com/production/item/5726-this-is-some...fhVX09_3ppktEMaiAeg&utm_content=106218657&utm_source=hs_email, accessed 12 March 2025.

These are ideal for use with oscilloscopes where a through connection needs to be measured, and the "T" BNC adapter enables the required connections to be made.²²

The sockets or female BNC connectors also come in a number of flavours. The very basic BNC

connector consists of a panel mounting assembly with a single connection for the coax centre. The earthing is then accomplished via the panel to which the connector is bolted using a single nut. Large washers can be used to provide an earth connection directly to the connector. Some of these connectors may also use four nuts and bolts to fix them to the panel. These arrangements are only suitable for low frequency applications, and not for RF. Where impedance matching and full screening is required. Most surveillance DVRs and CCTV cameras have BNC female output.

There are two main variants of the BNC connector assembly method:

- *Compression gland type*
- *Crimp type*

The compression gland type has the centre pin of the connector which is usually a solder pin and the braid and sheath of the cable are held by an expanding compression gland fixed by a nut at the rear of the connector. This type of connector by its nature can cope with a (limited) range of cable sizes and requires no specialised tooling to assemble. This makes it ideal for small quantity production, either for one off cables for laboratory use or for limited production runs.

The crimp connector has the centre pin which is normally crimped to the centre conductor. This crimped pin is then pushed into position through an inner ferrule which separates the inner insulation sheath and the braid of the cable. An outer ferrule is then crimped over the braid and outer insulation which fixes the cable to the connector. Greater accuracy is required for the crimp style connectors and therefore the correct connector variant must be chosen for the cable being used. This may result in a crimp style connector not being practicable for some cable types. In addition to this the assembly requires the use of the correct crimping tools to ensure that the connector is correctly crimped. While these connectors are always preferred for large production runs because they are much faster to assemble, it is not possible for them to be reworked for obvious reasons.

For both styles of BNC connector it is essential that the exact amount of insulation is stripped from each section to ensure accurate assembly and the required RF performance.²³

22 Ian Poole, Electronic Notes, https://www.radio-electronics.com/info/antennas/coax/bnc_connector.php, accessed 12 March 2025.

23 Ian Pole, 2025.

LOG:: 06 SWIPE ME SVA

Sometimes, one gesture comprises an entire drama, the accent of one word ruins an entire existence, and the indifference of one glance kills the happiest passion.

—Honoré de Balzac

The *swipe-down* mechanism, a pervasive interface design element, is fundamentally altering human behavior and cognition. This seemingly simple algorithm is reshaping our neural pathways and diminishing our humanity by promoting compulsive behavior and instant gratification.

Swipe culture is the phenomenon of rapid-fire dating app matching, made prevalent through platforms like Tinder, Bumble, and Hinge. While this culture has made dating seeming more accessible and efficient, allowing users to quickly find potential matches based on their preferences, it has also introduced social behavioral concerns. The mechanism, used, by 2024, across social media platforms well beyond dating apps (news sites, video platforms), is designed to keep users continuously engaged by minimizing, quite literally, the need to lift a finger from the screen. Companies deliberately implement this design to maximize user engagement and screen time, resulting in unprecedented levels of media consumption. The psychological impact is significant: users become conditioned to expect immediate satisfaction and develop shortened attention spans. This behavioral modification extends beyond digital interfaces into real-life interactions, particularly in dating, where people make snap judgments based on brief impressions. This contributes to society's growing anxiety epidemic by keeping people in a constant state of high stimulation.¹

Interface design exploits and amplifies human compulsive tendencies. While businesses benefit from increased engagement, users become trapped in addictive patterns of behavior that reduce their capacity for deeper, more meaningful interactions and thoughtful engagement with content. This cultivates a society of reactive, impatient individuals whose mental faculties are being diminished by constant exposure to this mechanism of instant gratification.

Swipe culture contributes to problematic behaviors like *ghosting*. When people abruptly cut off all contact with someone they've been dating or talking to, it's known by several terms that paint different shades of the same behavior. *Ghosting* is a sudden vanishing act: one day there, the next gone without explanation. *Simmering* keeps things at a low boil, occasionally responding just enough to keep the other person hanging on. *Icing* puts the relationship into deep freeze, deliberately ignoring someone while leaving the possibility of future contact dangling.

These behaviors share a common thread: avoiding direct communication about ending a relationship by simply disappearing, leaving the other person wondering what happened.

1 Ansh Jain, The Swipe Culture, <https://medium.com/@jainansh01/the-swipe-culture-15156d56e25>, accessed 12 March 2025.

While technology makes it easier than ever to stay connected, it also makes it surprisingly simple to vanish from someone's life with the tap of a *block* button, or by simply never opening their messages again. This common kind of relationship exit strategy leaves the person on the receiving end without closure or understanding of what went wrong. Instead of having potentially uncomfortable conversations about why things aren't working out, people choose to fade away into digital silence.

In swipe culture, people are likely to invest less time and energy in building relationships with negative impacts on commitment.

And the emergence of short-form video content and short-form video applications (SVA) has fundamentally contributed and transformed the social media landscape. The way young people interact with online content is affected by short-term video. The continuous video feed scrolling has become deeply embedded in daily social behavior.

TikTok, YouTube Shorts, and Instagram Reels have dramatically shifted the video content ecosystem. This represents a significant departure for YouTube, which traditionally dominated the long-form video market. While long-form videos previously offered clear monetization opportunities through multiple ad placements and brand collaborations, the shift to short-form content has somehow created a paradoxical situation: despite increasing viewer time spent on platforms, content creators face greater challenges in generating revenue due to reduced advertising opportunities. Audience viewing preferences and behavior patterns have changed radically.²

Connect, Create, and Capture

Essentially we are experiencing video today in more or less three different ways, each with its own personality and rhythm. First, there's the addictive world of TikTok and Instagram Reels; it's like flipping through a magical deck of cards on your phone, each one packed with music, filters, and quick cuts. Videos are bite-sized snacks, gone in seconds, but somehow you keep finding more and more. It's a world where anyone can remix anything, and new trends spread like wildfire.

Then there's the cozy campfire of live streaming, where you can settle in for the long haul. Creators and viewers share real moments together, complete with technical hiccups and unscripted surprises. It's less about perfect edits and more about building genuine connections. Live streaming can be thought of as the digital equivalent of hanging out with friends, where inside jokes flourish and communities grow stronger with each stream.

And then there is the silent sentinel of surveillance video—the watchful eye that never blinks. Unlike its more social cousins, this form of video isn't about entertainment or connection.

2 Prajit T. Rajendran, et al, Shorts on the Rise: Assessing the Effects of YouTube Shorts on Long-Form Video Content, ArXiv abs/2402.18208 (2024): n. pag., <https://arxiv.org/html/2402.18208v1>.

It's the patient observer, storing endless hours of footage, quietly analyzing patterns and waiting for something noteworthy to happen (as described before).

What is fascinating, somehow, is how each of these video forms has carved out its very own niche. Each is like a different language in the visual world: TikTok speaks in rapid-fire bursts of creativity, live streams flow like long conversations, and surveillance footage whispers in the language of record-keeping. The way we engage with each one is completely different, from the quick dopamine hits of short-form content to the slow burn of a favorite streamer's broadcast.

These distinct cultures show us just how versatile video has become; it's not just about watching anymore, but about how we connect, create, and capture our world in vastly multiple ways.

Gestures in Time

There is a text by Giorgio Agamben, *Notes on Gesture*; it is the last chapter of *History & Infancy*, a concise piece. It's also fascinating. He tells about an exciting symptom recorded by physicians at the end of the 19th century: the loss of gestures among urban (bourgeois) people, people forgetting manners of walking or experiencing disorders (uncontrollable jerking, etc.) while making simple everyday gestures. He says that with the start of the 20th century, this issue was no longer noted. Not only, says Agamben, because this state became *normal*, but also because of the rise of a *machinery of gestures*. Following Deleuze, Agamben calls cinema a production of gestures—blocks of space and movement, which are basically gestures. So, one loss of gestures was replaced by another kind of gesture production.

The state Agamben describes before the turn of century is a state of alienation, a response of the body when one suddenly falls into another form of life. The stranger forgets how to walk, how to move his hands, how to point and how to look.

I'm living in this newly gentrified area, you know, which is an old immigrant neighborhood now invaded by mostly white young artists, students and yuppies. And I observe their manners and gestures, which are incredibly interesting; some sort of very much individualistic set of expressions, but highly stylized manners which are never original, or natural at all; an expressive explosion, as opposed to an expressive implosion, forgetting that is experienced by the other side, the immigrants.³

We observe that every repeated action we perform shapes who we are and influences our future behavior, from the second time onward. This means there's no such thing as an insignificant repeated gesture. During the Enlightenment, this understanding of repetition took on new significance: people realized that the world's continuity depends on these patterns of repetition. This isn't an argument against unique events, but rather a criticism of how we overly romanticize the concept of uniqueness. Both nature and culture function as systems built on repetition. Even in religious terms, this concept holds true—divine power primarily

3 Email conversation with Aras Ozgun.

works through nature's established patterns, with miracles being rare exceptions. Kierkegaard captured this modern understanding when he proposed that repetition is fundamental to existence itself; without God willing repetition, there would be no world.

The world exists through and consists of these patterns of repetition. Nietzsche extended this thinking through his self-experimentation, suggesting that style, which he saw as the cultural expression of repetition, is the essence of a person. Someone who truly understands style sees happiness not as random occurrences but as a cultivated habit of being happy.

The key insight is that repetition isn't just mechanical reproduction; it's the fundamental pattern that shapes both our world and ourselves.

Was uns prägt und entprägt, was uns formt und entformt, sind eben nicht nur die durch die 'Mittel' vermittelten Gegenstände, sondern die Mittel selbst, die Geräte selbst: die nicht nur Objekte möglicher Verwendung sind, sondern durch ihre festliegende Struktur und Funktion ihre Verwendung bereits festlegen und damit auch den Stil unserer Beschäftigung und unseres Lebens, kurz: uns.⁴

Windows of Interaction

I like to imagine gestures as a language that speaks through movement—not just any movements, but those that carry meaning and intention. Such movements can be more than just physical actions. For example, Vilem Flusser viewed them as windows into how we express ourselves and interact with our world.⁵

Consider how writing has evolved: from the flowing motion of handwriting to the tapping of keys, and now to *this smooth swipe* of a finger across a screen. Each change in technology transforms not just how we move, but how we think and express ourselves. These technological shifts reshape our gestural vocabulary. In the world of smartphones and dating apps, the simple swipe has become a powerful gesture that would have intrigued Flusser. This single movement now carries the weight of complex social decisions—acceptance or rejection, interest or disinterest—all compressed into a quick slide of the finger. It's both liberating in its simplicity and constraining in its binary nature.

It is amazing how quickly these new gestures become second nature. Swiping has developed its own cultural language: a swipe right means one thing on Tinder, while a swipe up means something else on Instagram. These movements, though simple, reflect profound changes in how we interact with information, each other, and our world. The swipe gesture represents an extreme simplification of human judgment and interaction. What should be complex social,

4 Günther Anders, *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen, Über die Seele im Zeitalter der zweiten industriellen Revolution*, Band I. Verlag C.H. Beck, München 1996.

5 Vilém Flusser, *Gestures*. Translated by Nancy Ann Roth, Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2014.

emotional, or intellectual decisions are reduced to binary, split-second movements. This reduction mirrors what Theodor Adorno might call the *standardization of consciousness*, where nuanced human experience is flattened into predetermined patterns. The swipe interface isn't neutral—it's designed to maximize engagement and data collection.

The gesture becomes a behavioral conditioning mechanism where users are trained to make rapid and emotional, rather than contemplative, decisions. The physical pleasure of the smooth swipe motion is paired with variable reward schedules. The endless feed structure creates what Jonathan Crary calls *24/7 capitalism*, where even our gestures are captured in cycles of continuous consumption.

Embodied Alienation

As we repeatedly swipe through endless content, our bodies become like machines—our fingers dancing to the rhythm of algorithms, our touch transformed from an intimate human gesture into data points for tech companies to collect.

Time itself seems to bend. We're caught in what feels like an endless present, where thoughtful reflection gives way to split-second decisions. It's as if we're racing through a digital landscape at breakneck speed, barely processing one piece of content before moving to the next.

Though we're supposedly more connected than ever, there's an ironic loneliness to it all. Each of us sits alone, swiping through our personalized content streams, our relationships increasingly measured in likes and matches rather than genuine human moments. While we feel we're making choices, we're actually moving through carefully designed pathways, each swipe feeding data to invisible systems that learn our patterns and preferences.

Perhaps most profound is how this simple gesture is rewiring our thinking. Complex decisions become binary choices: left or right, like or dislike. We're training ourselves to react rather than reflect, our attention scattered across an endless stream of fleeting moments. It's a shift that goes beyond just changing how we use technology; it's changing how we think, feel, and connect with the world around us.

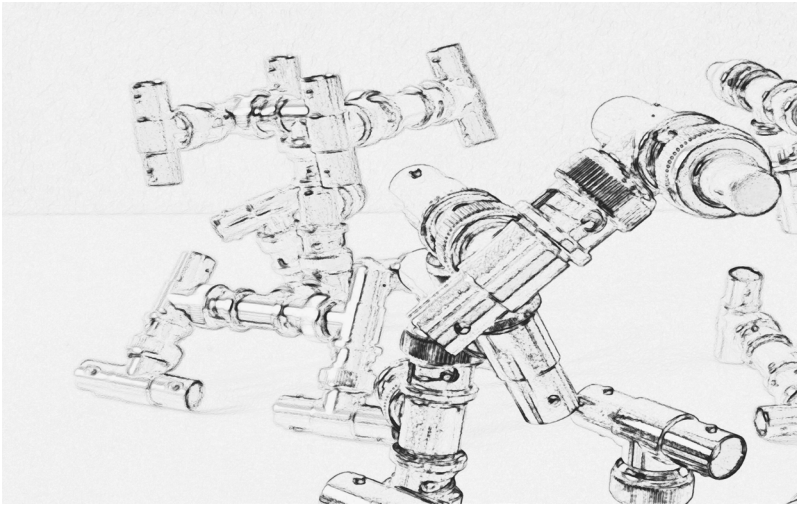


Fig. 7. META-SCHAUEN OBSCUR

The fundamental event of the modern age is the conquest of the world as picture. The word picture (Bild) now means the structured image (Gebild) that is the creature of man's producing which represents and sets before. In such producing, man contends for the position in which he can be that particular being who gives the measure and draws up the guidelines for everything that is.⁶

In Du Mode d'Existence des Objets Techniques (On the mode of existence 1958), Simondon showed us a new approach to the understanding of technical objects, and rethought the relation between humans and machines, cultures and technologies. Today we are witnessing the proliferation of types of object – digital objects in particular – while the very notions of object and objectivity are being transformed by digitizing processes.

This has inevitable implications for experiences and concepts of subjectivity, ...⁷

6 Martin Heidegger, *The Age of the World Picture*. Freiburg, 1938, Translated by William Lovitt.

7 Audio Proceedings of Simondon and Digital Culture. 21-22 November, 2013, Lüneburg, Germany, <http://www.digitalmilieu.net/simondon/>, accessed 26 January 2025.

LOG:: 07 OBJECTS OF INTEREST

Now objects perceive me.

—Paul Klee

Paul Virillio relays this line from the painter Paul Klee. What Klee imagined has become the truth. We humans are no longer the subject who sees.¹ Virillio's *Vision Machine* was, at the time of its writing, somehow still speculative: a fiction of a machine that not only recognizes shapes and contours but can also interpret a complex visual environment, directly operated by a computer, automatically interpreting the meaning of change and events in the observed field.²

Seeing has become a matter or ability of a material. Computer or machine vision is a massive research field in the sciences. Still, we need to understand non-human seeing technology's cultural aspects and impact. We realize that a shift is happening, and this shift relates to human perception. We are still determining if the change will be an expansion of our perception, a controlling force, and a power of capital to co-construct how we live and act in our world.

Photography is a simple example of the technological shift of a medium's meaning and use. Photography has seen two essential value shifts. The first is a value shift from the individual aesthetic of the artist as a photographer to the collaborative and social aesthetics of social media platform services or applications. The second value shift is using photographic images as a vast, combined data fabric to extract information, train chatbots, and re-deliver this cumulative information as a totally different package.³

Our lives are saturated with photos. Our smartphones capture everything, from selfies to everyday scenes. Visuals dominate communication, and images are attached to almost every message. This constant capturing and sharing turns us into both consumers and creators of imagery.

The sheer volume of photos has become overwhelming. The rise of selfies exemplifies this. Manually sorting and organizing is no longer feasible. We are unable to extract information in the way Daguerre was, where the camera and the photograph—as well as the photographer—documented and witnessed a single fact. We need AI to step in. Machines excel at analyzing vast amounts of photos, identifying patterns, and highlighting key moments. AI is then not just a sorting tool, it's starting to shape our visual language. It learns our photography preferences and even suggests new styles.

1 Jill Walker Rettberg, *Now objects perceive me: Art that interrogates machine vision*, University of Bergen 2016.

2 Paul Virillio, *The Vision Machine*. Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1994: 59.

3 On Malick, *On visual web*, a photo is worth more than a 1000 words, December 2014, <http://om.co/2014/12/10/weaving-a-very-visual-web/>, accessed 12 March 2025.

This automation is driven by powerful computing, vast datasets, and sophisticated algorithms. Individual desktop computers will likely become relics, replaced by cloud-based, mobile-centric technology generating a general aesthetic.

Images and *objects* are looking back at us. Instead of passively consuming visuals, we already interact with them in a dynamic way. Photos don't just document our life; they actively influence it, perhaps even subconsciously. But, what kind of *images* or *objects* are looking at us? What is happening or has changed in our relation to *things*?

Cinematographic Objects

For years, different fields have debated the role of objects. However, film and media studies haven't fully explored how such work might contribute to understanding agency, both human and non-human. What if we saw cinema not just as a way to show things, but as a machine for learning about them? In this light, what can cinema tell us about objects and their relationship with humans and non-humans?

Films are full of objects, on different levels. There are the things we see on screen, the objects the film is about, and even the film itself as an object. Martin Heidegger might call these *Zeug*, or useful things.

Volker Pantenburg's book *Cinematographic Objects* delves into how film theory defines and categorizes objects. Different theorists have different ideas. Balazs is drawn to the surface qualities of objects, while Epstein focuses on their active power. Casetti argues that Epstein's work suggests objects can even *act* on viewers. Thomas Elsaesser analyzes the specific example of the carousel on screen. He proposes a new way to think about film, moving beyond the idea of the image simply capturing reality. Instead, he suggests *energy* is a better concept, as it applies to different film technologies and captures the various types of energy involved, from mechanical to digital.⁴

Energy today is experienced as distributive, networked, nodal. As such, it is closer to information and code. Energy in cinema is the ability to convert mechanically generated movement into brain perception and body sensation (Deleuze and Kittler). The object carousel as a para-, proto-, and meta-cinematic object par excellence, points, in Elsaesser's reflection, to an idea of cinema that *finally can, and perhaps should, only exist in mind*.⁵

Of course, this reflection on the cinematographic object is grounded in a form of cinema that is already inadequate, despite directors like Christopher Nolan and Hollywood capital proofs a nostalgia for celluloid. Cinematographic objects, in this form of reflection, or *Betrachtung*, as a theoretical approach, don't offer more to our understanding of what is happening in the further algorithmic automation of culture.

4 Volker Pantenburg, *Cinematographic Objects: Things and Operations*, Berlin: August Verlag 2015.

5 Pantenburg 2015.

Cinema in 2024 is a niche, a system inside a broader cultural system offering a specific form of formalized entertainment, while streaming and platforms dominate the daily.

Thing and Medium

A very different reflection on objects comes from a 1926 essay by Fritz Heider, *Ding und Medium*. Thanks to Niklas Luhmann and Dirk Baecker, this essay is available today.

Heider, a psychologist by training, was partial to Gestalt psychology, with which he eventually made a career in the US. In 1920, Heider received his doctorate with a thesis on causality under Alexius Meinong, a student of Franz Brentano who became known for his object theory. Later in the 1920s, in Munich, Heider worked with the psychologist Max Wertheimer, one of the founders of Gestalt psychology. From 1927 on, he worked with the psychologist William Stern, father of Günther Anders, in Hamburg and emigrated to the US in 1930. In *Ding und Medium*, Heider asks why our perception singles out an object. Causality would treat everything as equally probable, so everything could be described through cause and effect. However, observation makes clear that humans are not determined, fixed creatures constrained by cause and effect. We can create our forms of life through surprising new combinations of cause and effect.⁶

Heider uses the example of a pencil and a lamp.

I can see this pencil here, for example. It is illuminated by the lamp. The pencil therefore causes the process on the retina. We can also go back even further to the lamp; one could also say that the light from the lamp causes the retinal process. Why do I see the pencil and not something here just in front of my eye or the lamp?⁷

Heider attempts to ask about the causal processes that create an energetic connection between a thing and our perception without us noticing anything about the energy source, about the energy transfer process between the thing and our senses, much less about the calculation of this perception in our body and brain. We perceive without perceiving the perception to which we owe a perception.

Heider suggests treating objects and media as similar in their basic building blocks. These elements can be combined tightly or loosely. Letters, for instance, are loosely connected, while words are a tight combination of letters. This means letters act as the media that creates a word object. Words can be loosely connected to form sentences, and sentences can be combined to form texts.

6 Fritz Heider. *Ding und Medium*, herausgegeben und mit einem Vorwort versehen von Dirk Baecker
Copyright © 2005 by Kulturverlag Kadmos Berlin.

7 Heider 2005.

This concept, later developed extensively by Niklas Luhmann, helps Heider escape a cause-and-effect trap. He argues that perception isn't caused by objects themselves but by the perceiver. Through our actions, we select and solidify specific things from the vast possibilities the media offers, essentially crystallizing them from the background. Heider even lays the groundwork here for a new understanding of how actions work.

The organism itself is a thing in the world. The object of cognition does not act directly on the sense organ but through some mediation. He asks whether a structure of the external world is decisive for cognition, and, if so, what is this like. The world might be seen as a network of causal processes. In terms of causation, all links in the chain of cause and effect are equal, but not in terms of perception. There is a unique link, namely our object of perception. Wave-mediated remote perception—for we will restrict ourselves to this for the time being (Heider)—structures the world into what is perceived, the objects of perception, and the mediation through which perception occurs. Most of the time, the objects of perception are the solid and semi-solid things in our environment, and mediation is the air-filled space, the medium that surrounds things. There are exceptions; for example, things like glass serve as mediators; we can see through glass. But we will ignore these exceptions for now and ask ourselves based on which properties the things and media play the roles of the object of knowledge and mediator. The medium and the stone are the substrates of the event; they remain in place, and the energy moves through and over these substrates and takes on different forms.

For Heider, the concept of energy is similar to the idea of information. Energy excites things in the medium of their perception.

Heider continues by identifying two types of events: internally conditioned events assigned to the substrate, and externally conditioned events assigned to the influence. The medium event is externally conditioned. What happens in the media depends on the form of the incoming energy; the specific nature of the medium is largely irrelevant to the form of the event. It is now necessary to distinguish between unified and multiple events. An exact depiction, imposition, or impression of a design is generally only possible if the thing is imposed by or through events or that onto which something is imposed consists of many independent parts. These imposed events form false units, possibly because they can be traced back to uniform causes. If the causes of the individual, independent shocks also had nothing to do with each other, then it would be extremely unlikely that order and regularity would arise.

Isn't everything in this world equally meaningful, grounded, and only referring to itself? How can there be something that points to something else? To point to something else, the sign must be closely associated with this other, with the thing being signified. The sign must point to something specific; it must not stand alone in the world; it must be linked to something else and clearly to something specific. We find these properties of association in the medium processes. All these medium processes that affect our sense organs and give us information about things are false units. These false units have the property of pointing to something else; they are incomprehensible if they are not related to the unified cause.

The diversity of signs could also have come about in another way. There could be a single sign for every word, for every concept: a sign that forms a unity in itself that is not composed of different independent parts. Image language is such a sign system. Most sign systems, however, use combinations to achieve multiplicity. Combining independent elements also prevails in flag signals or Morse code. The arrangement of units occurs not in space, as with letters, but in time. The arrangement of points must come entirely from the person who gives the signs; it must not arise in any way from the nature of the signs themselves. In other words, the signs must be independent of one another. If the combination is used in time, then the time position of one element must be independent of the time positions of the other elements.

We must ask ourselves how the environment is structured in relation to its vital importance and its immediate importance for the organism. Of the countless possible environmental factors, we only need to know a few to be fully oriented to them as concerns their potential relationships to our bodies. We only live in a particular sphere of this world; we have no relationship at all to much of what is around us and what is happening; it is not really for us. The unity of the chair is, therefore, objective. The chair has properties as a whole. Specific laws and relationships between these whole properties are, to a high degree, invariant compared to the determinations of the small particles. Being spherical is one such property. It can be realized in an infinite number of particle combinations. Each of these combinations has the further property of being rollable. A solid ball can be rolled, no matter what material it is made of. There is, therefore, a correlation between different whole properties across the small particles and their properties. For the sensory-physiological processes, these physical systems are of great importance; for the practical structure of the world that surrounds us and for the conditions of perception outside the organism, structures of the type of solid units are probably more important.

In our world, there are more gruesome and smaller units and parts of larger wholes. The organism now steps between these things and creates its world. The things become rich in relationships, almost all of which are not transparently geometric. One must be clear: not everything has meaning for us, and a great deal happens that does not even enter our world. And the media are indeed filled with units that are of a lower order, yet that are empty about our order. Both events, the coarse material and that of the small molecules, are therefore linked to static units. Only the coarse material is of importance to us. This connection between most things carrying out their vibrations and media carrying out imposed vibrations and the wave process is thus linked to the world in which we live through associations, which is of great importance. This becomes clear to us from the exceptions. There are opaque media and opaque things. Fog has no coarse material significance for us; one can move in it as if in *empty air*, but in it, the associations of light waves with things are disturbed. Another exception is glass. It cannot impose characteristic arrangements on the wave process; it lets the orders through and transmits them like a medium. But it is a coarse material unit; glass is a solid body. These exceptions have biological significance. Sailors and mountain climbers die in fog, and small birds perish if they have not adapted to these exceptions and hit window panes with their beaks.

Multiplicity Events

In cinema, the wall is the medium. Display devices are not ordinary media that pass on the influence they receive. They have their own laws. Display devices make something different from what hits them, transposing this into changes that we can perceive with greater sensory precision. Because of these laws, a display device is no longer a perfect medium. It abstracts certain moments from the influence and transposes their changes. This transposition must, of course, take place according to stringent laws. That is, the changes in the pointer must be precisely assigned to the changes in the influence. This is a medium mediation law: the successive positions of the pointer are not linked by a law specific to the pointer but are determined by external factors. Suppose one creates it by excluding the influence of form (flat surface) and lighting (uniform lighting) through suitable changes to the surface. In that case, an image is created in the narrower sense of the word. A projection image is created if one excludes the influence of form and surface quality (a uniform white wall) through specific lighting. This trace must be such that it sends out extensions similar to the ones that form the trace. The extensions have thus been fixed, for this trace substrate becomes a solid body whose parts cannot be moved relative to one another, which asserts itself as a unity in the changes. It is a fixation of false units, a fixation of mediation. In cinematographic depiction, too, the sequence is broken down into a sequence following one another, and an event is preserved in a solid body.

Because something like perception apparatuses exists in the world structure, things generally have much more characteristic effects. They become real in a much more comprehensive sense, since new possibilities of effect are opened. How does a knife work, for example, in the usual super-elementary connections? It works as a whole, as a physical unit; it works through its weight and even its shape; the wedge shape of its blade means it can cut. But when does its shape as a whole ever have a uniform, characteristic effect on other bodies? One is tempted to say this only happens in the organism, which recognizes its shape.

This reconstruction of the core units from the offshoots is now the *synthesis of ideas and sensations*, the *production of the form*. The necessity of such a synthesis is thus entirely understandable with reference back to the structure of the external world. Every being wishing to perceive its environment through a medium would have to use such a synthesis. If we tried to construct an apparatus that reacts to external things through a medium in a meaningful way, we would also have to build this apparatus in such a way that it brings the multiplicity of effects emanating from the units back together into units. In this sense, the synthesis is conditioned by the external world. We will assume that its more specific laws cannot be derived entirely from the psyche.

The order that lies latent in the medium is made physically effective, and this is also the first step in the meaningful unification of the effects rushing through the medium. The lens is even more effective, in that it keeps out what comes from other units and collects the multiplicity from a unit. This is already the beginning of synthesis.

But only the beginning. The lens does indeed restore the order of the light-emitting points. Still, how the points are grouped into units needs to be assigned. On the screen or in front of the retina, the points next to each other are of equal value and atomistic.

General and Special Devices

If the medium were not homogeneous and the rays did not spread out according to a general pattern, a device for unification as generally usable as the lens would be impossible. Constructing a device that reunites the rays emanating from a point is possible. This duality is of the utmost importance. Firstly, there is the event itself, but also its meaning. The rays *signify* the points from which they come in some way. And when they are reunited, they are reunited correctly and meaningfully. This is analogous to the relationship between the physical and the psychic. The physical is the carrier of the psychic. Two layers of functional connections are superimposed on one another. The offshoots must be reunited meaningfully into units, so the laws determine the type of unification according to which the offshoots are assigned to the big things. But of course, the physiological process of this unification also has laws that are different from what it means.

There is a second possibility of the connection between the two layers. The laws of the carriers of these events could correspond in their structure to the laws of the layer of meaning. An apparatus could react meaningfully to many different influences by virtue of the laws within it. A change in the multiplicity of offshoots, i.e., in the stimulus, would not result in something different in the central part, and this is not because a changed stimulus sets in motion another apparatus precisely tailored to it, but because the apparatus reacts differently. The laws of the connection between offshoots and core events require specific assignments for the return.

A single, adaptable apparatus connects everything; it reacts differently depending on the cause. And, yes, we can improve our ability to perceive things with things we make in workshops, with glasses, microscopes, and telescopes.

The more specific the assignment of offshoot combinations to the center, the less likely it is that there are physiological apparatuses that respond meaningfully to many stimuli. The type of mediation influences the image of the objects; we can even place mediation at the center of perception. The hand is the perfect direct mediation of action, and we can recognize its mediating properties. Thus, the organism is not as directly involved in the causal connection as a thing that is pushed and pushed again; instead, it lives between two false units of multiple mediations. It receives the multiplicity emitted by the unified thing with its senses, unites it somehow, and then acts back on the thing's events through an assortment. This peculiar causal connection makes new connections and relationships between things possible. In the individual, if you can see through something, you can run your hand through it without resistance. What is *something* to our eyes is also *something* in the larger sense. Waves can, therefore, mediate the knowledge of significant things. This relationship of mediation to what is mediated, which we found in the wave event, now applies generally to knowledge transfer.

I tried to condense Heider's essay but wanted to retain his originality. So, I feel it is needed to sum up:

Things are not things per se, and media are not media per se. Everything can also be a medium for another. A thing is perceptible in a medium that mediates this perception. Because the thing owes its existence to perception, which is only possible through the medium, no thing can be outside of a medium. Media are thus always something in between and move between other things.

Heider highlights the medial concept, including its effects, but simultaneously subjects it to an economy that banishes the potential threat of the medial to the form of the human being (Heider) or the system (Luhmann).⁸

The ancient elements are media insofar as things appear in them. But the things are not substances, but *false units*, insofar as the *wave events* are configured in perception as objects. (Glass, for example, can be *seen* as a thing or, as a medium, can *let other things see*.) This is constructivism in its most radical and at the same time most anthropological variant.⁹

'You only hear the clock ticking because the air itself is not ticking.'¹⁰

We don't perceive the transmission channel.

Digital Objects

What I call digital objects are simply objects on the Web, such as YouTube videos, Facebook profiles, Flickr images, and so forth, that are composed of data and formalized by schemes or ontologies that one can generalize as metadata. These objects pervade our everyday life online, and it is in fact very difficult for us to separate what is online and offline anymore, as indicated decades ago by the action of jacking into cyberspace.¹¹

Technological objects constantly evolve to match their time period, with digital objects currently changing at an especially rapid pace. Yuk Hui examines digital objects, which he defines as things that appear on screens or operate in computer programs. Data itself becomes materialized as objects. Hui's work draws heavily from philosophers like Stiegler, Husserl, Simondon, and Heidegger. A key concept is Simondon's idea of *concretisation*—how technical objects tend toward an ideal (but unreachable) natural state that reflects their current era. Hui

8 Rezensionennotiz zu Neue Zürcher Zeitung, 28 June 2005. <https://www.perlentaucher.de/buch/fritz-heider/ding-und-medium.html>, accessed 12 March 2025.

9 Stephan Günzel, About false units. Fritz Heider's essay "Thing and Medium" from 1926 in a new edition. <https://literaturkritik.de/id/8265>.

10 C. Morgner, The Medium in the Sociology of Niklas Luhmann: From Children to Human Beings. *Educ Theory*, 73: 890-916. 2023. <https://doi.org/10.1111/edth.12609>.

11 Yuk Hui, What is a digital object? *Metaphilosophy*, vol. 43, no. 4, 2012, pp. 380–95. JSTOR, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/24441843>. Accessed 9 January 2025.

develops a method based on Bachelard's *orders of magnitude* to analyze digital objects from different perspectives. He argues that digital objects represent a new kind of materiality—not just binary code, but the material capacity to process data.

Digital objects exist as a distinct category of technical objects that differ fundamentally from physical objects. They are made up of data and metadata, structured through relations within digital systems. Digital objects are not simply virtual representations, but have their own mode of existence characterized by their relationality; they exist through networks of relations with other digital objects, users, and technical systems. These objects are inherently relational; their existence depends on complex webs of relations between data, protocols, interfaces, and infrastructures. Unlike physical objects, which have relative independence, digital objects cannot exist outside their relations. A key point is that digital objects differ from traditional technical objects in their temporality; they're oriented toward the future, rather than serving as objects of cultural memory.

Digital technology has fundamentally altered our relationship with reality, time, and memory. This transformation operates on several levels. Regarding digital objects and reality, there's a complex interplay between two types of ontology: the technical (dealing with metadata and knowledge representation) and the existential (concerning our being-in-the-world). Digital objects exist through both discursive relations (technical/logical) and existential relations (our lived experience of them). This dual nature suggests we might be experiencing an *inauthentic* version of technical reality. Concerning time and memory, time itself has become quantifiable data—something that can be measured, controlled, and infinitely divided (albeit with delays). This transforms how we store and access memories through what Bernard Stiegler calls *tertiary retention*: our technological memory systems. Time no longer flows uniformly but exists in different rhythms, scales, and intensities. And regarding the human-technology relationship, we've become so intertwined with technology that humans are now *unthinkable* without their technical supplements. Technology shapes how we form and retain memories (both immediate and long-term). This relationship has a *pharmacological* nature - meaning technology acts as both a remedy and a potential poison.

Digital objects have introduced a new way of being, in which numbers are material entities subject to control, symbols are transformed through *de-symbolization*, and our very experience of time and memory is mediated through technical systems. This isn't just about using technology - it's about how technology has fundamentally reshaped our way of existing in the world. We are in a new phase of human evolution. Digital objects transform our thinking about materiality and our relationship with technology, producing new forms of social and cultural memory through their persistence and replicability.

As discussed, we perceive things through transparent media like air or light; think of how you see an object through air. The medium (air) and the thing (what you're looking at) are clearly separate. But digital objects (Hui) work differently. They're both the thing AND the medium at the same time. Think of a digital photo: it's an object you can look at, but it's also the means by which information is transmitted.

While traditional media need to be *formless* to carry information (like clear air letting you see things), digital objects have their own form while still carrying information. Copying, modifying, or deleting instantly define different ways of existing and being perceived.

With digital objects, several complex layers of mediation emerge. There's the physical infrastructure layer: the hardware, processors, memory, and network cables that form the material basis for digital objects. Unlike natural media, these aren't *thing-free*, but are highly structured and engineered specifically for information transmission. Then, there's the software layer: the operating systems, protocols, and code that interpret and translate digital information. This represents a form of mediation that has no clear parallel in Heider's theory, as it's both a medium and a set of active processes. And, there's the interface layer: the screens, speakers, and input devices through which we actually interact with digital objects. Here we finally return to something closer to Heider's natural media (light from screens, sound waves from speakers), but these are already heavily processed and transformed.

These layers of mediation affect our perception of digital objects as *real* things. In Heider's theory, direct perception through natural media helps establish the reality and permanence of physical objects. But digital objects are always accessed through this complex chain of technological mediation, which might suggest they should feel less *real* to us. Yet paradoxically, digital objects often feel quite real and present in our experience. Interestingly, while Heider's theory suggests that multiple layers of mediation should make objects feel more distant and less real, digital objects often achieve a kind of immediate presence in our experience despite (or perhaps because of) their complex mediation.

As digital objects transform our experience of the world, they also transform our interaction with it. The digital layers upon the physical, creating an invisible skin of mediation, a *formless* package. The complexity of hardware, software, interface and network melts into a thing, mediated and invisible. Our world, our minds perceive with and in technology. The smartphone as we know it now is just a state of in-betweenness.

•

Are we becoming strange to our world?

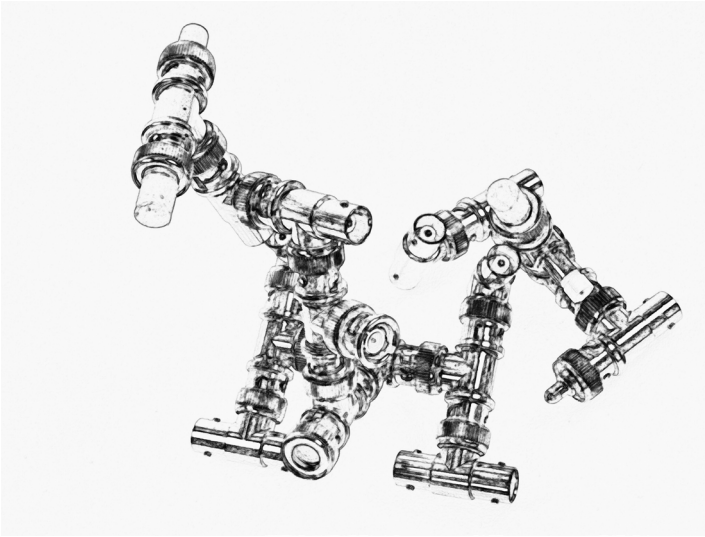


Fig. 8. ANT-000

Graham Harman: *Basic principles of OOO*

(1) All objects must be given equal attention, whether they be human, non-human, natural, cultural, real or fictional.

(2) Objects are not identical with their properties, but have a tense relationship with those properties, and this very tension is responsible for all of the change that occurs in the world.

(3) Objects come in just two kinds: real objects exist whether or not they currently affect anything else, while sensual objects exist only in relation to some real object.

(4) Real objects cannot relate to one another directly, but only indirectly, by means of a sensual object.

(5) The properties of objects also come in just two kinds: again, real and sensual.¹²

ANT - relations or connections between things (material) and concepts (semiotic); Technology/nature and social are together in a network of relational properties and acting potentials Actor-Networks are short term, have a short life, are constantly becoming and reborn, some relations have to be constantly repeated otherwise the network would dissolve, ... in other words social relations are always changing and have therefore constantly be built

Deleuze and Guattari use an description of rhizomatics as a nomadic form of connections constantly in flux, ever becoming and leading off in a chaos of directions, this is a practice.

12 Graham Harman, *Object-oriented ontology: a new theory of everything*, Pelican Books London 2018: 14.

Bruno Latour: 'An actant can literally be anything provided it is granted to be the source of an action.'

Graham Harman: >For Latour, we have nothing but our dealings with networks of objects; some may be nobler and others more base, but all are on the same ontological footing. Hence, for Latour there is no way to transcend the world, and it is no accident that the concept of nothingness plays no role whatsoever in his thinking.

If philosophy is to make any progress in the decades to come, it is vital that we consistently

oppose Heidegger and side with Latour: against the ontological/ontic distinction, against the theory/practice distinction, against the blanket contempt for mass-produced objects, against the idea that knowledge means transcendence of the world, against nothingness, and in favor of endless

curiosity about all manner of specific beings.¹³

13 Graham Harman, The importance of Bruno Latour, Cultural Studies Review. Vol.13 No 1 March 2007.

LOG:: 08 ABOUT A LINE

Wenn ein Punkt Bewegung und Linie wird, so erfordert das Zeit.

—Paul Klee

Where to start? Paul calls. No Free Play. Extrabreit. Video is the pure change of light. The visual starts with a point. The point is on a plane. The point moves in an ordered structure. Two points make a line.

At the beginning of the history of the moving image, there was a technological and scientific interest. This interest in technological advance and invention is about movement and research regarding movement. A lab set up is built and used: a wall, a horse, a camera, and an isolated body in movement. The body is the object of interest, the camera a research instrument. Movement is magic. Movement motivated Melieres.

The first cameras are also the first projectors. Their separation makes incredible distances for the reproduction of movement possible in multiple places far away from each other.

Scanning

The technical problem of television was the reproduction of the event anywhere simultaneously. The trick of scanning line by line as a principle methodology made it possible. Lines and pixels, points on a target plane, are a technical condition of transport and time to form anywhere a grid. After the invention of television, it took many years to be able to record the analog video image. This was accomplished through creating the scanned raster of lines and inscribing what information was present in each line. This was the strategy of analog video in its two main forms: PAL and NTSC.

While film and cinema are about pictures, photographic images, and lines as compositional elements inside frames, the electronic system uses points as targets to scan and reproduce the live event. Movement and storytelling in cinema are framed and static, while television video and electronic and digital media are highly dynamic. The high speed of construction and transformation makes images visible and sound audible. Two points near each other construct a line. The signal's scanning methodology goes by the line, line by line, from top to bottom, and the attributes or content of the target points on screen, pixels, and visual information build a line, then building each image.

With digital technology and modern LED screens, scanning became obsolete. A form of inscribing and recording information that was independent of the scanned raster but was grid-like, digital in form and mode, took over. Digital videos structure is pixel-based rather than line-based, and stores complete frames as data. No physical scanning beam (only necessary because of the state of magnetic control of electron beams and glass technology), but compression algorithms. Displayed instantly as complete frames. Different, aesthetically.

Two Points

From one point the world arises, from two points a life that is a line.¹

As an essential visual and design element of drawing, the line is both a technical instrument and an artist's means of expression and style. The line connects two points; it separates, guides, organizes, draws, stretches, outlines, and designs or runs in a disorderly, labyrinthine, undulating manner.

The Italian architect and art historian Manlio Brusatin points to the myth of Daedalus. The first artist and architect built the labyrinth of the Minotaur as a symbol of architecture and road building, which in turn could only be outwitted by the *line* of a string: Ariadne's thread.

I want to follow Brusatin in an attempt to look again at the screen as a medium in itself and at the lines and pixels or dots it consists of. Here, I also insist on an aesthetic approach to something that might otherwise appear all too technical, or all too ubiquitous.

Simplex Linea

Manlio Brusatin writes. Life is a line; thinking is a line, and acting is a line. Everything is a line. The line connects two points. The point is a moment; the line begins and ends in two moments. For Euclid, the line separates itself from the dimension of bodies to be able to control them. Bodies without dimensions are surfaces. Surfaces without extension are lines. The ends of lines that have no length are points. Euclid begins his geometry in reverse.²

In classical antiquity, the line expressed clarity and proximity. Under the influence of Platonism, in the age of humanism, there was a strong push for the production of images, which were almost entirely replaced by the religious cultic world of imagery. The line of Platonism is a whole cosmos, traversed and structured by ascending, descending, circular, and spiral lines.

When the *optics* of the Middle Ages developed from Arabic optics, a fundamental problem arose. According to Euclidian geometry, perception presupposes the existence of an observer whose eye emits rays whose trajectories are as precisely directed as arrows. Yet according to optics, committed, as it is, to Platonism, the emanated rays are equal to the properties of the bodies (species) that emanate from the *surfaces or shells* that, as Democritus says, cover noble things. The power of sight is as delicate as a line; like a line, the shorter the path it travels, the more immediate and sharp it is. For Aristotle, too, nature operates along the shortest and best possible route: thus, a straight line. The commentaries of medieval scholastics on Robert Grosseteste, the Bishop of Lincoln, who saw light as something entirely material, do, however, see a parallel between lines and direct rays, as well as between angles and reflected rays (broken lines that change their trajectory) that strike reflective or even opaque surfaces.

1 Manlio Brusatin, *Geschichte der Linien*. Aus dem Ital. übers. von Sabine Schulz. Berlin: Diaphanes. 2003: 12.

2 Brusatin 2003: 19.

The geometric line, reinforced by the principle of light, is like an arrow that bounces off and is reflected. This is why vision can no longer be static, determined by the point of observation. That the ray is subject to actions such as reflections becomes the established conception of an optics and theory of vision that extends *geometrically* to Newton and *psychologically* to Berkeley.³

Distance, also a line, can only be determined by the greater or lesser deviation of the rays from one another, which is a rather simplistic representation. But this opens up an aspect that was still completely unknown in the ancient world: the possibility of bringing objects as close as possible to the subject, which is almost miraculous, because it: >shows us how we can, at our will, make very distant things appear very close, large things that are close by appear tiny, and small things that are far away appear large, so that we can read tiny letters from an incredible distance, as if we were counting grains of sand.⁴

These not-yet-entirely apparent considerations inevitably bring to mind the *modern* invention of spectacles, which would not appear until the 13th century.

It is difficult to say whether it was Platonism or Aristotelianism, with their respective conceptions of the rays of vision (that they emanate from objects or rather from the human eye), which prepared the compositional and representational aspects that were central to the Italian *prospettiva*, which would later be attributed to Filippo Brunelleschi (in the material sense) and Leon Battista Alberti (in the spiritual sense), and which is expressed, for example, in the paintings of Piero della Francesca.

The two coincide. The Platonist discourse of the Bishop of Brixen, Nicholas of Cusa, develops its symbolic construction, turning away from the distant relations of similarity that occupied astronomy, in a brilliant act of bringing the objects of the world of the sensible closer together (*De docta ignorantia*, Chapter I). The horizon line is now one and the same—whether for the Arab world, which crosses deserts and seas, or for the Italian city, where from a tower top, a point on the horizon is determined where the vanishing lines converge, but also, at the same time, *return* from the horizon and arrange themselves on a targeted baseline closest to the observer.

The results is a visual pyramid or optical cone formed from imaginary rays, which we might better imagine as something emitted by the viewer's eye. This scheme for seeing is closer to Euclid and Aristotle. It thus corresponds to a geometric-physical (and, at the same time, painterly) *optics*; the development in *De pictura* nevertheless remains somewhat ambiguous. Of course, perspective in this sense does nothing other than arrange two visions according to the *concordant oppositorum* taught by Nicholas of Cusa, by exchanging them with one another.

3 Brusatin 2003: 38.

4 Brusatin 2003: 40. Robert Grosseteste: *De lineis. angulis et figuris seu de fractionibus et reflectionibus radorum, sowie De iride seu de iride et speculo* (1230-33) (ital. Übersetzung in: *Metafisica della luce*, hrsg. von Pietro Rossi, Mailand 1986; dort S. 126 f. zu Linien und S. 140-1 52 zum Regenbogen).

The theoretical as well as practical success of the *perspectiva artificialis* and, related to this, its entire symbolic value, is based on the desire for a permanent close-up view, which is the opposite of the distant and momentary vision in the Middle Ages: the view of a city or the brief glimpse of a star or a coat of arms.

For Piero della Francesca, who defines perspective as *things seen from a distance*, the view, the form, and the lines move from the objects seen to the eye. But, ultimately, they are >that place between the eye and the object where things are to be represented. [That is,] a place where the eye, based on its visual rays, represents things according to their proportions and can thereby judge their size.⁵

It is true that by solving the riddle of perspective, artists acquired a new intellectual status and were able to assert themselves socially as colleagues within the literary world. But in reality, perspective is more of an emblem, a cipher, far too complicated and at the same time far too simple, a labyrinth that the artist knows how to traverse only by secret paths and which he often presents as a marvel to the stern gaze of his master or despotic patron. It is also clear that the mastery of central perspective becomes the golden rule, the first true metaphor of an intellectual function of the arts, a genuine and unique revolution of the artists against the manifold skills and secrets of medieval recipe books, against the emblems and color symbolisms of an iconographic code in which, like an arithmetic book, the hierarchies of meaning that applied within the limits of the panel painting (but not outside it) were recorded. Art is not a reflection of social reality but rather its correction.

Beyond a mimetic function, central perspective (*perspectiva artificialis*) brought the author himself, or what could be considered his intellectual work, to the foreground. Perspective is more of an aid, a talisman of interpretation, a model that guides the production techniques of the various arts, and which the painter can use to develop his new role as interpreter.

Artistic geometry is still developed under the same considerations discussed before perspective, and only today do we seem to anticipate the space-time relationship that uses very *geometric lines* (as mechanical trajectories) to describe the line through a linear equation as the speed of a point. Leonardo compares the point to time and the moment. There is, therefore, an immediate similarity between the line and a *quantity of time*, because just as points mark the beginning and end of a line, moments are the beginning and end of a period. The hand that follows and fixes a line grasps time and gives it form: a line becomes consciousness of a period and, thus, the dimension of an idea projected by time and, through time, into the *beyond* and perhaps eternity. At the end of the 16th century, there is a coat of arms motif (whose imagery is concentrated on a variety of symbols) that conveys precisely this moral message: a row of dots runs parallel to a line, extending over the same length, and underneath it is written: *Eternity is made of moments* (sie ex instantibus aeternitas).⁶

5 Brusatin 2003: 46.

6 Brusatin 2003: 84/85.

Kandinsky Klee

Forget about lines as physical things; they are more like the path a moving point leaves behind. Imagine a single point, perfectly still. A line is born when this point breaks free, its movement a rebellion against its static state. This movement is dynamic, a leap from stillness to action.

The forces driving this transformation can be anything - diverse and unpredictable. The number and combination of these forces determine the character of the line. Imagine a *language* of lines, one that speaks through their variations in tension and direction. Words can't capture it.

Art, at its most precise, strips away unnecessary details, letting the inner voice of this line-language resonate. Pure forms become vessels for vibrant emotions.

For Wassily Kandinsky, lines craved freedom. His abstract art was all about liberating them from being tied to objects. As a point finds movement, it creates a *design*, a fundamental structure built on movement itself.

Similarly, Paul Klee saw lines not as connections, but as organic growths, like plants sprouting from a point. Every line continuously evokes new feelings. Remember, movement is the ultimate source.

There are very different ways in which the movements develop, either like a walker wandering through a park or like a dog without a leash wandering back and forth to all sorts of lamp posts and all sorts of scent marks, and in this drawing you can see exactly these two types of movement, a walker and a dog without a leash.⁷

•

Questions of Walking and Seeing

In her book *Wanderlust*, Rebecca Solnit draws a fascinating parallel between walking and the creative process. She compares writing to carving a new path through the landscape of imagination, where reading becomes a guided journey alongside the writer.⁸ At first glance, both pathfinding and guided travel seem to rely heavily on sight. Pathmakers and travelers both need to watch their steps and navigate the terrain. However, Solnit's analogy goes deeper.

Writing and reading, like walking, involve more than just the visual. Tim Ingold asks: *What happens when we walk?* He argues that watching our steps isn't simply about processing visual information like a map.

7 Paul Klee, Notebooks Vol1. TheThinkingEye. New York, G. Wittenborn 1961. <https://archive.org/details/paulkleethinking0000klee/>, accessed 12 March 2025.

8 Rebecca Solnit, *Wanderlust: A History of Walking*, Penguin Books 2001. P.72.

We engage with the ground beneath our feet, not a mere image of it. Similarly, when we *look where we are going*, we scan the entire physical world around us, not just pictures or representations.⁹

In Akira Kurosawa's *Dreams*, a painter steps into the paintings of Van Gogh and walks through his landscape.

Reading and writing involve the exercise of both eye and mind, which must be true of walking. Can we find a way of describing the imaginative activity that goes on as one walks, reads, or writes, without having to suppose that it involves the perusal of images? Perhaps it is the very notion of the image that has to be rethought, away from the idea that images represent, on another plane, the forms of things in the world; instead, take the notion of images as place-holders for these things, which travelers watch out for, and from which they take their direction. Could it be that images do not stand for things but rather help you find them?

Should the drawing or painting be understood as a final image to be inspected and interpreted, as is conventional in visual culture studies, or should we consider it a node in a matrix of trails to be followed by observant eyes?

Are drawings or paintings of things in the world, or are they like things in the world, in the sense that we have to find our ways through and among them, inhabiting them as we do the world itself?¹⁰

Across cultures and time, in the simplest manner, traditions have fostered surprisingly similar ways of understanding the world. From medieval European monks to Aboriginal Australians, these approaches don't rely solely on spirits (animism) or animal ancestors (totemism). Instead, they use the physical world—landscapes, artwork, and even written text—as a bridge to a deeper reality, a connection with something more profound.

These traditions challenge the modern view that separates imagination and reality. They suggest that the *mental* and *material* are interwoven, like countries without borders. This contrasts with the view of imagination as distinct from the physical world.

Everything we experience, from paintings to nature, walks to written words, offers a path to understanding a deeper reality. These experiences are all valid forms of knowledge, shaped by a deeper source within us, a kind of wellspring of life force.

Medieval monks saw reading and writing as journeys. Mentally traveling through their writing, they drew upon past experiences and ideas. This flow of thought was purposeful, allowing for variations in mood and style.

9 Tim Ingold, *Ways of Mind-Walking: Reading, Writing, Painting*, *Visual Studies* 25 (1): 15–23. 2010. doi:10.1080/14725861003606712.

10 Ingold 2010, 16.

The 12th-century Benedictine Peter of Celle advised scripture readers to imagine themselves walking through a landscape. By actively engaging all their senses, slowing down and speeding up as needed, the reader becomes a *craftsman using various instruments*, fully immersed in the process of understanding.¹¹

In the Middle Ages, people didn't just read religious texts, they lived them. Imagine these texts as vast landscapes you could explore on a pilgrimage. Specific locations became characters and stories from the Bible. By visiting these places, people felt a real connection to the narratives and their figures. This immersive approach wasn't limited to written words. Buildings, too, were designed like intricate texts. Every detail was intended to inspire thought and contemplation. People didn't try to grasp everything at once, but rather moved around and pondered each element. This applied to both reading and viewing art. Images weren't simply visual, nor were words just concepts; both could be experienced through a blend of sight and sound. Ultimately, reading and exploring a landscape weren't so different. Both were journeys of the mind, offering profound encounters with the world.

'One would *read* the painting as a story, moving around the picture space as the events of the narrative unfold.'¹²

Wassily Kandinsky took this approach even further. He believed music, like the works of Mussorgsky, could directly evoke emotions and inner experiences without depicting specific objects. He saw painting as achieving the same effect with colors and shapes. He compared the artist to a musician: colors were the keys, the eye was the hammer striking them, and the canvas served as a multi-stringed instrument resonating with feeling.

For Kandinsky, abstraction wasn't about creating empty spaces, but removing distractions. He aimed to reveal a deeper meaning by stripping away unnecessary details. This *abstract content* resonated with the soul, similar to spiritual concepts found across cultures. True art, for him, wasn't about copying the physical world, but about revealing these inner truths.

Experiencing art, as Kandinsky did while viewing an exhibition while listening to Mussorgsky's music, becomes a spiritual journey. We relive emotions and connect with the creative force that drives everything.

Imagination isn't about creating images of things, but about the creative force that shapes our world and what we experience in art and nature. Kandinsky suggests that art and the world itself share a fundamental structure.

There are six essentials of painting, said he—namely, spirit, resonance, thoughts, motif, brush and ink. To this, Ching Hao remarked: Painting is to make beautiful things, and the important point is to obtain their true likeness, is it not? The old man

11 M. Carruthers, *The Craft of Thought: Meditation, Rhetoric, and the Making of Images*, 400-1200, Cambridge University Press 1998: 109-110.

12 Ingold 2010.

answered, It is not. ...Painting is to paint, to estimate the shapes of things and really obtain them, to estimate the beauty of things and reach it, to estimate the reality of things and grasp it. One should not take outward beauty for reality; he who does not understand this mystery, will not obtain the truth, even though his pictures may contain likeness. Likeness, responded the old man, can be obtained by shapes without spirit, but when truth is revealed, spirit and substance are both fully expressed.¹³



Thinking Like a Carpet

Once you suspend figurative image making, a world of creativity opens up. Large-scale forms, such as figures and narrative, cramp the creative energy of the lines and colors that compose them.¹⁴

In her book *Enfoldment and Infinity*, Laura Marks explores a surprising connection between Islamic art and contemporary media art. What excites Marks is the way Islamic artistic abstraction uses non-representational forms to create a sense of *unnatural* life. Marks argues that these non-figurative images encourage a unique way of seeing that transcends the human perspective.

Imagine looking at a carpet. By entering its intricate patterns from any direction, our own perception becomes a part of creating something new. This idea—that seeing is an act of unfolding—can be found in the work of Ibn al-Haytham, a 10th-century Muslim scientist known as Alhazen in the West. Alhazen, in his book *Treatise on Optics*, proposed a theory of vision that emphasized active perception. He argued that form isn't something we simply see; it's a mental construct built by our brains. This means we need to contemplate what we see to recognize form, using memory, comparison, and imagination. Ultimately, our understanding is limited by our senses and is constantly being shaped by our interaction with the world.

Marks finds a fascinating echo of Alhazen's ideas in the work of French philosopher Henri Bergson. Bergson's concept of the mind as an active interpreter of the world influenced Gilles Deleuze, who argued that perception isn't a mirror reflecting reality, but a process of unfolding the world based on our unique viewpoint.

Normally, we react instinctively to what we see (food, danger, etc.). But Bergson suggests that the more time we spend absorbing the world around us, the more we can perceive. The longer we look, the more we discover (through sight, sound, smell, taste, etc.). This requires us to break free from our automatic reactions and truly contemplate what we see.

13 Sirén 2005, 234-5. Ingold 2010.

14 Laura U. Marks, *Thinking like a carpet: embodied perception and individuation in algorithmic media*, In: Brauerhoch, Annette; Eke, Norbert Otto; Wieser, Renate; Zechner, Anke: *Entautomatisierung*, Paderborn: Fink 2017, S. 39-58. DOI: 10.25969/mediarep/4032.

For example, instead of immediately spearing a charging boar, we might take a moment to observe its details — its fur, its tusks. In some ways, this deep contemplation goes against our basic human instincts for survival, which often demand quick reactions. However, both Alhazen and Bergson propose that true understanding comes from taking the time to contemplate what we experience before acting.

Carpets, at their core, are like woven algorithms. From the loom's grid-like structure to the number of threads per inch, the knot style, and the overall design, each element involves a set of pre-determined instructions. These instructions function much like an algorithm, a set of steps to be followed.

Interestingly, the design itself isn't limited by the carpet's material. Many carpets draw inspiration from other mediums, like paintings. This suggests that the *algorithms* carpets execute can be independent of the material itself. In simpler terms, carpets aren't just about the material; they express a relationship between the material and the idea behind it—the algorithm.

Humans weave intention into algorithms, just like carpet weavers. These creations, far from being cold and emotionless, reflect the choices, thoughts, and even feelings (and sometimes mistakes) of their makers.

Take, for instance, Ottoman-era Turkish carpets—Ushak carpets, for example. They feature interlocking medallions in contrasting colors, each with intricate, swirling patterns, all set on a similarly complex background. These carpets depict a world within a world, a never-ending reflection.

Carpet experts sometimes believe the center, the deepest layer, symbolizes heaven. Often, the designs become more refined as they approach this *divine* center. In a mystical interpretation, these carpets could be seen as teaching the illusion of reality, yet revealing an underlying order to the universe.

So, carpets act as a representation of the cosmos. But even the most structured, hierarchical ones reveal imperfections where concept meets reality.

Instead of focusing on figures that we compare ourselves to, *thinking like a carpet* encourages us to explore how our bodies experience the world. It's not just about seeing, but also about feeling the design and patterns around us. The lines and shapes can even create a sense of movement that we can connect with through touch and sensation.

I think we should attribute the power of the Figural to the non-figurative, or not-quite-figurative, patterns that invaded Western painting from the East. Islamic aesthetics were the undoing of European figurative art. The uneasiness of the Figural often results directly from a confrontation of a molar-scale, figurative image with the rhythmic energy of the abstract line. Whether the carpets themselves are Figural probably lines in whether a person comes to them with a figurative mindset in the first place. Someone accustomed to figurative images may encounter a Figural shock; someone who has spent more time surrounded by non-figurative images is less likely to.¹⁵



Fig. 9. BREATH

The primal scene for what, in the Judo-Christian tradition, deserves to be called inspiration, is the creation of humans - an event that appears in the Genesis account in two versions: once as the final act of the six-day work of creation, though it passes over the life-breathing scene in silence, and once as the initiatory act for all further creation, but now with an explicit emphasis on creation through breath and with the characteristic distinction of clay modeling in the first case and breathing in the second. Here the reader of Genesis encounters the inspirator, the Lord of Creation, as a figure with a sharp ontological profile: He is the first producer with complete authority. The creature into which He breathes life, for its part, appears on the stage of existence as the first human being, the prototype of a species that can experience inspired ideas. The biblical account of the first breath reproduces the original visit of the spirit to a host medium.¹⁶

15 Marks, 2017.

16 Peter Sloterdijk, *Bubbles: Spheres Volume I: Microspherology*, Semiotext(e) 2011: 31.

LOG:: 09 TEMPORAL AUDIOVISUAL WORKOUTS

Was vernünftig ist, das ist wirklich, and was wirklich ist, das ist vernünftig.

—G.W.F. Hegel

What is more educational is most aesthetic, and what is most aesthetic is most educational

—Nam June Paik

What can you do with video without recording and immediately sharing the social self-referential instant?

What can you do with video if you don't record fictional material for whatever mini-feature or story of another self of you?

Are these the right and adequate questions? Shouldn't we rather ask how to stay fit with video? Fit not in the sense of physical exercises, but in the sense of exercises that maintain fitness for technological-driven cinematographic or non-cinematographic audiovisual things, visuals, worlds, or environments.

I like to call this etude, or finger exercises: a post-cinema video practice, or temporal audiovisual workouts. Etudes are exercises to train and make us sensible in our daily lives with video. They are meant to strengthen, maintain, and enjoy. We have to stay fit! Fit with Video for Video!

Etudes for video are little conceptual exercises to train observation, flow, and rhythm, settling a diverse practice, a form. The parallel here is not between running on a machine in a sports salon and running with the camera in extreme position and depth of field shots, or between parameters of the body lifting tools and the parameters of the lens, the parameters of recording, playback, editing and montage, parameters of projection, display, and the sweat of bodies in mirrors.

What Makes You Sweat When You Are Video Graphing?

Etudes in a post-cinema-video practice are about something other than learning how to make better videos through lessons and technical tutorials, advice from influencers, creators, industry insiders, and personal creativity consultants from social media video-driven technological platforms.

Let's think of video as the form and material of a simple camera, a signal, and a processing unit. The exercises should consider diverse aspects of this form.

The etudes are an artistic practice as a form of orientation.

But which elements belong to the form, the frame, and the light when we do not want to fall into the trap of cinematic capital labor and dictatorship?

Body and Hand - video sports or protocols of life, feeling time, longing for contemplation, images of change and natural movement, perception and lateral thinking, water logic, dancing with video, a framework for a hypothesis to experience video not in the old way, to be a barbarian with primitive tools and ways overcoming the obsolete in the static. Language forces us to look at the world in traditional ways, which have become outdated.

Perceptual truth is system truth.¹

In a way, we should stop teaching film/video, or at least stop treating film/video like film/video cinema/video. We should end the Hollywood-like industrial production model and the European countries' cultural subvention model and move on.

Where? TikTok has opened up a different way: multiple speeches, ways to talk, writing in movement, ephemeral, disappearing as the words are uttered, or as the song is sung. But we need a different kind of literacy to utter this speech and free ourselves from any mode of exploitation.

A film festival in 2022 in the Turkish coastal city of Antalya invites 250 students to its film school. It sounds wonderful. Cinema has become everyone's again. But why should we feed a machine that has already run out? Aren't the monstrously hungry streaming platforms and the kids on the block the new feeders and fodder in the barn?

Should we re-learn a way of video to prepare for the new world of non-human actors? What is the method needed? What kind of fiction will they embed? Let's remember: how did we learn to write? We repeated a symbol over and over. Isn't that like TikTok for paper? The teachers should have told us to send our pages to publishers. They didn't invite us to festivals of cultural officials and social workers.

Film studies is dead. Media studies is dead. Cultural studies is dead.

Technologies of video's moving image, politics, and aesthetics are alive.

The big school of social media is taught by TikTok. Every new situation changes the use we can make. The mythos of the great film director is dying, a new type is appearing, and the disappearance of the cinematic championship needs to be accepted and then forgotten to have this new historical moment of great pleasure, a phantasm to create new science and build new knowledge.

Everyone is a creator.

1 Edward De Bono, *Water Logic*, London: Penguin 1993.

Observation

Observation is the basic concept of every video etude or practice. Etudes or audiovisual video practices—workouts for video—can take many forms, many variations, and can be done everywhere, in restaurants, cafes, bars, at train stations, airports, hotels, maybe in classrooms or studios, but also in private spaces—anytime.

Etudes are fragments of time and view – not necessary manipulated through editing, not necessarily operated during recording, and not reframed. These are pure shots, following a basic instruction. Their nature is planned, but their execution is mostly spontaneously, and not really set up or framed. But they have one general condition in common: the way they are practiced.

Etudes follow the spirit of early cinema practice, where movies were attractions of one single shot. But after more than 100 years of cinema history, with the development of television, digital platforms, and mobile media devices, there are no more attractions except going back to the purest form of cinema: time and space. In other words, leaving the sphere of action to action images - as Deleuze would describe it – through a conscious limitation. And therefore giving back to the camera its actual meaning: its character as an object of recording.

Etudes are *fern-sehen*. The German word *fernsehen* or far seeing, which is used for television, comes back to its original meaning.

Etudes are not live. They are live recorded. Also, they are not live streamed. Only in this way can they become *present* whenever they are watched. This happened, this was recorded, it happens, it is actually there, the camera was there, the camera is there, I was there, I am there—and I am here.

Concentration - Conditioning - Celebration²

We need to concentrate. We need to repeat. We need to have fun.

² Daniel Irizarry's three C's in: *Mantı ve Çay. A documentary by Boran Aksoy, Melih Aydinat, Daniel Irizarry and Andreas Treske*. Bilkent University, Ankara 2019. <https://vimeo.com/346824086>, 9 January 2025.

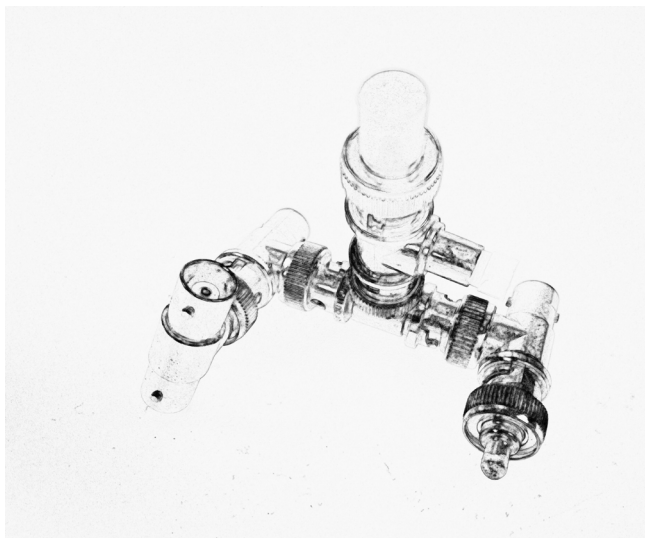


Fig. 10. ALL THINGS MOVE

'All things move, all things run, all things are rapidly changing.'

From the Manifesto of Futurist Painters, April 1910

LOG:: 10 CLAIR-OBSCUR

For everything that is shown, something is hidden.

—James Bridle¹

We have become screen people. Like shopping malls with no outside windows, our travels, as once with trains from one place to another, don't need the window anymore to explore the landscape rushing along. The fantastic world of screens has created Alice's wonderland for us.

We had been warned. The shower curtain of Hitchcock's *Psycho* presented us with the silhouette, obscuring the perpetrator. The medium had presented a veil. But the veil was not covered, and there was no protection. It was just an instrument of suspense, lengthening emotional involvement and tension.

But the inside of the screens, the beautiful screen worlds, present a new now, a now of being together inside. What a marvelous soap bubble.

So, first, windows are replaced by screens. We don't need to look outside, and we don't need light to enter. Second, small screens are in our hands, computing anytime from anywhere and observing us as cameras and multi-functional sensors. Screens and cameras and computers merged into tiny super devices in our hands, building an algorithmically calculated space between our surrounding walls, where the paint watches us.

A constant feedback circuit.

There had always been a trend for invisible technology that blends into the background, a trend to camouflage technology. Hardware is merging and getting smaller, transforming into a future skin, close. This development is no longer about human mobility. Movement has given away to agents, chatbots, or our digital doubles. We are too slow with our bodies and minds, which lack the super microsecond reaction time of high-speed trading worlds.

Amid the limits to the space around us still left in an overcrowded planet we call home, the physical is becoming another interface and distribution environment, an *Umwelt* for us living together with digital objects. The camera itself is becoming the operating system. The real world and the web are a single time and space. Spatial computing turns the world into a new canvas. The camera finally gets its active role. The camera creates the experience of consumption and transaction, a trustworthy platform for extended reality, the next playground for developers, and an obsession for all of us consumers.

1 James Bridle, *New Dark Age: Technology and the End of the Future*, Verso 2018.

The camera or the designed physical object that functions as a camera directly will compute and run applications in a *virtual* representation of the world. Pokemon Go has already given us a little taste of the augmented world to come. Apple Vision or Meta's phantasies are the next step in immersive technology and spatial computing stretching out.

Imagine that we can compute and interact with, on many levels, what we see or sense. The world around us is then programmable, in an always-available and always-on relation with anything digital. We don't need to ask for availability; we always have access to contextualized information. With these new operative lenses, imagination becomes the only limit. This might be the near future of our smartphones. It is all about the camera. It's all about sensing and operation.

Clair-obscur

There is light and shadow. In painting and cinematography, we talk about *chiaroscuro* to describe the use of contrasts of light to give three-dimensional objects and figures some form of volume. In libertine literature of the 18th century, writers questioning and challenging moral principles would rely on veils and *linguistic shadows* to make their texts more intriguing and more erotic. The notion of *Clair-obscur* draws on an analogy between a painter creating harmony between the light and the dark on his canvas and a libertine writer aiming to reach a balance between polarities in pleasures: liaisons unfold between vice and virtue, control and abandonment, society and the self; seductions rely on a compromise between revelation and concealment, clarity and obscurity, bridging the gap between the aesthetic and erotic spheres. *Clairs-obscur*s are conceptualized as crucial factors for a superior form of enjoyment. Darkness is the core and source of artistic and erotic pleasures.² Libertine authors re-evaluated the charms of shadows and departed from the tradition of praising the beauty of light. Obscurity has more than a simple aesthetic function; it is also endowed with erotic powers.

Eye Window Brain

What do the new layers of our world obscure that gives us pleasure? Is pleasure no longer focused on the in-between, the suggestion, the half darkness, or the could be? We see our boring world between four walls, but what reflects our senses is an experience in which we are part of pleasure.

From its moment of initiation, cinema has always had a relationship with money. Capital is the driving force behind the development of audiovisual technologies. What we see or sense is directly influenced by and through technology, controlled by finance. It does nothing but obscure what it does.

2 M. GANOFSKY, *Libertine Clairs-Obscurs: The Enticement of the Shadows*, J 18th Cent Stud, 37: 499-515 2014. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1754-0208.12203>.

Ann Friedberg, in *The Virtual Window: from Alberti to Microsoft*,³ looks at the paintings of the Renaissance painter Leon Alberti and notes that the aim of an *open window* is a metaphor for perception and the organization of a particular form of subjective vision. The visual regime operates on several levels. It shows a variable rectangular frame, uses the window as a metaphor for the frame of the painting, points to the 'subject' seen through the frame, and produces the human figure as a standard of measure and a determined *centric point*, thereby creating the immobility of the viewer.⁴ Consequently, cinema, in the sequence of development of the window as a visual metaphor, is the quintessence of the system of vision imposed by Western aesthetics. Descartes uses, in his description of the *camera obscura*, the word *finestre*—window—to describe the hole in the eye—the *shutter* or lens—that lets light through and focuses light into the retina. The window reference underlines the essential etymological root for the window as a mediating lens to vision.⁵ The metaphor suggests the world is already filtered through a frame, making visual perception inherently unreliable. The rise of camera technology, mirroring the eye, amplifies these anxieties. In essence, early film theories echo Descartes's framework. The *mirror that becomes clear glass*—human vision as a mediating window—evokes the same suspicion Descartes felt when questioning optical illusions. While positioning the human eye as the standard for film, these theorists potentially overlook non-human or future forms of vision.

The urge for cinema to exist independently of human perception mirrors the shift in capitalism where money holds value independent of gold. Both these developments are not just consequences of crisis, but also contribute to it. What defines industrial art is not mechanical reproduction but the internalized relation with money.⁶ Money folds within the cinematic image in an intimate and intrinsic correspondence of forms. Further new structures of power and control just now give way to the erosion of Vertov's camera eye and introduce of new interactions between *film* and life. The regime of vision that implemented the golden mean and produced a whole, unified subject gives way to a new system that Deleuze explicitly points toward: the brain as the screen. The screen has overruled the conventions of the subject and of human posture. It constitutes rather a pool of data and information, a seemingly transparent surface to layer other commercial worlds, replacing the eyes of nature.

'The camera-money exchange has become the only relation that moves through the window.'⁷

In his essay *Postscript on the Societies of Control*, Gilles Deleuze identifies a substantial shift in power dynamics. Modern societies dismantle the defined spaces of family, school, and work, *breaking down interiors* that used to structure people's lives. Individuals are no longer distinct entities within the crowd but *individuals* constantly monitored by control systems. This fragmented state reflects the workings of financial systems, with money itself exemplifying the difference.

3 Ann Friedberg, *The Virtual Window. From Alberti to Microsoft*, The MIT Press 2009.

4 Friedberg 2009: 27.

5 Friedberg 2009: 51.

6 Alasdair King, *The Financial Image. Finance, Philosophy and Contemporary Film*, Springer 2024.

7 Morgan M. Adamson, 'The Closure of the 'Gold Window': From 'Camera-Eye' to 'Brain-Screen', *Film-Philosophy* 17.1 (2013), <https://www.euppublishing.com/doi/pdf/10.3366/film.2013.0014>.

The concept of the brain screen, where the mind becomes a receiving surface for images, perfectly aligns with this era of control. Cinema initially presented itself as an objective window to the world, but ultimately undermined that very idea. The cinematic image precipitates its undoing, and the closure of the gold window points to an ambivalence within film as an industrial art: its flexibility and adaptability to the functioning of systems of control. Furthermore, understanding the function of visual economies in our present world must consider the financial logic that structures the relationship between cinema and money, between video technologies and capital.

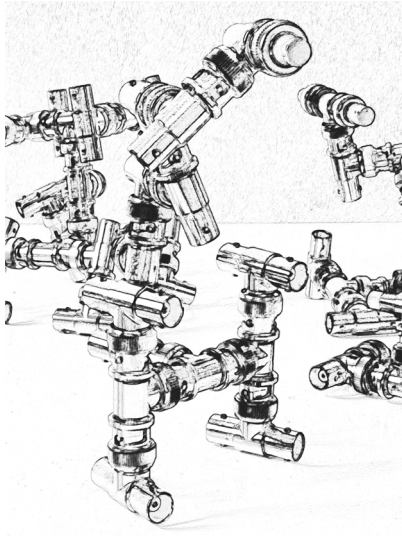


Fig. 11. DOMAIN

Transformers is a media franchise produced by American toy company Hasbro and Japanese toy company Takara Tomy. Initially a line of transforming mecha toys rebranded from Takara's Diaclone and Microman toylines, the franchise began in 1984 with the *Transformers* toy line, and centers on factions of self-configuring modular extraterrestrial robotic lifeforms in an endless civil war for dominance or eventual peace. In its history, the *Transformers* robot superhero franchise has expanded to encompass comic books, animation, video games and films. Marvel's cinematic universe - Construct a fully furnished world and then gradually reveal the space/mythology of that world. Gradually revealing a world's hyperdiegesis and borrowing the spatial configuration of video games creates an environment that encourages exploration. This environment propels hard-core fans to seek out more information, draw connections, and gain a better understanding of the fictional world. At the same time, casual fans can imagine a vast expanse while focusing on the characters and main events of the show.⁸

8 Aaron Smith, *Transmedia Storytelling in Television 2.0*, Thesis, 2009, <https://sites.middlebury.edu/mediacp/about/>, accessed 12 March 2025.

Where diegesis is the narrative world seen by audiences, Matt Hill's hyperdiegesis is the creation of a vast and detailed narrative space, only a fraction of which is ever directly seen or encountered within the text, but which nonetheless appears to operate according to principles of internal logic and extension (2002: 137). This vast world is built throughout the series by accumulating and reiterating details. Mentions of people (The Federation in Star Trek), places (Maps included in Lord of the Rings books), and events ("Vatican cameos!" in Sherlock Holmes) suggest a complete world with a long history. Though gaps in this history may be explored by the primary text in future episodes, fan productions are used to fill them in the meantime. The hyperdiegesis provides a coherent world and the rules of operations by which it works, rules that fans must abide by when they choose to explore the world themselves. While a show's hyperdiegesis needs to remain consistent to maintain the trust of its audience, Hill believes that producers must 'play with their own established rules and norms. . . in order to preserve audience interest'.⁹

9 Matt Hills, *Fan Cultures*, London: Routledge, 2002.

LOG:: 11 LIGHT WANTS CRYSTAL

...the new environment [that] . . . must bring with it a new culture.

—Paul Scheerbart

Glass. It is not plastic. The object might feel like it, but it's not made of plastic. Historically it had been, with smaller screens embedded in a case made of plastic and metals. But now, digital devices have become full screen with less non-screen placed on the front side of the thin rectangular hand-sized object. All screen: to see, to touch.

Glass material is durable, scratch-resistant, and, most importantly, touch-sensitive. New materials like Gorilla Glass provide excellent display clarity, enhance visibility, minimize distortions, allow for solid and easy touch interaction on screen, enhance durability, and actually protect against daily usage—pocket in, pocket out, scratching and crashing, ohh, accidental drops. Glass also added style and visual appeal to the viewing experience.¹

The object became *sleek* and *modern*. Aesthetic appeal pushed for round edges and seamless finishes, generating fashion accessories with changing skins fitting outfits and handbags. Manufacturers using the transparency of glass experiment with colors and textures to provide an increasing amount of design options and personalization. Glass's smooth, reflective surface adds a touch of sophistication and elegance. You carry the object with you as a statement of you.

Glas / Verre / Glass / Crystal

I run all the time like everybody else, I take the train each morning (I live in New Jersey) to slip into the cluster of prisms I see emerging beyond the Hudson, with its sharp cusps; I spend my days there, going up and down the horizontal and vertical axes that crisscross that compact solid, or along the obligatory routes that graze its sides and its edges. But I don't fall into the trap: I know they're making me run among smooth transparent walls and between symmetrical angles so I'll believe I'm inside a crystal, so I'll recognize a regular form there, a rotation axis, a constant in the dihedrons, whereas none of all this exists. The contrary exists: glass, those are glass solids that flank the streets, not crystal, it's a paste of haphazard molecules which has invaded and cemented the world, a layer of suddenly chilled lava, stiffened into forms imposed from the outside, whereas inside it's magma just as in the Earth's incandescent days.²

1 Travis Sharrow, Unveiling the Brilliance: The Truth Behind Why Smartphones are Encased in Glass, Softandtech March 25, 2024. <https://softhandtech.com/why-do-smartphones-have-glass/>.

2 Italo Calvino, Crystals. In: Calvino, Italo. *t zero* (Translated from Italian by William Weaver), New York: Harcourt, Brace & World, 1969.

Like many cities in the world, since the 2010s, Ankara's look has changed. Along the main roads, high-rises with reflecting glass surfaces have been built one after another. The glass curtain facade has been the representative standard for office buildings and skyscrapers for decades. More or less, they have a uniform appearance in cities worldwide; glass stands for the confidence of capital.

Contemporary glass architecture also gives us some idea about the possibilities of the material glass. Building glass is coated with a thin wash of color or stained, printed, lacquered, laminated, and used in conjunction with many other materials. Transparency and translucency vary in different forms. The crystalline character reappears with colorful shapes, broken surfaces, and asymmetries. In darkness and when lit from the inside, some buildings appear to be made simply of light.³ Glass pushes color to the foreground; translucency allows matte glass walls, playful illusionary settings of spaces, and exchanges between variations of interiors. Moreover, a glass surface is alive through light reflection and mirror effects.

Manufacturers like Zeiss are producing new multifunctional *Smart Glass* materials, which offer transparent holographic displays, enabling spatial computing as promoted by the latest personal VR, AR, and XR devices.⁴ Initially developed for space flight, the technology enables new lighting, display, projection, filtering, and touch detection. Glass is combined with transparent plastic surfaces, micro-optical structures, and holographic optical elements. This technology enables head displays for automobiles and aircraft, displaying augmented-reality overlays of vehicle status for the driver or pilot. The glass material can power holographic cameras and transparent displays with projected keyboards. Wherever glass is used, this technology can add a digital layer on any otherwise transparent surfaces, such as windows of buildings, screens, and side windows of vehicles, forming multiple imaginable usages. They are becoming on-demand communication screens. A layer is generated within a thin, transparent layer, sandwiched between glass sheets, to which ultra-high-precision optics are attached. Car windows might only be the start. The technology enables fluent switches in cockpits and smart home applications. It also allows direct eye contact between people in videoconferences by placing a transparent camera in the middle of a device's screen.

Glass is matter. It is light. Glass is immortal, and also fragile. Glass can be viewed in terms of its many profound contradictions: at once firm and delicate, solid and liquid, and formed of sand and ash, being of the earth but appearing otherworldly in its chemical complexity, and in the mysterious duality of its transparency: revealing and yet veiling, altering perceptions.

Glass can be transparent and translucent. You cannot see clearly through translucent material, as it has a blurry surface. Translucent construction in architecture acknowledges the separation of exterior and interior. Using subtle manipulations of visual perception, the ambiguity between the two realms is often the primary field of inquiry. It accompanies the interruption

3 Barbara Linz, *Glass = Glas = Verre*. H.f. ullmann, 2009.

4 ZEISS at CES 2024. Multifunctional Smart Glass for a wide range of application Press Release 14 December 2023. - <https://www.zeiss.com/corporate/en/about-zeiss/present/newsroom/press-releases/2023/microoptics-ces.html>.

of space flowing across the exterior boundary of the building's spaces and its physical structure at its exterior face. The American architect and curator Terence Riley characterized this separation as a veil constituted by an imposed delay in apprehension between viewer and space beyond: a *triggered subjectivity*.⁵

Transparency

The idea of in-betweenness is inseparable from glass. The material exists at a threshold, chemically speaking, and the debate continues as to whether glass is an amorphous solid or a super-cooled liquid. What is clear, though, is that glass exists as a state between a liquid and a solid. This means that despite having properties of both liquid and solid, glass is neither. It is too dense to be a crystalline solid and too cohesive in molecule structure to be a liquid.

In these glass-walled, *transparent* enclosures or environments, things are not as they seem; reality becomes skewed. A general belief in the transparent, vision-enabling properties of glass is evident in its incorporation into optical devices such as glasses, magnifying lenses, and camera lenses. However, early musings on the nature of glass allude to its illusory qualities, linked only in part to seeing.

In the 1960s Colin Rowe and Robert Slutzky's influential essays on transparency set in motion critical discussion.

Transparency may be an inherent quality of substance—as in a wire mesh or glass curtain wall, or it may be an inherent quality of organization.⁶

Rowe and Slutzky distinguished between two senses of transparency: literal, real transparency, and phenomenal, seeming transparency. Adrian Forty added a third sense of transparency: transparency of meaning (Adrian Forty, 2004).⁷ Forty build upon Susan Sontag's statement that it should be clear that what is there should have no ambiguity between form and contents. The truth of material must exhibit its character.

The myth of transparency has haunted modernity. We are obsessed with everything being open and transparent: people revealing themselves to nature and each other, and society knowing everything about everyone. This transparency is often on display in buildings made of glass, where spaces flow into each other and light and movement are everywhere. Glass has always been more than just practical. It's been linked to fantasy, myths, and utopian dreams. Legends about glass, like King Solomon's palace, which was built of glass and water, show how glass can be both revealing and create illusions.

5 Annette Fierro, *The Glass State: The Technology of the Spectacle*, Paris, 1981 - 1988, The MIT Press 2006: 99 - 100.

6 Colin Rowe and Robert Slutzky, *Transparency: Literal and Phenomenal*, *Perspecta*, vol. 8, 1963: 45–54, JSTOR, <https://doi.org/10.2307/1566901>. Accessed 9 January 2025: 161.

7 Adrian Forty, *Words and Buildings: A Vocabulary of Modern Architecture*, Thames & Hudson 2004: 288.

King Solomon used a glass floor to expose the Queen of Sheba's true nature. He wanted to know if she was a real woman or a genie (said to have hairy legs). The Queen, tricked by glass that looked like water, lifted her skirt to avoid getting wet, revealing her human legs. This story perfectly shows the paradox of glass architecture: it tells the truth through an illusion, truth and myth in the appearance of glass itself.⁸

Leandro Erlich's *Swimming Pool*,⁹ first created in 1999, is an art installation with a glass floor permanently housed at the 21st Century Museum of Art in Kanazawa, Japan, with past temporary exhibits at MoMAPS1 and the Venice Biennale. The installation creates an optical illusion of a filled swimming pool through a very clever design: visitors above look down to see people walking at the bottom of what appears to be a water-filled pool, while those below experience the effect of being underwater through a glass ceiling with a thin layer of flowing water above it. The piece includes typical pool features like a ladder, allowing visitors to interact with the installation and experience the underwater illusion while remaining dry.

In medieval stories, glass symbolized pure, honest love. By the 1800s, its reflective nature made glass a symbol of self-absorption and the path to understanding oneself and changing. Paul Scheerbart's 1913 manifesto, *Glass Architecture*, envisioned a future filled with magnificent glass buildings on mountaintops bathed in colorful light. He believed glass architecture could create a utopian world, protected from harm and shining brightly. Paul Scheerbart and the architect Bruno Taut dreamed up a utopian architectural style based on extensive use of glass. This vision, largely unrealized, is slowly gaining recognition as a forgotten strand of Modern Architecture.

Scheerbart and Taut, however, saw their *Glass Architecture* as an inheritor to the Gothic cathedral. They admired how stained Glass in cathedrals created a unique atmosphere, filtering light and hinting at a heavenly realm. This artistic manipulation of light, they believed, could elevate people morally. Scheerbart even argued that daily exposure to beautiful glass would make people better! He saw it as more than decoration, but as a powerful force for good.

Paul Scheerbart viewed glass architecture as instead offering the possibility for a new cosmopolitan spirituality and a transcendent connection to nature. Glass, for Scheerbart, embodied the metaphoric potentiality of color and light, and the crystal was the natural form that symbolized these ideals. In *Glass Architecture*, he dreamt of buildings that were anti monumental, always changing, never the same.¹⁰

Unlike many early modernist buildings that aimed to reveal the true nature of things, Glass in Taut's work wasn't about transparency but about creating an illusion of another, dreamlike reality. Instead of using glass to maximize light and create open spaces like the modernist

8 Rosemarie Haag Bletter, 'The Interpretation of the Dream-Expressionist and the History of the Crystal Metaphor', *The Journal of the Society of Architectural Historians*, Vol. 40, No. 1, 23 March 1981.

9 Leandro Erlich: *Swimming Pool*. 19 October 2008–12 April 2009. <https://www.moma.org/calendar/exhibitions/4922>.

10 *Glass! Love!! Perpetual Motion!!! A Paul Scheerbart Reader*. Edited by Josiah McElheny and Christine Burgin. University of Chicago 2014.

architect Loos, Taut focused on colored glass and light. This wasn't about letting in more light, but bathing the space in a softer, colored light that filtered through the colored glass, creating gentler, more muted experience.

Only some of what's clear is genuinely transparent. Artists like Taut and Scheerbart believed colored glass could improve society, not plain glass. The word *transparent* itself has been misused, confusing how glass reveals the world. Historically, from ancient to modern architects, glass's symbolic meaning goes beyond its physical clarity. Glass can be invisible (like windshields or screens) and distort reality (like in scientific instruments). Even in modern architecture, perfect transparency is a myth, and glass can also represent hope for humanity. Buildings like Libeskind's Freedom Tower use glass not for its clarity but for its ghostly reflection and the way it creates a sense of absence. This reflects postmodern ideas of space and embodies the utopian vision of glass in a contemporary way.

We're bombarded with the idea that everything should be transparent: open, accountable, readily available. This ideal is especially pushed online, where transparent screens and easy access are the keys to a better world. But is transparency all it's cracked up to be? The dark side of transparency is the constant feeling of being watched (*black boxes*), the overwhelming amount of information (*black transparency*), and the frustration of unclear communication (finger smudges, bad connections).

Violent Opaque

Instead of striving for perfect transparency, the art project by Malaysian curator Ray Tat and Gabriel de Sita *VIOLENT OPAQUE* proposes embracing the messiness of communication. It focuses on the *opaque* aspects of our digital world—things that are unclear, uncertain, and frustrating. This *violence* isn't physical, but rather the emotional impact of unclear communication. Examples of *VIOLENT OPAQUE* are the frustration of a blurry video call, the uncertainty of who you're talking to online, and the feeling of being watched without knowing who's watching. The project argues that by acknowledging the messiness of communication, we can have a more realistic understanding of our digital world.¹¹

When information is readily available, according to Byung-Chul Han, societies rely less on trust and more on control. Transparency doesn't build trust; it creates a system of constant monitoring. With instant communication everywhere, long-term planning becomes difficult because everything needs immediate attention. The continuous flow of information makes it harder to disagree or have different opinions. Transparency pressures everyone to conform. Transparency is a tool a neoliberal economic system uses to turn everything into data that can be controlled. Transparency overexposes people, making them vulnerable. It seems like freedom but leads to constant surveillance, as in social media becoming Bentham's panopticon.

11 Video Vortex XI Kochi 2017 Conference Report. 23 – 26 February 2017, Kochi, India. <https://networkcultures.org/blog/publication/video-vortex-xi-kochi-2017-conference-report/>.

Transparency is an idea that sounds good on the surface, but when taken too far, becomes dangerous and controlling. In our fast-paced world, there's no room for privacy or reflection. This constant flow of information and communication disrupts everything.¹²

Our society prioritizes constant display and image over substance. Everything is judged by its *exhibition value*, meaning its ability to be seen and consumed. This continuous display has a pornographic quality, where everything is exposed and devoid of hidden depths. This system thrives on *attention capital*, where the more attention something gets, the more valuable it becomes. This leaves no room for *dwelling* or appreciating things on their terms. There's only the pressure to be constantly showing off and seeking validation. In this culture of exhibition, only the visible matters. The *invisible*, anything that doesn't generate attention or fit the mold of the constant display, is deemed unimportant. This creates a society obsessed with external appearances without any inner depth or meaning. >Everything must become visible. The imperative of transparency suspects everything that does not submit to visibility. Therein lies its violence.¹³

Images designed to be easily grasped (exhibition value) lack complexity. They are so clear that they become like pornography: obvious and lacking any challenge that might make you think, no brokenness, nothing to reflect upon. Further, faster communication comes at a cost. It simplifies things to speed them up, sacrificing depth for speed. This *anesthetic hypercommunication* ignores the senses, which are slower but would be more prosperous. Transparency, then, means a lack of sensory experience.

Transparency wants to eliminate all distance, making everything readily available. However, this destroys true closeness. Real proximity requires space for contemplation, which is impossible when everything is constantly in your face. This *tactile perception* eliminates the beauty of observing and reflecting. Transparency removes all sense of distance, creating a uniform state that's neither close nor far.

Pleasure requires some mystery. Transparency strips information bare, making it uninteresting and flat. While sometimes seen as negativity to be banished, mystery is a valuable cultural tool. It creates symbolism and depth, even if it is unclear.

In essence, technology acts as an extension of our senses and nervous system. Cameras capture what we see, and digital media reflects our thoughts and emotions. Social media, in particular, reveals the unconscious aspects of society as a whole. The digital world totalizes algorithms, calculations, and accumulation. It takes existing forms of communication, like pictures and movies, and makes them adaptable and endlessly reproducible.¹⁴

12 Byung-Chul Han, *The Transparency Society*, Stanford University Press 2015.

13 Han 2015.

14 Byung-Chul Han, *Digitale Rationalisten und das Ende des kommunikativen Handelns*, 2013 page 28.

Crystal Palace

The 1851 *Great Exhibition* showcased a significant shift in British society. The focus moved from aristocracy and beauty to the middle class and industry. Notably, the *Crystal Palace*, a giant glass and iron building filled with global products, embodied this change. Following Walter Benjamin, Hiroki Azuma compares it to an arcade, a space for leisurely browsing. This aligns with the idea of the tourist as a *flâneur*, someone who casually wanders and observes. The tourist, as a contemporary figure, like a window shopper, is drawn by chance encounters and discoveries, sometimes uncovering things locals might prefer hidden. This *drifting* nature is critical to understanding tourists. It has both limitations and potential for exploration.¹⁵

Moreover, the image of the arcade and that of the Crystal Palace is also deeply related to nineteenth-century political thought. It is well known that the great imaginative socialist Charles Fourier used the arcade as a model for designing the building for his ideal community of phalanges. In other words, Fourier saw the shopping mall as a utopia, or at least thought it could serve as a foundation for such a utopia. The emergence of the arcade, a new space for consumption where a new class of people supported by new industries and new technologies congregate, provided a new utopian image for contemporary socialists.¹⁶

Fyodor Dostoevsky's novella *Notes from the Underground* criticizes the future vision of another writer, Nikolai Chernyshevsky. A key symbol in this critique is the *Crystal Palace*. Chernyshevsky saw the *Crystal Palace* as a model for a future society. This society would be wealthy and comfortable, with people living in beautiful, modern structures. Dostoevsky's *Underground Man* hates this idea. He calls the *Crystal Palace* a *chicken coop* because it represents a world without room for rebellion or individuality. People would be stuck in a perfect, boring society, unable to express anger. The *Crystal Palace*'s focus on technology and consumption as the path to happiness disgusts the *Underground Man*.

Two opposing visions of the future are confronted. The Utopian Dream is a future filled with connection, shared experiences, and potentially even freedom from work thanks to technology. This vision is similar to ideas of utopian socialism and the *Californian Ideology*. It reflects the concept of a globally unified humanity, achieving *the unity of mankind*. Dostoevsky's character, the Underground Man, rejects this utopian dream entirely. He doesn't care about technological advancements or the homogenization of the world through consumerism. The Underground Man's rebellion isn't about the specifics of the utopia but the very idea itself. He believes humans have the right to be unhappy, irrational, and even *cringeworthy*. He sees forced happiness as a loss of his individuality and humanity.

15 Walter Benjamin, *The Arcades Project*, tr. H. Eiland and K. McLaughlin, Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press, 1999: 158.

16 Hiroki Azuma, *Philosophy of the Tourist*, Urbanomic 2022.

The Underground Man becomes the archetype for those who reject a future of forced happiness and sameness, valuing the right to experience suffering and individuality over a comfortable but uniform existence.

Arcades

Walter Benjamin notes, reflecting on the arcades of Paris, that a society lost in dreams doesn't learn from the past. Everything seems both wholly new and repetitive. Even the feeling of something being cutting-edge is a dreamlike distortion, like the idea of everything eternally repeating. Their perception of time is chaotic and layered, just like their perception of space. Once this society becomes conscious, they start categorizing things based on political and religious ideas. These categories act as a filter, slowing down the constant flow of events and form history. Just as a crystal formation captures light, these categories capture the flow of time. Similar to how a full stomach doesn't directly influence the dreams of a sleeper, the economic situation doesn't directly appear in a society's dreams. However, it does get interpreted and reflected in their dreams. When they wake up, they can finally understand the true meaning behind those dreamlike interpretations.

Unlike artistic creations, technological advancements succeed when their social impact is clear and easy to understand. This is why things like glass architecture are successful - they are transparent in their purpose. These early shopping malls were a forerunner of modern department stores. They were built during a time that Balzac described as a period of extravagant displays. Filled with luxury goods, these arcades blurred the line between art and commerce. Everyone admired them, and they became a major tourist attraction. Described as miniature cities, these glass-roofed walkways offered a luxurious shopping experience under the first gas lights.¹⁷

The second condition for the emergence of the arcades is the beginning of iron construction. The Empire saw in this technology a contribution to the revival of architecture in the classical Greek sense. ... Empire is the style of revolutionary terrorism, for which the state is an end in itself. Just as Napoleon failed to understand the functional nature of the state as an instrument of domination by the bourgeois class, so the architects of his time failed to understand the functional nature of iron, with which the constructive principle begins its domination of architecture. These architects design supports resembling Pompeian columns, and factories that imitate residential houses, just as later the first railroad stations will be modeled on chalets. Construction plays the role of the subconscious. Nevertheless, the concept of engineer, which dates from the revolutionary wars, starts to gain ground, and the rivalry begins between builder and decorator, *Ecole Poly technique* and *Ecole des Beaux-Arts*.¹⁸

17 Benjamin 1999: 465.

18 Benjamin 1999.

For the first time in the history of architecture, an artificial building material appeared: iron. It undergoes an evolution whose tempo accelerates. The rail becomes the first prefabricated iron component. Iron is used in arcades, exhibition halls, and train station buildings that serve transitory purposes. At the same time, the range of architectural applications for glass expands. However, the social prerequisites for its widened application as a building material will come to the fore only a hundred years later. In Scheerbart's *Glasarchitektur* (1914), it still appears in the context of *utopia*.¹⁹

As a new way of producing things emerges, people imagine a future shaped by the new and the old. These visions are like wishes, reflecting a desire to overcome limitations while holding onto familiar aspects. At the same time, they push away anything outdated, even the recent past. This yearning for something new can sometimes lead to a romanticized version of the distant past, a time without social classes.

Inspired by the rise of machines, Charles Fourier envisioned a future where people live together harmoniously, free from the moral corruption of the business world. His phalanstery, a giant communal living space, is described with intricate details that function like machinery but are built with human passions and desires. This *human machine* creates a paradise, a wish for a perfect society that echoes throughout history, a heaven on earth.

Fourier took inspiration for his phalanstery from the arcades and shopping centers he saw around him. He flipped their purpose, transforming them from commercial spaces to places of residence. This colorful, idyllic vision contrasted with the strict forms of his era. Even later writers, like Zola, show the influence of Fourier's ideas, even as they move away from the specific details of his utopia. Benjamin points out the rise of panoramas. Panoramas, large-scale painted views, marked a turning point. They emerged alongside the technological advancements of iron and Glass construction, suggesting a move away from traditional artistic forms. Panoramas aimed for extreme realism, using techniques to depict changing light and movement. This focus on capturing real-life details foreshadowed photography and film.

Parallel to this was a new type of literature mirroring panoramas. Panoramas influenced a style of writing that presented snippets of life and information, similar to how panoramas combined foreground details with background landscapes. This literature also reflected social changes, depicting the working class within a broader societal context. Panoramas became a way for city dwellers to connect with nature, bringing the countryside into the urban environment.

With his knowledge of lighting and scenic effects, the inventor of photography, Louis Daguerre, collaborated with diorama painters from 1821 and owned himself a profitable diorama theatre in Paris. In 1839, his panorama burned down. Daguerre was able to save his experiments, daguerreotype specimens, notes, and equipment and publicly announced his invention just a couple of months later: the daguerreotype.

19 Benjamin 1999: 4.

The Glass House

To live in a glass house is a revolutionary virtue par excellence. It is also an intoxication, a moral exhibitionism, that we badly need. Discretion concerning one's own existence, once an aristocratic virtue, has become more and more an affair of petit-bourgeois parvenus.²⁰

A lens in the landscape is how the photographer Welling described Philip Johnson's glass house.²¹ Philip Johnson, following the footsteps of his mentor and collaborator Mies van der Rohe, writes about his glass house:

The multiple reflections on the 18' pieces of plate glass, which seem superimposed on the view through the house, help give the glass a type of solidity; a direct Miesian aim which he expressed twenty-five years ago: I discovered by working with actual glass models that the important thing is the play of reflections and not the effect of light and shadow as in ordinary buildings.²²

Johnson chose these words to accompany the most captivating photograph in his pathbreaking 1950 essay detailing the influences on his new home. The photograph of the north end of the west wall depicts Johnson reading at his desk. More importantly, the giant pane of glass absorbs the entire landscape and sweeps trees onto its reflective surface—what Johnson irreverently referred to as *very expensive wallpaper*.

Modern architecture started as a broad movement with many goals. It aimed to create a perfect society through innovative design and technology, and its supporters avoided calling it a *style*. In 1920s Europe, these architects believed in using honest materials (especially glass, steel, and concrete) and letting the building's function determine its form. They saw architecture as a way to improve society as a whole. The one person who kept changing modern architecture from a movement to a style was Philip Johnson. In 1932, Johnson, a young curator at the Museum of Modern Art, helped introduce to American audiences what he, together with Henry-Russell Hitchcock, called the International Style. Both insisted on calling it a Style (with a capital S). They also used other words like *contemporary* and *current*. This switch to calling it a Style had a significant impact.

Johnson later reminisced about the publication that accompanied the exhibition: >One of the points that the book made was a key one—that the Modern movement was a *style* similar to Gothic or Baroque, and it was that point which caused the objections from practicing architects.²³

20 Walter Benjamin, *Surrealism*, in *Reflections: Essays, Aphorisms, Autobiographical Writings*, Peter Demetz ed., transl. Edmund Jephcott (New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1978), p. 180. Cited after *Maison de Verre* pg 4 ...

21 Noam M. Elcott, *Reflections on Glass Houses*. 2011. <https://www.columbia.edu/cu/arhistory/faculty/Elcott/Elcott-2011-Reflections-on-Glass-Houses.pdf>, 9 January 2025.

22 Philip Johnson, *House at New Canaan, Connecticut* (1950). Reprinted in David Whitney and Jeffrey Kipnis, *Philip Johnson: The Glass House*. New York: Pantheon Books, 1993: 13.

23 Philip Johnson, Foreword to Hitchcock, Henry-Russell and Johnson, Philip. *The International Style*. New

Johnson wouldn't become a practicing architect for a decade; he eventually designed his own houses that perfectly embodied the minimalist style of Mies van der Rohe. The houses—the Glass House and the Brick House, completed in 1949 on his estate—could be seen as the pinnacle of Modern architecture. However, this achievement also marked the movement's decline. For Johnson, Modernism became just another historical style from which to draw, as seen in his later architectural works.

Modernism meant the negation of the past, an annihilation of history. Early twentieth-century avant-gardes declared an absolute rupture with the past. F. T. Marinetti spoke for many avant-garde artists when in 1909 he exclaimed: >Do you, then, wish to waste all your best powers in this eternal and futile worship of the past, from which you emerge fatally exhausted, shrunken, beaten down?²⁴

Johnson's Glass House—the structure and the estate—can be seen as one attempt to redo modernism with a sense of history. This seems contradictory. Nevertheless, the Glass House embodies a Modernism born not of necessity, ideology, or functionality but rather of exhibitions and books—in a word, history. Where Modernists fancied themselves creators *ex nihilo*, Johnson's 1950 essay on the Glass House enthusiastically cited source after source, from the Acropolis and Karl Friedrich Schinkel to Le Corbusier and Mies van der Rohe.²⁵

Johnson turned his estate into a personal museum, or in his words, the *diary of an eccentric architect*. In a 1970 TIME Magazine article entitled *The Duke of Xanadu at Home*, art critic Robert Hughes emphasized that *most of all, in Johnson's view, people need a sense of history*.²⁶

A traditional Modernist genealogy of the Glass House follows the bread crumbs left by Mies in his Farnsworth House (1945–51), through Pierre Chareau's *Maison de Verre* (1928–32), all the way back to Joseph Paxton's Crystal Palace (1851). One might add Walter Gropius's Dessau Bauhaus (1925–26) or the *Galérie des machines* (1889) and the other great glass and iron constructions clustered around world exhibitions in the late nineteenth century. The story is the same. The maxim is light, air, openness—in a word, transparency.²⁷

Johnson emphasizes a processional approach to architecture, where the building unfolds and reveals itself gradually through movement and time. The design of the approach road ensures visitors experience the full depth of the Glass House from multiple angles, surpassing the experience at the Acropolis, where visitors can only perceive three corners at once.

York: W. W. Norton, 1995: 16.

24 Filippo Tommaso Marinetti, *The Founding and Manifesto of Futurism 1909*, *Futurist Manifestos*, ed. Umbro Apollonio, Boston: MFA Publications, 2001: 23.

25 Elcott 2011.

26 Robert Hughes, *The Duke of Xanadu at Home*, 1970. Reprinted in Whitney and Kipnis, Philip Johnson: *The Glass House*: 56.

27 Elcott 2011.

The diagonal approach reveals the building's depth in stages. Johnson allows visitors to see all four corners through the transparent structure.

However, Johnson's processional architecture is designed for a small, elite audience, unlike the public experience of the Acropolis. With its private studies and intimate tours, the Glass House estate resembles the processional experience of 18th-century mansions, not the public spectacle of modern architecture often celebrated.

Light

At the heart of every smartphone, laptop, and modern electronic device lies an invisible technological marvel that depends on light. While we often think of light technology in terms of photography or architecture, its most profound impact may be actually in the realm of semiconductor manufacturing.

ASML in Veldhoven produces advanced chip-making machines—photolithography machines which are used to produce computer chips. ASML is partnering with Zeiss in Jena, which provides the sophisticated optical systems essential to ASML's extreme ultraviolet (EUV) lithography machines. These machines use incredibly precise light patterns, projected through specialized lenses, to create the microscopic circuits that power our digital world.

The process is akin to an ultra-precise form of photography, but at a scale so small it challenges our imagination. Using light, these machines pattern circuits onto silicon wafers, creating structures at the nanoscale - thousands of times thinner than a human hair. This light-based manufacturing process has become the foundation of modern computing, enabling the creation of increasingly powerful chips.

The implications of this technology extend far beyond the clean rooms where chips are manufactured. Every time we use a smartphone, start our car, or interact with any modern appliance, we're relying on components that were created by these machines. It's a reminder that while we often focus on the digital nature of modern technology, its physical foundation rests on our ability to harness and control light with extraordinary precision.

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To say that light is a medium is a refusal to realize that there are at least three definitions of light. Light can be a Signal of information (I use electricity to transmit impulses that, in Morse code, mean particular messages); light can be a Message (if my girlfriend puts a light in the window, it means her husband has gone out); and light can be a Channel (if I have the light on in my room I can read the message-book). In each of these cases the impact of a phenomenon on the social body varies according to the role it plays in the communication chain.²⁸

28 Umberto Eco, titled *Towards a Semiological Guerrilla Warfare* and published as part of his essay collection *Travels in Hyperreality*, where he refutes what Marshall McLuhan said about light as a

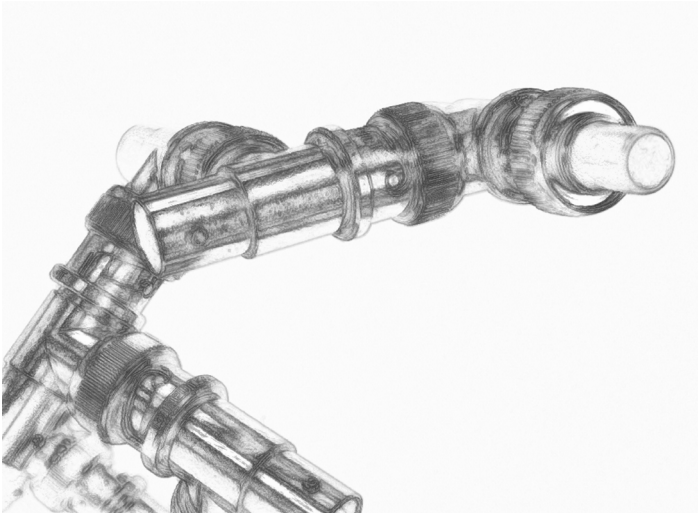


Fig. 12. YOU

Now objects perceive me, the painter Paul Klee wrote in his Notebooks. This rather startling assertion has recently become objective fact, the truth. After all, aren't they talking about producing a vision machine in the near future, a machine that would be capable not only of recognising the contours of shapes, but also of completely interpreting the visual field, of staging a complex environment close-up or at a distance? Aren't they also talking about the new technology of visionics: the possibility of achieving sightless vision whereby the video camera would be controlled by a computer? The computer would be responsible for the machine's - rather than the televiewer's - capacity to analyse the ambient environment and automatically interpret the meaning of events. Such technology would be used in industrial production and stock control; in military robotics, too, perhaps.²⁹ —Paul Virilio

medium, <http://tesugen.com/archives/03/10/eco-on-media>.

29 Paul Virilio, *Vision Machine*. 1994: 59.

LOG:: 12 SHARPNESS

In this language of images, one must lose completely the notion of image. The images must exclude the idea of image.

—Robert Bresson, 1997

As video becomes ever more realistic and sharper, it somehow loses something essential—a certain mystery or illusion present in older media forms. Unlike the analog television image written line by line, creating a progressive scanning effect, digital video appears as a complete, instantaneous image. This fullness, this crystal clarity, can feel almost unsettling or *unheimlich* (uncanny).

This explains the deliberate addition of softness or *cuteness* to ultra-sharp digital images. It's as if we are trying to create emotional distance from the overwhelming clarity of digital video. Think of how bokeh (that beautiful blur in out-of-focus areas of photographs) has become not just a technical effect but an aesthetic choice that adds emotional depth. We are encountering a paradox of clarity and distance.

The streaming era has changed our relationship with moving images in fundamental ways. While traditional cinema was always experienced *there*, in specific architectural spaces within cities, streamed content exists in an immediate *here and now*. This immediacy creates a kind of closeness that needs to be mediated, softened, or disguised in some way for comfortable sharing.

The technical evolution reflects this tension. From the 525 or 625 vertical scan lines of early television to today's 4K resolution (3,840 horizontal pixels), we have pursued ever-greater clarity. When Hollywood transitioned from analog to digital, they needed to jump straight to 4K imagery because 2K appeared too grainy on large screens. Yet paradoxically, as our ability to capture and display crystal-clear images has improved, we continue to develop numerous techniques and filters to reintroduce blur, softness, and imperfection. There must be something profound about human perception and emotion: sometimes clarity needs to be veiled to be truly seen, and precision needs to be softened to be fully felt. The *unschärfe* (blur) isn't just a technical imperfection—it's a bridge to emotional connection.

When George Lucas shot Star Wars Episode II in 2002 with the first digital cinema cameras, he and his crew encountered digital clarity as one of their essential problems. All of a sudden, smudges and brushstrokes in the makeup were visible. Lucas needed to use filters to soften the image and make it less sharp. Sets, costumes and makeup needed to be more precise and refined. Everything needed to be more finely detailed.¹

1 American Cinematographer: George Lucas Interview Interview by Ron Magid. <https://theasc.com/magazine/sep02/exploring/>, accessed 1 December 2024.

In 1986, long before digital video became commonplace, an interesting paradox of image quality emerged during the filming of John Lennon's *Imagine* music video, as Babette Mangolte notes.² Using a prototype Sony high-definition video camera, the crew obsessed over the image sharpness on their monitors. However, when transferred to 35mm film, these *perfectly sharp* electronic images revealed unexpected patterns of sharpness and softness—quite different from what traditional film emulsion would produce. The image seemed to exist in two stark states: either sharp or soft, without the subtle gradations typically found in film.

This early experience with high-definition video foreshadowed issues that would later emerge in digital cinema. Take 1995's *Toy Story*, for example. As the first fully digital feature animation, it exhibited an almost unnatural total sharpness across the entire frame, lacking the natural depth-of-field effects we're accustomed to in traditional film. While later digital animations learned to mimic traditional film techniques like chiaroscuro and selective focus, there remained something artificial about digital softness. The hard-edged nature of pixels always lurked beneath the surface.

Interestingly, many filmmakers today actively avoid the pristine sharpness of digital video, preferring to manipulate shutter speeds to create what they call the *film look*, essentially recreating the motion blur characteristic of traditional film.

While extreme sharpness might seem to prevent the mind from wandering freely (a quality valued in certain types of cinema), the real challenge may lie in the digital image's brightness and its collapse of the distinction between *real time* and *screen time*. Rather than freeing the mind to wander, this hyper-clarity creates a kind of restlessness - perhaps explaining why we often seek to soften these too-perfect images.

•

Zoom

And then there are the blurred backgrounds in our daily video conferencing, hiding the wall, the pictures, the shelf, the cafe, hotel lobby, the transitional space to isolate the head, the face, the shoulder, the close up. . .

Clair obscure.

2 Babette Mangolte, A Matter of Time. e-flux notes. 2024, <https://www.e-flux.com/notes/641724/a-matter-of-time>, accessed 10 January 2025.

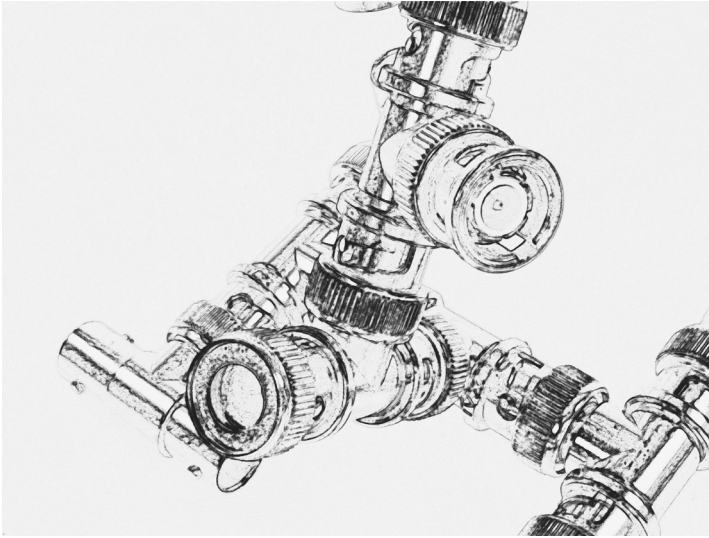


Fig. 13. UTOPIA > It is not as if the world has not long, long been one in which vast numbers live in dystopian depredation. The horizon is more visible now to many who had thought themselves insulated, if they thought about it at all. And dystopia for some is utopia for others. To repeat something I have said elsewhere, we live in a utopia: it just isn't ours. > —China Miéville³

³ China Miéville, *A Strategy for Ruination*. An interview with China Miéville. 8 January 2018. <https://bostonreview.net/literature-culture-china-mieville-strategy-ruination>, accessed 12 January 2025.

LOG:: 13 PHANTOM WORLDS OR EVEN CATS WATCH TV

This TV should change its form.

—KasputNiK

SCOTT me up, be me!¹ *Cats! Cats! Cats! Cats!* Why are all these people watching cat videos over and over again and again? What is it that makes cats celebrity brands? People watch cats doing hilarious and adorable things, strange and cheesy. An Indiana University study reveals that viewing cat videos *boosts positive emotions and decreases negative feelings*.² Wow! Pleasure!

So Cute

We have to come to terms with our understanding of reality. We are living in a cold and technical world. Seeing something *cute* is a relief for a few seconds, a let go from the perfectness, the operational, and excellence. Sianne Ngai calls it the *erotization of powerlessness*.³ Cuteness is not just about cats; it is part of a system and a matter of politics. Cuteness can be a strategy for individuals to resist or to gain some kind of status.

An excellence-cuteness syndrome drives our society. Everything is becoming the same in a world shaped by globalization and neoliberal work cultures. In the past, people found meaning in their religion and culture. Now, all we care about is being cute or excellent. But these don't give our lives any real purpose; they're just shallow ways of trying to look good. We only want to be cute or excellent to show off; it's all about ourselves. This obsession with cuteness and excellence is a form of self-absorption that people and societies use to define themselves. But who we are is about things that can't be measured, like our feelings, beliefs, and experiences. Our culture shapes these things. Importantly, they can't be quantified. Focusing on cuteness and excellence doesn't connect us to these more profound things. Instead, it just makes us chase after the latest trends and fads or try to outdo each other in superficial ways. It doesn't make us feel any better. Consequently, our obsession with cuteness and excellence can quickly become an unhealthy habit.⁴

1 Beam me up, Scotty! - Captain Kirk in Enterprise ...

2 Thorsten Botz-Bornstein, Why Are There So Many Cute Cats on the Internet? The World is Driven by a Cute-Excellence Syndrome. LA Review of Books. 23 December 2017, <http://blog.lareviewofbooks.org/essays/many-cute-cats-internet-world-driven-cute-excellence-syndrome/> and Not-so-guilty pleasure: Viewing cat videos boosts energy and positive emotions, IU study finds. June 2015, <http://archive.news.indiana.edu/releases/iu/2015/06/internet-cat-video-research.shtml>, accessed 12 March 2025.

3 Sianne Ngai, *Our Aesthetic Categories*, Harvard University Press 2015.

4 Botz-Bornstein 2017.

Sianne Ngai offers three categories or keys to how we experience today's world as surfacing on social media: *zany blogs*, *cute tweets* and *interesting wikis* are categories creating attention.⁵ >The best explanation for why the zany, the interesting, and the cute are our most pervasive and significant categories is that they are about the increasingly intertwined ways in which late capitalist subjects labor, communicate and consume.⁶

They are the material through which we can have perceptions and share judgments that seem most closely related to what we do, say, and use in the 21st century. The *zany* is a performance style that's both anxious and over-the-top. It's energetic, sometimes even sweaty, and involves physical humor that can be suggestive. It blurs the lines between play and work, with elements of both being taken too seriously or not seriously enough. Think of Lucille Ball's physical comedy or Hugo Ball's Dada performances. It can be dangerous, like Charlie Chaplin getting caught in the machinery. The *zany* is similar to camp, which celebrates failed attempts at style. But unlike camp, the *zany* is more likely to turn success into failure, like the cartoon Coyote's constant struggles. It's a performance that's either too stiff or loose, creating tension between different roles or activities. It can be desperate or stressful but not wildly joyful or chaotic. It's like lousy pornography: trying too hard and missing the mark. Despite the effort, the *zany* can be attractive but never truly happy.

The *zany* concept comes from a stock character in an old theater, a peasant forced into service. Initially, these characters helped fix romantic problems, foreshadowing the idea of emotional labor. Over time, the *zany* became a comedic figure who exaggeratedly imitated others, a wild improviser. Today, we see the *zany* in characters like The Cable Guy, stuck between different types of work, or Kramer from Seinfeld, an exaggerated version of Jerry. These characters all represent the idea of *virtuoso labor* (Lazzarato's immaterial labor), where work becomes a kind of performance.

Cute comes from a sharper, more intense word, *acute*. Cute things are endearing and familiar, unlike the strange or wild (*zany*) that we keep at arm's length. We can control and interact with cute things, even though they need our care. The *zany* is about creation, while the *cute* is about enjoyment. It's like the difference between a worker and a finished product. We identify with cute things; they feel like *us*.

Cuteness is different from beauty. Beautiful things are rare, unique, and untouchable. Cute things are cuddly and approachable. They can be mass-produced and kitschy, appealing to our emotions in a simplified way. Cute objects often want our love and care, like a child asking, *Are you my mother?*

Cuteness can be a fixation, hiding the work that went into making it. But it can also be a hopeful dream, a world where things are valued for their usefulness, not just how much they cost. Cute objects want us to believe in the fantasy of a perfect thing.

5 McKenzie Wark. Our Aesthetics. Blog Post 27 June 2017. <https://www.versobooks.com/blogs/3291-our-aesthetics>, accessed 12 January 2025.

6 Ngai 2015.

They hint at a world where things are helpful and safe, untouched by the harsh realities of buying and selling. This powerlessness can be strangely attractive, even arousing—pure pleasure.

The ultimate test of something being cute might be if it looks good enough to eat. This sweetness can be unsettling. The transformation of real work into abstract value (like in factories) can be compared to turning meat into a pink, formless paste. Cute objects, with their friendly faces, might be a way to escape this feeling of being used up. Cuteness makes production seem like a comforting household activity, even though it can be violent and sexual.

The third aesthetic category by Ngai, *interesting*, is about information and how it circulates, not about performance or emotions. It's like a small surprise, a deviation from the norm. Science finds interesting things that connect many ideas and social aspects. Interesting things are a balance between understanding and surprise.

The *interesting* is linked to exploring and observing the world, like a flaneur in a city. Literature, especially modern novels, became *interesting* through a focus on diverse characters and situations. *Interesting* things are not universal or timeless; they focus on everyday details and change over time. *Interesting* things make you think and question, but the feeling is mild. It's just a starting point for further exploration.

Interesting things happen in a flow of time, unlike the shocking or beautiful. They reflect the current moment. Photography captures everything, making it inherently interesting. Conceptual art uses everyday elements and processes, creating an *information aesthetic*. *Interesting* things ask you to pay attention to details in a fast-paced world. This attention might lead to new knowledge and understanding. Critics can help us see the interesting aspects of things, influencing public opinion and creating communities with shared interests.

Diachronic and informational, forensic and dialogic: the aesthetic of the interesting can produce new knowledge. From Adorno on the products of the culture industry to Cavell on Hollywood screwball comedies [to Ngai on the interesting], all contemporary criticism is thus, in some sense, an implicit provision of evidence for why the object that the critic has chosen to talk about is interesting [...]⁷

The *zany* is a subject, the *interesting* an object, and the *cute* a hybrid, and all are in between play and labor, signaling an era in which work becomes play and play becomes work. The three emotional responses to aesthetics in our modern, service-oriented world aren't grand or dramatic. Cute things are small and vulnerable, while *zany* is a feeling of awkward helplessness. Interesting things are constantly changing based on what's expected and different. These might seem unimportant, but they differ significantly from the classical ideas of beauty (calm and distant) or the sublime (powerful and overwhelming).

7 Ngai 2015: 171.

Ngai argues that art has become independent and fully integrated into everyday life. This seemingly utopian outcome is different from what anyone expected. Art has adapted by becoming less severe and more like a friendly ghost haunting us. It's still around, but it's casual and doesn't demand respect or awe. The part of art that merges with daily life can even seem like mental health issues. Our interest can become obsessive boredom, cuteness can feel manipulative, and zaniness can be like a nervous breakdown. Everyday art is like watered-down versions of past artistic styles. Cute pictures are like calm landscapes in a digital format, zany jokes are like short online videos, and interesting things are like personality quizzes. This connection between art and information might explain the rise of these new emotional responses. Art is now tied to performance, products, and information. This reflects several trends, like the blurring of lines between art and commerce, the growth of a more personal public life and a commercialized private life, and the constant activity in both areas that can't be easily called work or play. While these emotions are less dramatic than the feeling of awe inspired by classical art, they still challenge traditional ideas of beauty. *Cute* things get too close, *zany* things aren't truly playful, and *interesting* things are observed coldly. The way we experience art just isn't what classical thinkers expected.

If, in response to the loss of the sacred under conditions of secular, industrial modernity, the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries plunged headlong into the resacralization of the aesthetic, the contemporary moment seems defined by a desacralization of the aesthetic turn, but a desacralization caused precisely by the aesthetic's hyperbolic expansion.⁸

Hiroki Azuma offered critical insight into the postmodern era by identifying a shift in Japan during the 1990s. This shift moved away from grand narratives and embraced a vast database of *cute elements* or *moe-points*.⁹

Ngai discusses aesthetics in a world dominated by capitalism and information technology. Her book analyzes aesthetics through the *interesting* lens, which acknowledges new trends within capitalism. Her concept of *zany* could have been an alternative way of looking—actively pushing against and exhausting existing constraints. A *zany aesthetic theory* could challenge the assumption that capitalism is permanent.

Ngai's work can be connected to a broader concept of *performative aesthetics*, celebrating the act of creation and embracing the possibility of failure, similar to *queer art*. The rise of information technology and control over data streams create a new *vectoralist class* with immense aesthetic power. Information is a commodity, changing how we perceive and interact with the world. Ngai's categories (*zany*, *cute*, *interesting*) help navigate this information-driven landscape. Still, they must be adapted to serve or survive in an AI-dominated future.

8 Ngai 2015: 242.

9 Hiroki Azuma, *Otaku, Japan's Database Animals*, University of Minnesota Press 2009.

Phantom Worlds

Mensch ist was er isst, says the German proverb: man is what he eats.

In his 1953 essay, *The Phantom World of TV*, the postwar German critic of mass culture Gunther Anders was among the first to relocate this proverb onto the terrain of cultural consumption. With the assertion, *it is through the consumption of mass commodities that mass men are produced*, Anders suggested that we are what we watch. He was already wary of the allegedly poor taste and potentially anti-social tendencies of *mass men*.¹⁰

'The world has now become an 'exposition'; and certainly an advertising exposition that is impossible not to visit, because we always already find ourselves in the middle of it.'¹¹

Television and modern technology are, for Anders, a new form of *Promethean shame*;: the shame of being confronted by the high quality of fabricated things compared to natural ones, a discomfort individuals might experience when faced with the power and influence over their lives, creating alienation, feelings of powerlessness, loss of control and disconnection from the world. Existence is technically mediated.¹²

Promethean shame is what we feel when we realize that the machines we have created are so powerful and perfect that we humans with our messy and mortal bodies cannot but feel very deficient in comparison. We recognize the superiority of the made over the born, and as a consequence wish to be made ourselves, which allows us more control over what we are, which is especially important when it comes to our sexual bodies.¹³

Key to Anders' notion of *Promethean shame* was his observation that we effectively adapt or suit ourselves to our technology, not the other way around. Provocatively, Anders argued that whereas the populace in the past (he was referring to Nazi Germany) required the techniques of mass psychology to manipulate and control, today we do this work on ourselves, in our own time, in our own space, using devices and subscriptions we pay for. As we *do this to ourselves*, we actively *program* ourselves in an ongoing digital practice, constantly and in real-time, providing the means for our own surveillance.¹⁴

10 Sure Wolton, *Marxism, Mysticism and Modern Theory*, Springer 2016. <https://link.springer.com/content/pdf/10.1007/978-1-349-24669-4.pdf>, accessed 12 March 2025.

11 Translation from German: Die Welt ist nun zur *Ausstellung* geworden, und zwar zu einer Werbeausstellung, die nicht zu besuchen unmöglich ist, weil wir uns immer schon ohnehin in ihr befinden (Anders 1980a, 161).

12 Oliver Marino, Günther Anders' Theory of Media and Communication: Developing a Conception of Technological Domination, Alienation and Ideology with Marx beyond Marx. A PhD thesis awarded by the University of Westminster, <https://westminsterresearch.westminster.ac.uk/download/3efa6c34f14faefd556f244c01f6c28b2efa3ddc0852eba61cb3955b6f259d72/3773962/E-ThesisSubmission.pdf>, accessed 12 March 2025.

13 M. Hauskeller, *Promethean Shame and the Engineering of Love*. In: *Sex and the Posthuman Condition*. Palgrave Pivot, London 2014. https://doi.org/10.1057/9781137393500_4.

14 Harvard Review of Philosophy Lecture: Babette Babich (Fordham University). Günther Anders'

We are entering into dependencies and addiction without awareness. We need to check our smart devices constantly. We fear obsolescence and being left behind. Skills like writing, communication, problem-solving, orientation, and spatial awareness are dangerously affected and reformatted. We are under pressure to perform and curate our lives, construct narratives, and showcase. The feeling of inadequacy leads to curating identities and idealized images.

Today, all media are social media.¹⁵ We use them to depict ourselves. Our bodies are now extensions of data networks, clicking, linking, and taking selfies. We render what we see and understand on screens that go everywhere with us. This understanding results from a mixture of seeing and learning not to see.

Anders argued that commercial broadcasting addresses the audience as consumers of commodities to increase sales. This dynamic is even more pronounced in today's targeted advertising on digital platforms, where user data is used to serve personalized ads.

Consuming commercial broadcasts is a form of *camouflaged labor* where the audience pays to sell themselves to advertisers. In the age of social media, users' content creation, data generation, and attention is a form of unpaid digital labor that generates profits for platforms. The monetization of user data on social media platforms is a form of commodity production. Boundaries between work and leisure are blurred. Streaming platforms curate and monetize user attention. The proliferation of fake news, filter bubbles, and echo chambers on social media platforms exacerbate this distortion of reality in contemporary media. Furthermore, the constant use of digital devices, immersion in virtual worlds, and social media platforms lead to feelings of estrangement from physical reality.

Technology platforms, the conventional wisdom now goes, are not neutral. Their design and structure encourage certain behaviors, and their algorithms control us even more. We may be paddling our boats, but the platform is the river, and the algorithms are the current.

Our situation is direr than in Anders' time, with centralized platforms making it nearly impossible to operate independently online. Geert Lovink argues the *platform has incorporated and then killed the network logic* and that talk of decentralized services is now a *farce*.¹⁶

§17 Anders

The person being informed is free because he has control over something absent; unfree because he only receives the predicate instead of the thing itself. So what is news? What does it do? It informs the person being informed about something absent in such a way that the person, the addressee, now knows about the absent indirectly, without his own experience,

'Promethean Shame': Technological Ressentiment and Surveillance. <https://philosophy.fas.harvard.edu/event/harvard-review-philosophy-annual-lecture-babette-babich-fordham-university>.

15 Nicholas Mirzoeff, *How to See the World*. Penguin UK, 4 Haz 2015: 13.

16 Geert Lovink, *Requiem for the Network*, <https://networkcultures.org/geert/2020/01/28/geert-lovink-requiem-for-the-network/>, accessed 12 March 2025.

based on vicarious *perception*. The appearance of the word *absent* confirms that we have not left our field of questions, including the ambiguity of presence and absence.

Social media, as we know it, is a celebration of absence. To speak means to speak of something absent: to present that which is not present to someone who is not.

Absence might be close to forgetting.

LOG:: 14 GENERATIVE TELEVISUALITY

The starting-point of any study of television must be with what is actually there on the screen. This is what content analysis is concerned to establish. It is based upon the non-selective monitoring, usually by a team of researchers, of the total television output for a specified period. It is not concerned with questions of quality, of response or of interpretation, but confines itself to the large scale, objective survey of manifest content. However, the reading of television must progress from the manifest content to the latent content, and very few analysts have begun to tread this path.¹

YouTube dominates watch time across platforms. YouTube is one of the biggest platforms in music. YouTube is rapidly eating podcasting, and is now a major cable competitor, and much more. *'If YouTube can make the big screen and the small screen feel like the same screen, it'll become even more unstoppable.'*²

A year-end update reveals that more people than ever are watching the video sharing platform on television—an inevitable switch in consumption habits.³ Traditional television is evolving into something much more dynamic and interactive. I like to call or define this transformation as *Generative Televisuality*.

The concept of *televisuality*, following John Caldwell, reflects on television as *a system of business conditions, styles, ideologies, cultural values, modes of production, programming and audience practices that make up television as a medium within a specific historical and geographical context*.⁴ Caldwell revolutionized television studies by emphasizing its visual nature and the economic value of program styles, highlighting the interconnectedness of aesthetics, economics, and technology in television.

Imagine watching a show that adapts its storyline based on your reactions, or content that's partially created by artificial intelligence responding to viewer preferences. This isn't science fiction; it's happening now. Television is no longer just a one-way broadcast; it's becoming a conversation between creators, algorithms, and audiences. That is said in a positive sense.

At the heart of this transformation is the merger of traditional television with digital technology. Algorithms analyze viewing patterns and help shape content, while interactive features allow viewers to influence what they watch in real-time.

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- 1 John Fiske and John Hartley, *Reading Television*, Routledge, London and New York 1988: 21.
 - 2 David Pierce. YouTube is a hit on TVs — and is starting to act like it. *The Verge*, <https://www.theverge.com/2024/12/11/24318434/youtube-living-room-tv-growth-2024>, 20 December 2024.
 - 3 Chris Stokel-Walker. YouTube is taking over TV, <https://www.fastcompany.com/91246335/youtube-is-taking-over-tv>, 20 December 2024.
 - 4 *Redefining Televisuality: Programmes, Practices, Methods*. International conference. ECREA Television Section Conference 2023. Filmuniversität Babelsberg Konrad Wolf, Potsdam, 25-27 October 2023, <https://www.consultacinema.org/2023/02/27/redefining-televisuality-programmes-practices-methods/>.

Social media integration means audiences can engage with content as it unfolds, creating a feedback loop that shapes future programming.

Netflix and Hulu analyze our viewing habits to suggest shows and movies we might enjoy. Viewers get control over what and when to watch, enabling binge viewing, marathon sessions of entire series. However, this freedom can lead to a paradox—the more you watch, the harder it becomes to find fresh content, and recommendations start to feel repetitive. Meanwhile, platforms like YouTube and Twitch add a social dimension that traditional television never had, with viewers able to chat with each other and interact during live streams.

The impact of generative televisuality extends beyond just how we watch TV. Production teams now use real-time rendering and virtual production techniques, while AI and machine learning help create and modify content. The line between producer and consumer is once again blurring, as viewers become active participants in the evolution of the content they consume. Viewers need to become creators.

This shift raises questions about the future of storytelling and narrative. Will our TV shows become completely personalized? How will AI influence creativity? What happens to shared cultural experiences when everyone's viewing journey is unique? As technology continues to advance, television is becoming less of a fixed medium and more of a dynamic, evolving form of expression that responds and adapts to its audience in real-time.

Generative AI plays a crucial role in reshaping content creation and audience engagement. While it offers significant opportunities for innovation and efficiency, it also presents not yet known challenges; in particular, authenticity and bias are already obvious. As these technologies continue to evolve, their impact on both the production processes and viewer experiences will deepen more.

From game design we have already learned that players easily can destroy the game experience. It is something naturally to test out the borders, and it is only consequently that any interactive experience has to be a controlled and invisible guided experience. You can do only what you are allowed to do, and you can only get what is in stock. But the stock can be rendered endlessly.

Together with Aras Özgün we wrote about how streaming platforms are reshaping not just what we watch, but how we experience entertainment itself.⁵ Streaming has ended the act of gathering around TV at a specific time, the common physical sharing of an experience with family or friends. *Microcasting* has let to a world where algorithms serve up personalized content just for you. While this customization might seem convenient, it comes with a trade-off:

5 Aras Özgün and Andreas Treske, On Streaming-Media Platforms, Their Audiences, and Public Life. *Rethinking Marxism*, 33(2), 2021: 304–323. <https://doi.org/10.1080/08935696.2021.1893090> and Aras Özgün ve Andreas Treske. “Süreğen Medya Platformları: İzleyici Etkinliğinin Dönüşümü Ve Toplumsal Etkileri”. *Ankara Üniversitesi İlef Dergisi*, c. 8, sy. 1, 2021, ss. 109-32, doi:10.24955/ilef.933277.

we're losing those shared cultural moments that traditional TV once provided. For the first moon landing, people gathered around television sets and lived every minute live with the transmission. Today, space travel is shared via social media, and millions of singled-out people are watching alone on a personal device. It's me with the device with the event.

The algorithms that power streaming platforms are like invisible curators, quietly shaping our viewing habits. They don't just suggest what to watch next; they're actively molding how we interact with the library content. It's a bit like having a very attentive but somewhat controlling friend who's always ready with recommendations, but might be limiting your exposure to new experiences. The awkward nerd from the video store took his revenge.

This shift toward personalized viewing has deeper implications for our society. When everyone is watching different content at different times, those conversations about last night's big show become increasingly rare. While we're gaining convenience and personalization, we might be losing something valuable: the collective experience of shared cultural moments. I still remember discussing every new episode of *Star Trek* seen on the weekend on a Monday morning with my friends while waiting for our school bus. Now, these discussions have shifted to notes and messages on WhatsApp, somewhere in the feed.

Yet streaming platforms aren't just passive content delivery systems. They're constantly evolving, experimenting with new ways to keep us engaged. As our viewing habits become increasingly personalized and algorithm-driven, how do we maintain the social connections and shared cultural experiences that traditionally brought us together through media?

Rather than praising technology unreservedly, paint doomsday scenarios, or get lost in economic analysis, we need to dig deeper. We have to acknowledge how technology is changing our world while maintaining a thoughtful critical perspective, to gain some distance. We have to stay away from a *technology is good* versus *technology is bad* debate. Instead, we need to continue to look at streaming platforms as complex systems that shape our culture in both visible and invisible ways. We need to understand how algorithms do more than just recommend content; they actually influence how we experience and make sense of media. For this we need to examine the whole system, and the infrastructure that keeps it running.

Streaming as media practice does not have to be as we now experience it in 2025. Alternative forms emphasizing participatory culture and collaboration in content creation and distribution could be facilitated. Algorithms could be used for fostering critical dialogues.

Creativity and *responsiveness* are the keys for community. Streaming platforms have the potential for cultural expression, particularly in times of crisis. They can generate reciprocal changes and therefore produce *real* interactivity.

We need to address interdisciplinary collaboration, economic sustainability, alternative revenues, social protocols, digital platforms, and support innovative formats for artistic expression and social commentary to challenge traditional and new technological boundaries.

The Force Again

Yes, we have understood that television shapes our world. TV is more than just a box that delivers entertainment. It is a powerful force that actively shapes how we understand reality and experience the world around us.

I like to recall Paolo Carpiagnano, who pointed out that television has the unique ability to create what he calls *present-ness*.⁶ Think about how TV can make millions of people feel like they're experiencing the same moment together, whether it's a historic event, a sports match, or a season finale, or the moon landing mentioned earlier. A Taylor Swift concert live? Carpiagnano argued that this shared experience is something special to television, creating a unique kind of intimacy that bridges the gap between our private lives and the public world.

Something quite profound about television's influence is not just about what we watch, but how we watch it. The way television presents information—its visual language, its rhythms, its way of telling stories—has fundamentally changed how we perceive and remember events. It's almost as if television has created its own language of experience that we've all learned to speak. An event did not exist if it was not or is not broadcasted.

Carpignano's framework of thinking about televisuality proves remarkably useful in analyzing how streaming services and digital platforms are transforming our viewing experiences. Even as we have moved away from traditional TV, many of the conventions and patterns he identified continue to influence how digital content is created and consumed. It is as if television's DNA has been passed down to these new forms of media, shaping how we expect to experience content in the digital age.

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The Cybernetic Desert - Intermission by Aras Ozgun⁷

Streaming media technologies transfigured *publics*, founded by print and broadcast media in modern times. In its new form, the 'audience' became an amalgamation of individuals, whose aesthetic and ideological preferences, along with their everyday routines and viewing habits, could now be quantified and assessed by the platforms, which gradually gained control over the production of the content as well as its streaming delivery. The incorporation of generative AI technologies into contemporary media culture takes place on this ground.

We often hear the complaints (not 'analyses' but indeed complaints) these days that generative AI technologies will strip humanity of its creative/intellectual essence.

6 Paolo Carpiagnano, Televisuality, 31 July 1997. Via Wayback Machine, <https://web.archive.org/web/19970731123140/http://www.newschool.edu/mediastudies/tv/televisuality.html>.

7 Aras Ozgun and I worked for some time on streaming media and their audiences, which resulted in several published articles. When writing, I thought it was needed to ask him to connect these notes to our discussion.

Well, stripping humanity of its creative/intellectual capacities began when Thomas Edison set up the Black Maria studio and consequently founded the Motion Picture Patents Company. Adorno and Horkheimer have already shown that mitigating critical reason is the operational logic of modern culture industries. What generative AI technologies actually do today is to remove media professionals from their 'middleman' position in this process. Algorithms, instead of producers, determine what people (not a general audience, but sums of individuals) precisely want, and generative AI produces that content from script to screen, instead of production crews.

It is quite interesting that despite the fact that the 'hyper-realism' of generative AI and Large Language Models (LLM) already provides us with perfect simulations, we seem to have forgotten Jean Baudrillard and his criticism organized around the notions of 'hyper-reality' and 'simulacrum'⁸. Baudrillard's criticism was directed towards a highly saturated, increasingly visual media environment, in which representations had started to substitute for the 'real', and without any reference to real. The problem, according to Baudrillard, was the loss of touch with reality at a collective level—the subsumption of the world outside by televisuality, so to speak. Today's social media platforms already become phatic communication domains that channel massive misinformation flows⁹. Streaming media platforms too, mainly serve a phatic function by accompanying molar audiences everywhere at all times on their mobile devices, feeding them nothing but what they feel they like. At this technological junction, the main promise of generative AI under platform capitalism is a cybernetic desert, a media environment devoid of information that representations of secondary order perpetually reproduce. Information, for Bateson, was a difference that makes a difference¹⁰. Whereas what generative AI produces is a simulation that resembles the same just enough to be able to substitute it, or reconfigure the parts of the same just enough to create an illusion of the new.

8 J. Baudrillard, *Simulacra and Simulation* (S. Glaser, Trans.), University of Michigan Press 1994.

9 Nikhilesh Dholakia, Aras Ozgun & Deniz Atik (2023): The miasma of misinformation: a social analysis of media, markets, and manipulation, *Consumption Markets & Culture*, DOI: 10.1080/10253866.2022.2149508.

10 Gregory Bateson, *Steps to an Ecology of Mind; Collected Essays in Anthropology, Psychiatry, Evolution, and Epistemology*, San Francisco, CA: Chandler 1972.



Fig. 14. UNKNOWN

LOG:: 15 SPEAK, THE SPEECH!

It is as if one saw a screen with scattered colour-patches, and said: the way they are here, they are unintelligible; they only make sense when one completes them into a shape.—Whereas I want to say: Here is the whole. (If you complete it, you falsify it.)

—Ludwig Wittgenstein¹

Speak the speech

I was told to 'speak the speech.'

So...I am speaking. And in doing so it is a speech.

Therefore I am speaking the speech. The speech about speaking the speech.

To speak about speaking, About speeches, About speaking speeches...one could end up preaching to

peaches how to preach to a spoken peach. Yes! Preaching.

...

Yet here I AM.

Speaking The Speech.

And now you know, now you know that you, you, you, are you, And I, I, I am I. And now you know

how to speak the speech.

How do you speak the speech? You speak! You speak The Speech

—I am the Angora Rabbit and I approve this message-²

¹ Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Remarks on the Philosophy of Psychology*, Oxford, 1980, vol. i, Remark 257.

² Daniel Irizarry, *Mouthgasm*, Angora Rabbit. Bilkent 2016.

Video is a Cybernetic Medium

Tom Sherman writes on Facebook in September 2015:

Video is a cybernetic medium based in feedback and control born in the latter half of the 20th century--film had emerged much earlier, at the end of the 19th century. There are different and better ways to use video than to continue translating live drama and literature into the screenplay. Video art was born largely in the context of the visual arts in the 1960s and 70s. Video was an expansion of sculpture under the influence of CCTV, closed-circuit television. Video expanded the spatial, sculptural domain as a superb surveillance technology. And video extended performance art through its documentation and expansion of performance in media. Video was employed in an evidential role, as an audio/visual form of documentation. Documentary and document are two different things, documentary being more akin to propaganda, the declarative insistence of what the evidence means. (Experimental film, the last great celebration of celluloid, was an extension of abstract painting.)³

Early video art challenged the dominance of television, the king of centralized media, by dissecting and critiquing it. Unlike traditional cinema's focus on narrative storytelling, video emerged as a decentralized tool for anyone to create, offering the potential for anyone to be an author. These early video artists weren't interested in simply carrying on the storytelling tradition of cinema. Their focus was on using video as an electronic tool to understand the here and now, the immediate events unfolding around them. They explored how this electronic intervention impacted the world and its effects on society, politics, economics, and even aesthetics. In simpler terms, video, with its ability to document, receive feedback, and continuously adapt representation, became a powerful tool for social change, pushing boundaries in all these areas.

In his seminars on video at Middle East Technical University in the mid-90s, the Turkish sociologist and media philosopher Ulus Baker emphasized that video differs from cinema. It's not just about technology. We appreciate cinema, but video offers new possibilities, he underlined. We can create an archive of open-ended works with video works, like unfinished music, that can connect to other videos. We don't need a rigid structure to create an ending, as in a film, and the challenge, says Baker, is how to achieve this. Our explanations and conclusions might be lacking, but that's part of the exploration. Godard, for instance, aimed for a *new image type*, a combination of all visual elements. This *I see* approach in video goes beyond cinema. In Godard's work, cinema is re-evaluated within a new visual style. He appreciates cinema but also seeks to expand it. Baker connects to Tarde's philosophy: new things come from encounters. The theater has grappled with similar issues. Grotowski's *poor theater* stripped away everything but the actor's body, in reaction to cinema's spectacle. In theater, you're not a passive observer but part of the experience. Cinema, however, presents a pre-existing world. The *I see* in cinema puts interpretation in the viewer's hands.

3 Note copied from Facebook by the author in September 2015.

As a pure *I see*, video offers the potential to explore these possibilities more freely. Ultimately, we must invent new ways of *seeing* with video. Video for Baker brings thinking back to the act of speech rather than writing.

We are citing ready items of thoughts through the replay of video and sharing. But isn't it like any experience, in that it has been there, and any thought has been formed, *deja vu*? The technique of instant replay added to our human abilities. The storage of audiovisual sense or sensation equal experience aims to hold the moment in flow and stop forgetting instant access.

Endless resolution and endless looks, views, memory machine, assisting brain or in creating intelligence through the ability of memory device.

Baker builds his ideas partially on the philosophy of Kant, bringing back questioning the focus on simple observation (*I see*). This reevaluation challenged the way artists viewed the world. Imagine a path, says Baker, starting with Descartes (known for *I think. Therefore I am*) and leading to modern philosophers like Blanchot and Foucault. Descartes's statement marked the beginning of contemporary philosophy, emphasizing the importance of reason and thought over mere perception. However, Kant argued that thought isn't just abstract concepts. It's about applying ideas within a specific time and space. He uses the French Revolution as an example: its ideals would only have mattered with the legal framework established afterward. Following Kant, modern thought emphasizes the practical application of ideas. Today, any idea or concept needs a real-world context to be considered valuable. Simply having an idea without a way to put it into practice holds little weight.

Images are seen as records of things within time and space, following Kant's ideas. Baker argues that if our existence is proven by action (*I walk, therefore I exist*), can the same be said for seeing? (*I see, therefore I think*). Video as a medium can prove thought because it's always trapped within the limitations of time and space.

Before Kant, we assumed thinking perfectly mirrored reality. We believed ideas were pre-existing things we had to remember or invent. Kant changed this. He argued there's a difference between the world itself (the *thing in itself*) and how we experience it (the *appearance*). Our minds actively shape our experience through concepts like space and time. So, when we say *I see* or *I think*, it's not a guarantee we're directly grasping the thing itself. We can only ever experience it through the lens of our minds. This shift from passive reflection to active construction became a key idea in modern philosophy. Just as an image in a movie can spark an idea, our experiences can trigger thoughts. This is similar to how editing techniques in film (like those used by Eisenstein) can guide the viewer's experience. Baker suggests that video art should indirectly imitate this process to create a *thinking instrument* for viewers, avoiding the manipulative techniques of modern advertising.

What are the conditions of being determined?

I can guess that: 'her yiğidin bir yoğurt yeyişi vardır deriz de her yoğurdun bir yiğide farklı bir yeniş biçimi vardır demeyiz...'⁴

Suppose we see cinema and video always as an activity of reactions. While cinema often focuses on responses, Baker proposes two essential purposes for cinema: depicting daily life and creating fantastical worlds. The second has become more popular, but the first offers a more critical perspective for him. Subjectivity is not simply a given. Subjectivity requires actively constructing viewpoints and attitudes, which can be challenging and constantly in flux. Authentic subjectivity isn't fixed or inherited but a continuous process of creation and potential failure.

In his attempt to understand video, Baker draws on Kant's schemas, which aren't pictures but rather the underlying rules that govern how something is perceived. A schema is a concept that bridges the gap between our abstract ideas and the world we perceive through our senses. Kant believed we have pure concepts, like causality or substance, that aren't learned from experience. Schemata are not mental images. They are more like processes or guidelines for making sense of our sensations according to our concepts.

The focus on *seeing* in video creates a unique space for thinking linked to the act of observation. Baker is questioning why video, with its focus on the act of seeing, isn't considered a more valuable tool for creative expression in a society dominated by spectacle (like dream cinema) and low-quality television (*poor TV*).

In a break from traditional filmmaking, Godard embraced revolution and documentary styles (*Cinéma-Vérité*). He used video to create films, but in a way that defied expectations. Unlike classic cinema's *I show you* approach, Godard's films embodied an *I see* perspective. Cinematic conventions do not limit this new way of seeing the world. Evaluating everything through traditional cinema doesn't work with video. While initially seen as avant-garde, video presents new challenges: its place as a mass medium and its artistic potential.

Cinema has yet to achieve its full potential. Deleuze and Godard believed films could make audiences think critically, but cinema is still mostly seen as entertainment. He emphasizes the importance of truly *seeing* a movie, not just watching it passively. Great directors have shown a *high-seeing* ability beyond what can be described. This contrasts with *low talking*, everyday speech that just relays what can be seen. True art uses language (*high talking*) to express things that can't be seen. Blanchot, unlike others, believed in the possibility of *high seeing* in film. Watching a movie isn't enough; you must grasp its deeper meaning. A film becomes truly powerful when it transcends language and can't be fully explained with words.

4 Google Translate: *We say that every brave man has his own way of eating yoghurt, but we do not say that every yoghurt has a different way of being eaten by a brave man...;-).*

The Gap

In his doctoral thesis, Ulus Baker explored a gap in social science:

For seven years, I wrestled with how to integrate film analysis into the study of social issues. While documentaries are often viewed as mere illustration, I believe they offer a powerful way to capture the essence of human experience. I see myself as a social scientist who utilizes film, not as a documentarian or video artist. Unlike traditional researchers, I believe video archives can be more than just data. A camera's perspective can reveal hidden aspects of a situation, like poverty, in a way text cannot. Documentary filmmakers have a unique ethical responsibility. They understand the impact of their choices, unlike many social scientists who rely solely on surveys. Our research often lacks a deep understanding of the lived experience. We can analyze, discuss, and propose solutions, but we may never truly see the issue. My inspiration came from studying still lifes (Naturmorts). Initially, these paintings depicted wealthy households. Poverty was only hinted at through symbols of death and decay. However, by the 19th century, artists like Cezanne used still lifes to portray the destruction of working-class communities.

I believe poverty can be portrayed in positive ways, not just through symbols of lack. A crack in a wall, a pregnant woman, a hand churning butter—all these elements can tell a story. My thesis argued that film has the potential to create a powerful archive of poverty unlike traditional social science methods. This archive wouldn't rely on pre-existing footage. I wouldn't just record poverty or sift through existing visuals. Instead, I would explore the full spectrum of possibilities for representing poverty on film. Ultimately, I reject the rigid separation of art and science. Every artwork embodies thought and reflection. Likewise, research without emotional connection seems pointless to me.⁵

Ulus Baker's main interest was a call to a politics of affect, to inspire people and challenge dominant power structures and ideologies. He draws on Spinoza's notion of *affections* to understand social life: a dynamic, non-linguistic form of a relation between entities with the definition of images as *affective thought processes*. Sociology is too focused on summarizing opinions, which are unreliable and better suited for journalism or traditional archives. He proposes a *sociology of affects* that studies emotions and experiences. He believes film and video are powerful tools for analyzing society, capturing the *invisible* aspects that text-based approaches miss. He sees traditional methods in sociology, which rely on analyzing written works, as limited and prone to bias. Baker suggests a new approach that incorporates visual and audio elements alongside text, inspired by the montage technique of filmmaking. This could revolutionize how sociology is taught and practiced. He highlights the rise of the *image age* with the growth of video and electronic media.

⁵ Baker on video. Original Turkish. körotonomedy. Without year, <https://www.korotonomedy.net/kor/index.php?id=21,147,0,0,1,0.html>.

These *thought-images* he sees as a new way of conveying knowledge and understanding, potentially replacing traditional text-based information. In simpler terms, Baker argues that sociology should move beyond just studying opinions and focus on emotions and experiences.

Images hold a hidden power. Godard notes that it is not possible to see *the same smile in the faces of Soviet worker girls and the German youth* (Nazi propaganda). This *power of the image* could be used to explore emotions and social connections through documentaries. The challenge is in combining documentary filmmaking with social science. Social science offers theories and methods, while documentaries have powerful images but lack a solid theoretical framework. The goal is to create a *sociology of affects* that uses documentary images to explore societal emotions. Film, from its beginnings, has analyzed social realities. Baker argues that cinema isn't just for analysis by other disciplines; it can analyze things itself.

The danger isn't the power of images but their misuse. Television, for example, turns images into repetitive clichés. The key is to liberate images from becoming mere TV clichés.

Our archive is multimedia, going beyond mere opinions. It captures sights, sounds, and emotions. Similar to Michel Foucault's *énoncé* (statements), these elements are uncommon, and their scarcity defines their existence. Clichés and opinions are ubiquitous, forming a constant background noise. But as Castoriadis observed, people often dismiss them as meaningless or tune them out—a phenomenon he called the *rise of non-importance*. Only by critically analyzing television and even using its methods can we cultivate a *neo-Vertovian* sensibility. Images can be creative forces that produce new ways of seeing the world.

Emotions like desire, joy, and sadness are linked to our will to exist.⁶ They show how strong we are in this pursuit. Negri builds on this, saying emotions are a force for personal and collective action. They're personal. They connect us to the unmeasurable aspects of life and the collective because they connect us to each other.

We're all connected (as minds, bodies, and feeling beings) and actively shape the world around us, a world of struggle, power, and desire. Just by having desires, we're part of this world-building process.

Affects are emotions and feelings, but not simply reactions to events. They are seen as forces that can shape our understanding of the world. Baker's *sociology of affects* focuses on these forces rather than on fixed opinions. This focus on affects has several implications for political thought. First, it expands the range of actors and forms of resistance. People don't need fully formed opinions to challenge the status quo. Second, it emphasizes the role of the body and emotions in political life. Thinking isn't a purely rational process but is shaped by our feelings.

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6 Spinoza. Ethics, Book III, Proposition 57.

Tom Sherman - September 4, 2015 • Facebook

All this is not to deride cinema and those who love film. It is simply to say that video art is not a historical footnote to film, and it is certainly not merely an anomalous component of cinema, that historical reenactment and recycled history of theatre in motion pictures. Nor is video art's role to revitalize or enrich cinema, which has become a bit of a black hole as it has aged and now functions as an anachronistic monolith in homage to the power of literature. Video art has a whole other universe to connect with as digital moving images and sounds swirl and tunnel through myriad networks as surveillance data and music and fashion and personal message streams are coursing through phones and tablets and lighting up an image exchange via screens and goggles and projections on the walls and halls and canyons of the complex global architecture of our electronic message culture at large. . . . Vertov did put up one hell of a fight. He recognized the qualities and potential of celluloid and he executed a new cinema. I must emphasize that Vertov made the break, a radical strain of celluloid didn't make it for him. (Video doesn't have a will.) Individuals will find ways of using digital highly network-compatible video that will differ from those choosing to replicate the appearance and mundane functionality of celluloid embodied narratives, the dominant narratives of the 20th century.⁷



Fig. 15. UNKNOWN CLOSER

7 Facebook note.

LOG:: 16 INTERMISSION - PAUSE

A break? Intermission? Here is a simple etude or basic audiovisual workout:

one minute of life

Instruction: **Record** on any device one continuous minute of your life as video!

The moment of recording has to be random. Follow an impulse to grab your device and press record. Don't think about it. Don't frame. Don't ask. Just be with the instant feeling, be with the wish to record. And then wait. Wait one minute. Let the timecode run. **One Minute.** Feel the duration, the process of time, extending what was an instant urge, but now is a duty to follow. After one minute you can press stop.

Don't watch the recording immediately. Let time pass, maybe days, before you watch it. Have a big screen to view your recording. Press start and watch it till it stops.

Play it again. And maybe again.

What has happened in this one minute of life recorded? What do you see?

If you wish you can gift this one minute to someone.

Repeat this etude frequently!

Enjoy!

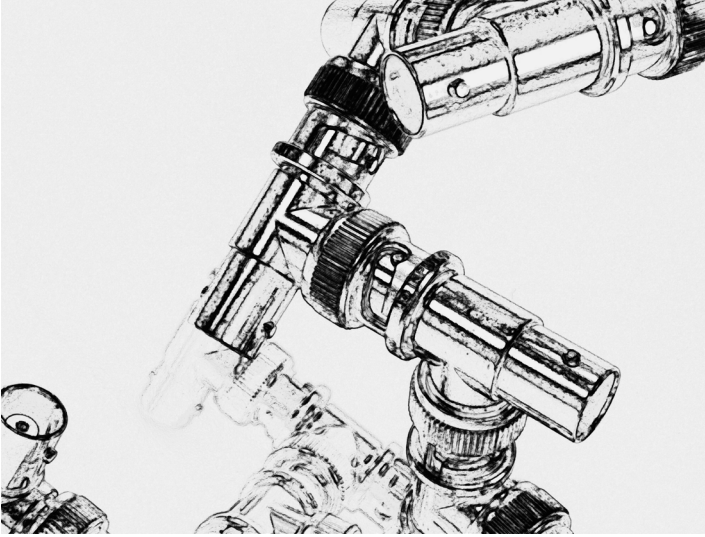


Fig. 16. BARBARIAN NON-CINEMATIC MEDIA THEORY

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LOG:: 17 BNC-MT

The black hit of space ...

—The Human League (1980)

BNC-MT is short for **BARBARIAN NON-CINEMATIC MEDIA THEORY**.

Video Theory Reboot. It is time for a call to action. We need to think critically about the impact of technology on our lives and develop new ways of understanding the world around us and new methods for understanding this new culture. We need to find ways to make sense of the vast amount of information available to us and their infrastructures, and we need to find ways to connect with each other meaningfully through alternative structures and spheres. We need new practices and aesthetics.

This call is nothing new. Audiovisual, technological culture is constantly changing. In 2015, in his book *Elegy for Theory* D.N. Roderick stated:

A new audiovisual culture, whose broad and indiscernible outlines we are only just beginning to distinguish, calls us to new modes of existence and forms of experience. Like any soul derailed by the vertiginous shock of modernity, we seek a conceptual compass to guide us home. One name for this navigational instrument is theory; another may be philosophy.¹

There still needs to be a theory. Many theories are embedded in various studies, grounded on objects, patterns, similarities, phenomena, fields, themes, and genres, scientific communities with specific dialects, algorithmic beliefs, disciplines like languages of different nations, governing systems of knowledge and knowledge distribution. It appears that *surgeons, generals, mothers, writers, chefs, archaeologists, biologists, engineers, and seducers* have a preferred domain of objects, and all constantly argue with one another about the relative importance of these materials, but *we forget that they are the same size and that nothing is more complex, multiple, real, palpable, or interesting than anything else*.²

Dispositiv Media Theory

During the opening of the Media Archaeology Lab at Bilkent University in Ankara in 2017, Wolfgang Ernst reminded me that we need to be precise, accurate, which I interpret to mean focused on the target.

Ernst himself formulates a dispositive media theory, reminding us that media are not neutral but rather *dispositifs* that shape how we perceive and understand the world.

1 D. N. Rodowick, *Elegy for Theory*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2014.

2 Harman 2014.

Media can be used to both empower and control people. Media theory can only be done with a deep understanding of the technologies that produce and circulate media. Such a theory must bridge the gap between the humanities and the sciences. Technical knowledge is essential for understanding materiality and impact.

Media theory needs a clear and precise definition of the media concept to carry out its work effectively. This definition should be broad enough to encompass all types of media. Yet it should also be specific enough to be useful for analysis. A well-defined media concept is essential for distinguishing between media and non-media and understanding media's unique properties. Media theory must be open to new approaches and perspectives and be willing to engage with other disciplines to produce a comprehensive understanding of media and audiovisual culture in the 21st century.

Any new theory needs to be a theory of liveness. Liveness is the possibility of the emergence of new forms and the potential to generate unprecedented connections and unexpected events.³

Doing Things

We need a new strategy of *doing things with words* and *doing things with things* or *doing things with visuals*. We need to stage interventions across conventional boundaries. The new aesthetics needs to operate simultaneously as a theory of production and reception. On the production side, it needs to provide a framework for understanding aesthetic work as the deliberate creation of relational atmospheres, rather than isolated objects. On the reception side, it needs to reframe our understanding of perception as a comprehensive experience of presence—specifically, how we encounter and sense the immediate reality of people, objects, and environments in their full dimensionality.

In the twenty-first century, we've moved in a more challenging environment than that of the time when bodily perception was seen as extended by technological prosthesis, as Marshall McLuhan famously argued. Our post-pandemic sensory world is deeply pharmacological: toxic and curative, exciting and dangerous, a place where endless media saturation forces us to revisit ideas of life itself.⁴

We need to crash the party. We need to have fun. And we need to start to tell different stories. Dance all night long.

3 Sarah Kember and Joanna Zylinska. *Life after New Media: Mediation as a Vital Process*. The MIT Press 2014.

4 Ravi Sundaram, In: *Signals. How Video Transformed the World*. MoMA, New York 2023: 116.

Schlage die Trommel und fürchte dich nicht,

und küsse die Marketenderin!

Das ist die ganze Wissenschaft,

das ist der Bücher tiefster Sinn.⁵

It really doesn't matter if we will tell this story over and over again, as long as we run against the capital's walls. This is needed to survive. Remember Scheherazade.

And the same significance can be seen in the reverse operation, in the expanding of time by the internal proliferations from one story to another, which is a feature of the oriental storytelling. Scheherazade tells a story in which someone tells a story in which someone tells a story, and so forth. The art that enables Scheherazade to save her life every night consists of knowing how to join one story to another, breaking off at just the right moment – two ways of manipulating the continuity and discontinuity of time. It is a secret of rhythm, a way of capturing time.⁶

It is also a way of understanding. Without understanding, we will struggle to formulate any theory. But, we might not understand *it* at all now. The Trojan horse is in place, if we only accept that we are inside and not surrounded but a part of *it*. Understanding is interconnected with practice. It will be the practice of the Barbarian, the simple ignorance.

Positive Barbarism

Walter Benjamin's concept of *positive barbarism* is one of his most provocative and generative ideas for me, emerging from his observations of cultural exhaustion and the possibilities for renewal in modernity. The concept appears in his 1933 essay *Experience and Poverty*, where he develops it as a response to what he saw as the crisis of tradition and experience in modern life.

World War I in Europe had interrupted severely traditional forms of experience and cultural transmission. The traumatic impact of industrialized warfare, combined with rapid technological change, had rendered many traditional forms of wisdom and experience seemingly irrelevant or impossible to communicate. Positive barbarism, for Benjamin, represents a radical strategic response to cultural over-saturation. It involves embracing a kind of cultural poverty—not out of necessity, but as a deliberate choice. This *barbarism* is *positive* because it clears the ground for new forms of experience and expression, unencumbered by the weight of tradition.

5 Heinrich Heine. Doktrin. Deutschland ein Wintermärchen. Heine, H., Gedichte. Aus: Zeitgedichte. 1. Doktrin. And: <https://www.zgedichte.de/gedichte/heinrich-heine/doktrin.html>.

6 Italo Calvino, *Six memos for the next millennium*. New York: Vintage Books, 1993.

The positive barbarian is one who starts from scratch, makes do with little, builds with limited means, values directness over complexity, and embraces new technological possibilities. For Benjamin, positive barbarism carries revolutionary potential. By clearing away the detritus of traditional culture, it creates space for new forms of collective experience, different modes of perception, novel social relations, and alternative political possibilities

This *starting from zero* approach isn't about destroying culture per se, but about creating conditions for genuine cultural renewal. The positive barbarian, in Benjamin's vision, is not someone who destroys culture out of ignorance or hatred, but someone who strategically reduces cultural baggage to create space for new forms of experience and expression. This figure remains provocative and potentially instructive for contemporary attempts to imagine and create alternative futures.

Today, when we face multiple crises and when the weight of accumulated cultural detritus often seems overwhelming, Benjamin's concept of positive barbarism suggests that starting from less might allow us to build something more sustainable, authentic, and collectively meaningful.

Practice, Practice

Human beings are fundamentally practicing creatures. Practice transcends mere repetition or learning; it represents the essential mechanism through which humans transform themselves. This concept forms the cornerstone of what Peter Sloterdijk terms *anthropotechnics*,⁷ the various technologies humans employ to shape, cultivate, and ultimately reinvent themselves.

Practice, as Sloterdijk defines it, is any operation that enhances the practitioner's ability to perform that same operation again. This seemingly simple definition carries deep implications for understanding human nature and development. Whether in the realm of physical fitness, spiritual devotion, or intellectual pursuit, practice serves as the bridge between what we are and what we might become.

The scope of practice in Sloterdijk's framework is remarkably comprehensive. It encompasses everything from the most concrete physical exercises to the most ethereal spiritual disciplines. Modern gym culture, with its regulated routines and measured progressions, stands alongside ancient ascetic traditions. Professional training programs share conceptual space with meditation practices. What unites these diverse activities is their transformative intent: their aim to overcome perceived human limitations and reach toward something higher.

This vertical tension—the constant striving upward—characterizes all meaningful practice. When religious frameworks provided clear paths to transcendence, this manifested as spiritual exercise. In our secular age, it emerges in different forms: the athlete pushing toward peak performance, the entrepreneur pursuing excellence, or the artist refining their craft. Yet the essential pattern remains: deliberate, self-directed effort aimed at transformation.

7 Peter Sloterdijk, *You must change your life; on anthropotechnics*, Wiley, 2013.

Crucially, Sloterdijk distinguishes between two forms of repetition in human life. The first is the mindless repetition of daily routine—the mechanical cycling of habits without purpose or progress. The second is deliberate practice—conscious, focused repetition aimed at growth and transformation. This distinction helps us understand why some repetitive activities lead to profound change while others merely maintain the status quo.

Perhaps most provocatively, Sloterdijk argues that what remains vital in religion today is not its belief systems but its practices—the technologies it developed for reshaping human thought and feeling. Modern society, rather than being post-religious, might better be understood as having inherited and secularized these ancient practices of self-transformation. Today's proliferation of training regimens, both physical and metaphysical, suggests that the human need for transformative practice persists, even as its expressions evolve.

The fundamental message is clear: humans are beings who must actively work on themselves through practice to achieve their potential. This work isn't optional or superficial—it's the very essence of human development. Whether through physical discipline, mental training, or spiritual exercise, practice remains the primary tool through which humans shape themselves and, by extension, their world.

This understanding of practice does not see humans as fixed entities. It rather presents us humans as works in progress, constantly engaged in the project of self-transformation through deliberate practice.

Things Strange

We have learned about networks, social connectivity, people and relationships, communication processes, mobility, information and capital flows, and network societies as the dominant social organizational structure in the age of globalization. People and objects are equal. Objects can determine reactions and act like people. Moments of actions. The short life and constantly newborn relations in repetition building.

The situation resembles an ecological system, an environment with climatic conditions. The social is the result of a technological formation. Modern technical media create an environment where data flows like living organisms, governed by digital rules - codes, protocols, and formats - that shape how information interfaces with human users. This digital ecosystem doesn't exist in isolation from society; rather, social interactions are transformed into inputs and outputs within these information flows.

Both human activity and data exchanges exist within a framework defined by technological capabilities, economic forces, and political structures. These systemic constraints shape our communication ecology much as climate shapes natural environments. However, this analogy has its limits. While natural ecosystems can occasionally influence their climate, the relationship between technical systems and their constraining conditions tends to be more one-directional.

To understand modern communication, we must examine both the technical infrastructure that enables data flow and the broader conditions that shape how we use these systems. It is a complex interplay between human society, digital information, and the structures that govern their interaction.

And so ...

What makes it worth talking about video, online video or the *Visual*? Its primary origin is a signal from a point of light moving, a dot creating a line, and then building a shape in time and repeating. The signal creates an environment spread in time and flow, and builds information through information of a location, a point, a plane, a status in time, bright or loud, a point somewhere and its data, a scan, a mode, or something.

In Nam June Paik's view, the camera is just a tool for processing information flows. It captures something (input) and sends it out (output) in real-time. What makes video unique is this constant exchange. We take a flow, manipulate it, and release it into the stream for further transformation.

Paik argues that video is more about interaction than observation. It's like being a sculptor or painter, working directly with the image rather than passively watching it. Unlike film, which emphasizes storytelling, or television, which focuses on consumption, video invites participation. Video even foreshadows the rise of virtual images. We criticize television's impact, but video offers something distinct: liveness. This *real-time* quality gives video a unique ontological presence, a way of being that sets it apart from other media.

Live TV is like life, you never manage to get everything done, there are always a few bittersweet regrets. . . . But what is the interest in being live? Interactive events must happen live. We'd like to use interactive TV because the best use you can get from a TV is to answer it like a telephone.⁸

Video goes beyond simply communicating messages and fostering social connections. It creates a new way of experiencing time. Unlike traditional media that capture a moment in time, video puts us right in the middle of the action. With video, we don't just witness an event, we participate in its construction. This happens through a collective process, where different elements (like technology and people) come together to create a flow of experience. Live video technology even changes how we think about ourselves as viewers. Joseph Beuys captured this well when he said, *I am a transmitter and I radiate*. He wasn't just saying he's involved; he meant he becomes part of the ongoing flow himself, connected to countless others. This opens up entirely new social and artistic possibilities, all centered around this idea of continuous, ever-changing experience.

Forget fixed images and pre-defined moments. Video lets us build time together as a collective flow.

8 Lazzarato 2019.

Perhaps it is in this sense that we should interpret another statement from Paik: 'The ultimate goal of the video revolution is the establishment of space-to-space communication, from situation to situation and not from subject to subject . . . we no longer work on an object, but a situation.'⁹

Video technology, with its ability to handle any situation, allows the world to truly become a realm of moving images, of *Visuals*, as envisioned by Bergson.¹⁰

Let's make things strange again. Ostranenie. Videoness!

BNC-MT shall be a theory of environments, of habitats where signals flow and social practices take place. Media is faces and places, or figures and spaces. Media theory is about environments and infrastructures as much as about messages and content. We need to think of media as environmental, as part of the habitat.

Nothing is pure, but everything is new.

Sight Seeing / Moving

Travel isn't just about going somewhere; it requires intention. We move for a reason: work, necessity, or personal growth. Our journeys are guided, following established routes or plans. Any non-work travel that follows a defined path can be considered tourism.

Unlike consuming media, tourism is a physical experience. Tourists are constantly on the move, physically traveling along routes, visiting designated landmarks, and following pre-determined schedules. This creates a routine. Deviations from these defined paths might be random exploration (sightseeing) or something more unsettling: terrorism.

Tourists and terrorists both reach destinations different from their starting points, but their motivations differ significantly.

Sightseeing expands the visitor's environment, allowing them to explore a temporary location and its surroundings. Hiroki Azuma argues that tourism shares similarities with a creative practice called *secondary derivation*. In this process, fans (often *otaku*) take original works and create new ones based on them. Similarly, tourists interact with existing realities (destinations) and create their own experiences, effectively making *secondary derivative works* out of reality.

There's a distinction between physical movement (like walking) and the rapid exchange of information, which is another kind of movement.

In Peter Weibel's work, movement encompasses both. It includes the physical movement of objects and bodies, the movement of thought, and the constant flow of information.

9 Nam June Paik, Binghamton Letter, 8 January 1972.

10 Lazzarato, 2019: 100.

Weibel's perspective suggests there's no such thing as something genuinely static. Everything is in a state of flux, even our thinking.

'There is nothing dead.'¹¹

At the turn of the 20th century, travel was primarily a function of power. Armies and resources moved in service of war and military exercises. Ordinary travel remained a luxury for the privileged few. The concept of the tourist emerged as a transformation of the industrial worker. Increased leisure time, a byproduct of this era, became a consolation prize for an otherwise grueling existence. The Nazi slogan *Kraft durch Freude* exemplifies this idea. In a society like the one depicted in Fritz Lang's *Metropolis*, factory workers might be offered moments of controlled leisure—a brief escape from routine without any real challenge to the system. Tourism is another structured element of life, offering an illusion of freedom and choice without ever allowing true liberation. The terrorist, in contrast to the tourist, operates undercover. They enter the travel system similarly, but their actions are disruptive and destructive.

Tourists and terrorists are the last moving human bodies at the moment of writing this text. Anything else is things. And the soldier is replaced by remote-controlled drones.

Hiroki Azuma, after wondering about the tourist, starts to reflect about the concept of family. He writes: >The philosophy of the tourist must be supplemented by the philosophy of the family. The strategy of the postal multitude that travels to and fro between nation state and Empire, spreading misdelivery and compassion, must be supported by a new familial solidarity.¹²

Family resemblance is also a philosophical idea by Ludwig Wittgenstein. Categories or concepts might not have one defining feature but a collection of overlapping characteristics. Think of a family: some members might have similar hair color, others share a height, but no single feature defines everyone in the family.

Video is social. The Barbarian is never alone.

11 Peter Weibel, *Territorium and Technik*, Merve 1989.

12 Azuma 2022: 155.

LOG:: OUT

One two three

A little fool I want to be

Two three four

You can give me more

Five six seven

I don't want to wait for heaven

Nine ten eleven

Going back to seven

Seven eight nine

Kann denn das noch sein?

...

We need it's...

We love it's...

Excess

—YELLO¹

1 Yello. *You gotta say yes to another excess*. Lyrics by Boris Blank. 1983, <https://genius.com/Yello-you-gotta-say-yes-to-another-excess-lyrics>.

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Theory on Demand #57

Heaven's Delight: On The Pleasures of Audiovisual Practices

Author: Andreas Treske

Kokusuz, dokusuz ve ne vaat ettiği belirsiz küçük kübik yumuşak görüntüsü ile Türk lokumu gibi; ağzınıza attığınızda yumuşacık peltemsi bir temas, yutarken boğazınızı yakan bir tat ve anında tüm hücrelerinize yayılan şeker... Parmaklarınızda kalan hafif beyaz pudra şekeri artıkları... (Like Turkish delight, with its odorless, textureless and vaguely promising small cubic soft appearance; a soft, mushy touch when you put it in your mouth, a taste that burns your throat when you swallow, and sugar that spreads to all your cells instantly ... Light white powdered sugar residues left on your fingers ...)

A deep dive into the world of video and digital aesthetics recalling and exploring everything from the beauty of instability in video signals (that wonderful chaos when things glitch) to how we experience video in our daily lives (even cats watching TV!).

Andreas Treske's *Heavens Delight* is a collection of logs, notes and essays exploring the evolving nature of video and its impact on culture, perception, and technology. In an age of algorithmic automation and technological advancement, video's ability to convey meaning is as captivating as it can be fleeting, rendering video ever vital.

Andreas Treske is an author, and filmmaker living in Turkey. He graduated from the University of Television and Film, Munich, where he also taught film and video post-production. He teaches in the Department of Communication and Design at Bilkent University, Ankara, Turkey. In 2015 he published *Video Theory. Online Video Aesthetics or the Afterlife of Video.* with Transcript. In 2017 the book was translated to Russian. Since 2008 he has been involved in the Institute of Network Culture's Video Vortex network.

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